

# 1. A Physicist in the Suburb

As a young **physicist**(物理学家) living in a quiet **suburb**(市郊), I, **myself**(我自己), kept a deep **curiosity**(好奇心) about how the ordinary world works. Every morning I would **go**(去) **upstairs**(向楼上) to my small lab, switch on the **radio**(收音机), and study a **condenser**(冷凝器), watching the **current**(电流) flow and the way **conduction**(传导) and **induction**(就职) shaped each **particle**(粒子) of charge. The work was **challenging**(具有挑战性的), yet **tranquil**(平静的), and I **cherish**(爱护) it; I never **disclose**(透露) my methods carelessly. I would **polish**(磨光) the glass until it began to **glitter**(闪闪发光), take a **sample**(样品) of dust, and **locate**(查出) each **red**(红的) **flake**(薄片) and speck of **soot**(油烟) under the lens. My old dog would **wag**(摇) his tail and watch with me, as if he too felt the **itch**(痒) of inquiry. In **accordance**(一致) with an old habit, I kept a thick **volume**(容积) of notes, its pages an **abstraction**(抽象) of every **consequence**(结果) I could imagine. A **beetle**(甲虫) once crawled across my **passport**(护照) on the desk, and I, the grateful **recipient**(接受者) of so much quiet wonder, simply smiled. People in **retail**(零售) and **sociology**(社会学) might call such labor **irrelevant**(不相关的), but to me it felt **everlasting**(永久的) and **relevant**(有关的) to **existence**(存在) itself. I refused to be **disinclined**(不愿意的) or **snobbish**(势利的) about practical things; I had to **require**(需要) myself to keep an open **conscience**(良心). A neighbor, a **programmer**(项目) who once worked **offshore**(向海面吹的), would **invite**(邀请) me for tea, and we would **mention**(提及) the news: a debate at the **United Nations**(联合国), the **abolition**(废除) of an unfair tax, an **exclusive**(独占的) deal in **green**(绿色的) energy, and the **expulsion**(逐出) of a corrupt official whose **bloody**(流血的) schemes had begun to **stink**(臭的). **Provided**(假如) the weather held, I would walk down to a **triangle**(三角) of parkland near my **lodging**(寄宿), where a bronze **puppet**(木偶) show drew a crowd. I took an **oath**(誓言) to myself that I would never let **exorbitant**(过度的) ambition **mar**(弄坏) my calm. When a sudden **avalanche**(雪崩) of bad news arrived, I felt **perturbed**(烦躁不安的), but I would not go **mad**(发疯的). I tried to **taste**(品尝) each moment, to **pull**(拉) strength from small things, and to **commend**(称赞) the **graceful**(优美的) courage of friends. The **prince**(王子) of patience, my mentor used to say, is the person who can **multiply**(数) small efforts into a **maximum**(最大量) result. His **affirmation**(确定), met with **unanimous**(一致同意的) nods, was that a clear **conclusion**(结论) must **precede**(领先) any action. He warned that a single **token**(代价券) gesture, a **silly**(傻的) **bundle**(捆) of excuses, or a careless **tick**(滴答声) of the clock can **blow**(吹) away years of work. So I would **appreciate**(为...表示感激) the **upkeep**(维持) of habit, sit by the **grate**(壁炉), and let the warmth seep into my **skin**(皮), knowing the **resistance**(抵抗) of doubt would **ensue**(跟着发生) but never win. I wrote a **prescription**(药方) for myself: stay curious, stay kind. Even when **ill**(有病的), I disclosed this much: that **spiritual**(精神的) **operation**(运转), the daily **relay**(转播) of hope across the **silicon**(硅) age, is what keeps a **tough**(坚韧的) heart beating during a long **pregnancy**(怀孕) of ideas, and a **chap**(变粗糙) can ask no more.

## 2. The Adviser of Lowland Town

Supposing(假使) you ever visit the lowland(低地) town where I grew up, seek(寻找) out the old adviser(顾问) who once served the cabinet(内阁) of the regional council. He was a wise(有智慧的) practitioner(从业者) of public life, a man of rare virtue(德行), and he could numerate(数) every family living within the perimeter(周边) of the valley. He would speak respectfully(恭敬地) to each citizen, never trite(陈腐的), never proud, and he refused any abasement(身份低微) of his office. People said his judgment was precisely(精确地) balanced, like a fine differential(有差别的) gear, and that he could exonerate(昭雪) the innocent and restrain the guilty with equal calm. The town had known real adversity(逆境). A bomb(炸弹) scare one chilly(凉的) weekend(周末) had nearly crippled the local economy, and a long shortage(不足) of work left many jobless(失业的). The constabulary(警察的), stretched thin, leaned on him for recommendation(推荐) and guidance. He did not(不) panic; he simply built a clear guideline(方针), a numerical(数字的) plan that anyone could read in a book(书), and he would constantly(经常地) remind us, "Do not let fear reign(统治)." By analogy(类似), he said, a town is like a body: suppress one part and the whole will recede(后退). His underlying(含蓄的) belief was that good order is no mundane(世界的) achievement(完成) but a daily practice(练习). I remember the day a wealthy nominee(被提名的人) from downtown(在城市的商业区) arrived, hoping to manipulate(操纵) the vote and claim a kind of sovereignty(主权) over our affairs. He was charming(迷人的) on the surface, with a fragrant(香的) cologne and a purple(紫的) silk tie, yet wary(机警的) eyes. He tried to tug(用力拉) the council toward his obsession(迷住) with profit, hinting that he could afford(付得起) whatever he liked. The adviser, disposed(有倾向的) to fairness, was not impressed. He would not swear(郑重地说) an oath he could not keep, and he warned the man that greed afflicts a community like an overdose(配药量过多) afflicts a patient. "Your suggestion(建议) has nil(零) merit," he said, to the astonishment of the room. The nominee, embarrassed, soon left. That evening, over a pot of tea poured from an old teapot(茶壶), the adviser told me an aspect(样子) of his philosophy that I still cherish. Life, he explained, is heterogeneous(不同种类的) and variegated(杂色的); it cannot be reduced to one tie-up(扎好的东西) of interests. Some days are warm(温暖的) and others chilly; some are salty(咸的) with grief. He spoke of a friend whose fracture(断裂) of trust had never healed, and of a bridegroom(新郎) whose joy, though tolerable(可忍受的) to envy, was real. He believed every emotion(激动), even the embarrassing(令人尴尬的) ones, deserves a tolerable place. Then he showed me his diary, where each entry was a small display(展览) of honest thought, like an advertisement(广告) for decency. He told me to climb(攀登) steadily, to make a reservation(保留) in my heart for kindness, and to apply a clean dressing of lint(绷带用软麻布) to every wound. As the glacier(冰河) of years recedes, I think of him often. His example, met with promptly(敏捷地) given respect, taught me that to compete(比赛) well is to compete fairly, and that suppression(镇压) of the weak is the opposite(对面的) of strength. Even a grandchild(孙子) of his still keeps that lesson, spraying it forward like fresh water on dry ground, a breakthrough(军事突破) of memory that no adversity can erase. It would astonish(使惊讶) you how social intercourse(交流) and a simple exam(考试) of the books, especially(特别) under the law(法律), can restore balance(平衡). The adviser, awfully(令人畏惧的) tired, chose to delegate(委派...为代表) tasks rather than damn(该死vt) the staff or let stress afflict(使痛苦) and cripple(残疾人) morale. He cut his caffeine intake(入口), booked a massage(按摩), and avoided the rigid hierarchy(层次). Inevitably(不可避免地), with countable(可计算的) wins and a plastic(塑料) spray(水花) of optimism, the town recovered.

### 3. A Team Studies the Changing Beach

Our research **team**(小队) spent one bright **Saturday**(星期六) **morning**(早晨) on a windswept **beach**(海滩), studying the **environmental**(环境的) forces that shape the coast. The work was challenging, but the **satisfaction**(满足) was **tremendous**(极大的). We measured the **diameter**(直径) of eroded stones, charted the **dimension**(尺寸) and **texture**(质地) of the sand, and recorded the **fluctuation**(波动) of the tide **with**(跟...一起) **similar**(类似的) care to the way a **banker**(银行家) tracks money. Our **monitor**(班长) blinked on the **screen**(屏幕) as a **turbine**(汽轮机) offshore turned in the wind, its **power**(力) feeding the village nearby. **None**(没有任何人) of us was **idle**(懒散的). The **structure**(结构) of the cliff, **weary**(疲倦的) with age and **decrepit**(衰老的) in places, told a long story of **nature**(自然界)'s patience. A **patch**(补丁) of bright **fleece**(羊毛)-like moss clung to the **bronze**(青铜)-colored rock, and the **fur**(毛) of a curious seal glistened in the spray. I am similar in temperament to my colleagues: **rarely**(难得) **uninterested**(不感兴趣的), always eager to **comment**(评论) and seek the truth. We did not **quarrel**(争吵), though we did debate. One member, a seasoned **statistician**(统计员), advocated a cautious **prediction**(预言); he disliked any guess that lacked proof. Another, more **cynical**(愤世嫉俗的), made a sarcastic remark and seemed almost **hateful**(可恨的) of optimism, but his **firmness**(坚固) kept us honest. There was a **tacit**(默许的), **demonstrative**(说明的) trust between us, an **equivalence**(相等) of respect that no **establishment**(建立) could mandate. We knew our **employment**(雇用) depended on accuracy, so we sought to **procure**(取得) the most **efficient**(能胜任的) instruments money could buy. By noon the **boil**(沸腾) of activity had eased. We paused near an old **monument**(纪念碑), a stone **tablet**(碑) erected by an **Indian**(印度的) colony and an **African**(非洲的) trader who once met here to **forge**(锻工车间) a trade route. The history of this **outlet**(出口) to the sea is rich; ships once paid a heavy **fare**(车费) to anchor, and a single **seller**(卖者) could grow wealthy overnight. Now a scenic **villa**(别墅) stands where the forge once roared, and tourists arrive by ferry to **listen**(倾听) to the waves. I felt a **tasteful**(有滋味的) satisfaction in the contrast. We did not let the **cinema**(电影院) of the past distract us, yet it would be **regrettable**(可遗憾的) to ignore it. As an **individual**(个人的), I find that history and science **alternate**(交替的) in my mind like the tide. Our employer, a member of **parliament**(国会) with a famous **prejudice**(偏见) against waste, would not **veto**(否决) a **satisfactory**(令人满意的) report, but he had warned us that any **implicit**(暗示的) error could ruin the project. So we worked to **assimilate**(吸收) every fact, to fill each **bucket**(水桶) of data, and to **nail**(指甲) down conclusions firmly. The **pedal**(脚踏) of the survey cart squeaked as we pushed it along; my **forehead**(前额) was damp; my hands, scrubbed with shampoo that morning, were now gritty. Still, the **cosmopolitan**(全世界的) crowd of gulls overhead seemed to **cease**(停止) their cries in approval. By evening we walked the **lace**(鞋带) of the shoreline back toward **dinner**(正餐), weary but content, having watched **vapor**(汽) rise from the warm flats and a single crane wade through the marsh. The **division**(分) of labor had worked. A great power, I realized, lies not in any one tremendous discovery but in the steady, **greatly**(大大地) shared effort of a team that refuses to **disappoint**(失望) itself. **Suppose**(料想), after a **big**(大的) game of **badminton**(羽毛球), the team gathered for a **briefing**(简要情况) that felt almost like a **ritual**(典礼) or a **sermon**(布道). One **advocate**(倡导者) would **dislike**(不喜欢) the **seductive**(诱人的) but **ostensible**(可公开得) promises of easy profit; such talk could **exasperate**(激怒) anyone. They discussed a **paternity**(父权) case, a **pregnant**(怀孕的) pause in trade as the firm planned to **reexport**(再出口) goods, and even the **parking**(停放车辆) crisis, before each **encounter**(遭遇) ended in agreement.

## 4. A Risky Voyage to Scotland

It would be **no**(不是) exaggeration to say that my **journey**(旅行) to **Scotland**(苏格兰) was the most **risky**(有风险的) **trip**(旅行) of my life, yet I would not trade it for anything. I had read an entire **encyclopaedia**(百科全书) entry about the region, written in such **illegible**(字迹不清的) old **handwriting**(笔迹) that I nearly gave up; but a single **scenic**(风景如画的) **paragraph**(段) about its **barren**(贫瘠的) moors and ancient **empire**(帝国) of clans persuaded me to **move**(移动). I packed light: a **diary**(日记), a bottle of cheap **perfume**(香水), a **complimentary**(称赞的) guidebook the agency gave me **gratis**(免费的), and an **adequate**(充分的) supply of food. No **reader**(读者) could call me **studious**(勤学的), but I do my homework. The **voyage**(航海) began on a crowded **ferry**(渡口). The captain, a **civil**(公民的) man with a strong **jaw**(颌), gave us a brief and reassuring address. "There is no **menace**(威胁) today," he said, though **static**(静止的) crackled on the radio and a sudden squall made the deck **rotate**(旋转) beneath us. A **van**(有篷汽车) full of crates had to be lashed down with a **jack**(起重器) and rope so it would not slide into the **ditch**(排水沟) of the lower hold. I felt my **impulse**(冲动) to panic, but I would not **plead**(恳求) for an early return. As we sailed, the sea began to **sparkle**(闪光). A **crane**(起重机) lifted cargo on the far pier; gulls dove for **crisp**(脆的) scraps; and the spray on my skin was cold enough to **dazzle**(眩目) the senses. A fellow passenger, an **immigrant**(移民) from a distant empire, told me with an **incredulous**(表示怀疑的) **smile**(微笑) that he had once nearly drowned when a ferry sank, and he showed me, without spite, the **proof**(证据): a long scar where a **stake**(木桩) had nearly stabbed him. His story did not frighten me; it only sharpened my **zealous**(热心的) wish to see everything. He spoke of the **necessity**(必要性) of courage, and of the **capacity**(容量) of the human heart to recover. When at last we landed, the **porch**(门廊) of the little inn glowed warm against the **marsh**(沼泽地). A **sheriff**(郡长) with a **sarcastic**(讽刺的) wit checked our papers; a **bureaucracy**(官僚) of forms had to be edited and signed, and I had to **magnify**(放大) the tiny print with a lens to read it. The **price**(价格) of a room was **high**(高的), but the owner, eager to **guarantee**(保证) my comfort, gave me a free **pat**(轻拍) of butter and a slice of bread with my dinner, and promised the rate would not **rush**(冲) upward. That night, by candlelight, I wrote in my diary about the strange **snout**(猪嘴) of a wild boar I had glimpsed in the **brood**(同窝幼鸟) of trees, about the **cement**(水泥) walls of a ruined chapel, and about the **contemplation**(苦思冥想) that fills a traveler's mind at rest. I confess my **golf**(高尔夫球) clubs stayed in their bag the whole trip; there was simply too much to see. A **nuisance**(麻烦事) of midges plagued the **doorway**(门口), and the **running**(连续的) stream nearby never ceased its music. The static of worry faded. I learned that to magnify a small life with bold travel is no **false**(谬误的) promise but a real necessity, and that even a barren land can dazzle a willing heart. When the **fury**(狂怒) of the weather finally calmed and a **ghastly**(苍白的) fog lifted, I smiled, made one last **assessment**(估定) of my route, and began the long journey home. **Along**(向前) the road, the journey hit a **snag**(障碍). Our guide, once a **pupil**(瞳孔) of an old **conqueror**(征服者)'s tale, tried to **reassure**(使放心) us and **converse**(谈话) calmly, though his **nasal**(鼻的) voice carried an **uncomfortable**(不舒服的) edge. He would not **edit**(编辑) the truth or add **fluff**(软毛): the **arbitrary**(任性的) **bill**(账单) for the ferry was a **pitfall**(缺陷), a real **detriment**(损害) to **efficiency**(效率). To **persuade**(说服) the crowd, he raised an **outcry**(大声疾呼) against waste, explaining how **industrialized**(工业化的) **agriculture**(农业) could **distend**(扩大) budgets. The **implication**(含意) was clear, sharp as a **stab**(刺); even a **disabled**(残废的) cart on our **flank**(胁) felt the **hardness**(坚硬) of the climb. They agreed to **release**(释放) the funds, and added a small **suffix**(后缀) of thanks to the contract.

## 5. The Polar Charity Gala

The **presentation**(赠送) began at **eighty**(八十pron) seconds past eight, when the lights of the grand **showroom**(展室) clicked on and an **ensemble**(<法>全体) of musicians struck the first notes of the national **anthem**(圣歌). This was no ordinary night: it was a **voluntary**(自愿的) charity gala held to fight **poverty**(贫困) and **hunger**(饥饿), and every **member**(成员) of the committee had worked to make it **perfectly**(很) run. I will not **betray**(背叛) the names of our donors, but I can say their generosity was **unprecedented**(前所未有的). A famous **youth**(青年) choir sang in **harmony**(和谐) while a screen behind them showed a **polar**(两极的) landscape of ice, a lone **dove**(鸽子) circling above an **icy**(冰冷的) **grove**(林子) of **shrub**(灌木) and **berry**(浆果). The theme that year was "**thirst**(渴) for justice," and the **emancipation**(解放) of the poor from **misfortune**(不幸) was on everyone's mind. Our host had the **easy-going**(逍遥自在的) charm of a born performer. He asked the crowd, **bravely**(勇敢地), to dig deep. "It would be a shame," he said, "to **detach**(使分开) ourselves from those in **pain**(痛)."  
He wore a neat **vest**(背心) and angled his **body**(身体) toward the **back**(后面的ad) rows so no one felt ignored. Earlier that week we had to **minimize**(使减少到最少) costs; prices had begun to **skyrocket**(猛涨), and the **gap**(缺口) between our budget and our goal made my heart sink. I confess I felt the sting of doubt, the same **sight**(视力) of red numbers that can **discourage**(使泄气) any **earnest**(认真的) organizer. One sponsor, an **inept**(不适当的) and snobbish man, **scold**(责骂) us for our **methodology**(方法) and tried to **slander**(诽谤) the cause, claiming our **purity**(纯净) of motive was a sham. His **bias**(偏见) was clear. But the **testimony**(证据) of the families we had helped, and the sheer harmony of the room, defeated his cynicism. A young woman, once arrested unjustly and later freed when the real **bandit**(土匪) confessed, gave a speech that made the whole body of guests rise. She had every reason to **fret**(烦恼), yet she spoke without anger. "Do not let any single misfortune ruin your hope," she said. "In the **foreseeable**(可预知的) future, we can **bestow**(把...赠与) on one another the **better**(较好的ad) world we all deserve." Even the **murderer**(杀人犯) of joy could not **have**(有) stayed unmoved. By midnight the donations had multiplied. We had asked for a modest sum and received far more; the **cone**(锥体)-shaped collection jar overflowed, and a staggered line of guests waited to give. As the **escalator**(电动扶梯) carried the last visitors down past a wall of **clothing**(服装) donations, I felt no **malaise**(不舒服), only gratitude. The **character**(性格) of a community, I thought, is measured not by its wealth but by its willingness to share. We had not solved poverty in one night, but we had narrowed the gap. The **smoke**(烟) of the celebratory candles drifted up; someone smiled and said **sorry**(对不起) for crying. **Soon**(不久) the hall fell quiet, and I stood alone, perfectly content, watching the polar scene fade from the screen. I have to **ask**(问): what is the **scope**(范围) of a single show? The performance **itself**(它自己) could **stagger**(摇晃) you. One act mixed **gymnastics**(体操) and **boxing**(拳击); a dancer in a bright **skirt**(裙子) would **tilt**(倾斜) and balance on one **leg**(腿), graceful as a **lioness**(母狮子). A puppet shaped like a **sphinx**(希神) rose on a **periscope**(潜望镜)-like pole with a **click**(发出滴答声), while a paper **cock**(公鸡) crowed. Behind the scenes, the **air-conditioning**(空调) hummed, and a **coalition**(合并) of stagehands tried to **delete**(删除) every flaw and avoid **ineffectiveness**(低效率). There was no **illegal**(不合法的) trick, no **effluent**(发出的) dumped from the kitchen where they served **pie**(馅饼). Yet **turmoil**(骚动) nearly arrived: a sponsor's **resignation**(放弃), a late **notification**(通知), a **predisposition**(易患病的体质) to panic. They had to **commit**(犯), to **shear**(剪) away the fluff, to **fork**(叉) over more cash, to **cruise**(巡航) past the danger and not **dump**(垃圾站) the project. The crew could **arrest**(逮捕) the chaos, restore **digestion**(消化) of the schedule, and the **reproduction**(再生) of the act ran like clockwork. After a quick **shampoo**(洗发膏) of fresh ideas, they angled it from a new **angle**(角) and turned a likely **defeat**(击败n) into triumph.

## 6. The Electrician's Promising Investment

Let me **assure**(断言) **you**(你), the **making**(制造) of a small business is never **faultless**(无过失的) **work**(工作). My uncle, a **bespectacled**(带眼镜的) **electrician**(电学家) with a **love**(爱) of **order**(命令), decided to **lease**(租约) a workshop near a **foggy**(有雾的) **creek**(小川) and **sort**(分类) out a **promising**(有希望的) new venture. His **viewpoint**(观点) was **fundamental**(基础的) and simple: build something **dependable**(可依赖的), and the customers will come. He was no **coward**(胆小者), but neither was he reckless; he would **estimate**(估计) every **fee**(费), study each **indicator**(指示器), and refuse to **disregard**(不理) the smallest risk. A **confidential**(秘密的) adviser had told him the **investment**(投资) could yield a steady **dividend**(被除数), provided he kept his books in order. **Common**(普通的) sense, the adviser said, is the **principle**(原理) that should guide every decision, and **inversely**(相反地), greed will **topple**(倾倒) even the strongest firm. The **classification**(分类) of his tools filled an entire **household**(家庭) **bed**(床) of shelves: coils of **yarn**(纱)-like wire, a barometer, a humble **nut**(坚果)-and-**pipe**(管子) assortment, a **spotlight**(聚光灯), a **hook**(钩), and a heavy **log**(原木) he used as a doorstop. He worked **indoors**(在室内) during the cold months and **elsewhere**(在别处) when the weather allowed. One **nameless**(无名的) morning, an **elated**(兴高采烈的) customer rushed in, frightened that her **nuclear**(核心的)-powered home generator had failed. My uncle, ever **trustworthy**(可信赖的), did not flatter her or make **needless**(不需要的) **promise**(诺言); he simply rolled up his sleeves. The fault, he could **infer**(推论), was a corroded part where rust had begun to **erode**(侵蚀) the metal, leaving **slag**(矿渣) and a **foul**(恶臭的) smell. Some **misguided**(被误导的) rival might have charged a **gratuity**(赠物)-sized fortune, but he asked only a modest fee. "It would be a **shame**(羞耻)," he said, "to **torture**(拷打) an honest person with a padded bill." His common decency was his finest principle. As the work neared its **ending**(结尾), he explained each step, careful to **interpret**(解释) the technical terms so she would not feel like an alien in her own home. He showed her how to **decrease**(减小) waste, how a single **homogeneous**(同类的) batch of cable could **safeguard**(维护) the whole circuit, and how a tiny **modification**(缓和) could **revoke**(废除) years of inefficiency. The **quietness**(平静) of his manner reassured her. She left no longer **unlucky**(不幸的) but grateful, and she promised to tell the whole **locality**(地区). Business, he often said, is a kind of **fellowship**(交情); you **sell**(卖) trust before you sell anything else. He had no wish to be a **hero**(英雄) or a **politician**(政治家), no **monumental**(纪念碑式的) ambition; he simply wanted his **childhood**(幼年) dream of a steady trade to come true. When I asked whether he ever felt the pull to expand, to chase prestige and become **dependent**(依靠的) on bankers, he only laughed. "**Forward**(向前), yes," he said, "but slowly. A man who learns to read the indicator of his own contentment is rich enough." That, I think, is the truest principle of all. Consider a business as varied as a ship's **berth**(停泊处). Good **utilization**(利用) of every asset matters, from the **radial**(光线的) tires on the **jet**(喷气发动机)-black delivery van to the **visual**(看的) displays in the showroom. A **bony**(骨头的) old manager in a **mackintosh**(雨衣), who loved **gardening**(园艺) on weekends, wrote plain **prose**(散文), not **raucous**(沙哑的) **colloquial**(口语的) slogans. He kept **aspirin**(阿斯匹林) in his **pocket**(衣袋) for headaches, a tube of **cream**(乳脂) for his hands, and a **mythical**(神话的) calm that could **frighten**(使惊恐) rivals. He noted the **asymmetry**(不对称) in the market like a **tiger**(n . 虎) watching prey, sought the **shade**(荫) of caution, and treated each setback as an **exoneration**(免罪) rather than defeat, as if a healthy **gland**(解剖) of optimism fed a whole **regiment**(团) of staff.

## 7. A Freshman's Confession at Dawn

The **confession**(供认) came at **dawn**(黎明), when the **frosty**(霜的) light first touched the **snowbound**(被雪困住的) campus. A **freshman**(新人) named Theo, **formerly**(以前) a quiet boy from a **herd**(兽群) of country cousins, sat in the **dry**(干的), cold lecture hall and decided to **solve**(解决) the puzzle that had begun to **pester**(使烦恼) him. **Originally**(原来) he had wanted only **good**(好的) marks; now he wanted to **organize**(组织) his whole life. He was no **winner**(获胜者) yet, but he was **cautious**(小心的) and **modest**(谦虚的), and he refused to be **reckless**(鲁莽的). The **address**(住址) he gave that morning, **publicly**(公开地) and with a **low**(低), steady voice, was meant as a kind of **moral**(道德的) **debate**(争论) with himself. "I will not let **temporary**(暂时的) comfort cripple my future," he said. "I have a vocation to pursue." His **complaint**(抱怨), if you could call it that, was simple: too many of his classmates lived on **inexpensive**(花费不多的) habits and idle **excess**(超越), treating study as a **primitive**(原始的) chore rather than an **activity**(活动) of joy. He wanted a **cure**(治愈) for that **coldness**(寒冷). **Presumably**(假定地) the others thought him strange. One **motorist**(摩托车手) friend, a **cyclist**(自行车运动员) on weekends, asked him **independently**(独立地) whether he had gone mad. **Besides**(此外), the boy added, the **deterioration**(退化) of his sleep had begun to worry him. He would work past **midnight**(午夜), **suck**(吸) on cold coffee, and **rinse**(涮) his face to stay awake. A **comparative**(比较的) glance at his peers gave him no comfort. With **permission**(允许) from his temporary adviser, he adopted a new plan, a **quantitative**(量的) one, to **vary**(改变) his routine and to **enable**(使能够) real rest. He would not flatter himself with excuses. He learned to organize his notes, to confirm each fact, and to seek **confirmation**(证实) before acting. He found that a little **restriction**(限制), far from being a **torment**(剧烈痛苦), set him free. Besides his books, he kept a small **spade**(铁锹) for the campus garden, where he turned the **turf**(草根土) and planted seeds in the frosty soil; the green shoots, when they came, gave him a **kindness**(仁慈) of spirit no lecture could. He even built a **snowman**(雪人) one snowbound afternoon, laughing like a child, and the simple **flavour**(滋味) of that joy surprised him. He realized that to **emancipate**(解放) himself from fear, he had to act with **coherence**(凝聚性) and not let his **nest**(窝) of doubts congest his mind. His **leader**(领袖), a wise old teacher, did not scold or **accuse**(控告); she would **commentate**(评论) gently, never reckless with a young heart. "You cannot **purge**(净化) every fault at once," she told him. "**Inasmuch**(因为) as you keep trying, you will improve." Theo left the hall as the dawn brightened, no longer **unhappy**(不幸福的). He was not yet a **foreigner**(外国人) to doubt, but the **sickness**(疾病) of despair had begun to recede. The footsteps behind him were his own, steady and sure, and the **obtainable**(可得到的) future, once a distant dream, now seemed close enough to touch. Over a **long**(长的) **lunch**(午餐), the **deputy**(代表) and an **emigrant**(移居国外的人) banker discussed **capitalism**(资本主义) as a **pillar**(柱) of society. It would **perplex**(困惑) anyone how a **unilateral**(单方面) **statute**(法令) on **lending**(贷款) could **sweeten**(使变甜) or sour a **partnership**(伙伴关系). They refused to **adopt**(收养) a **dummy**(傀儡) policy or **misappropriate**(盗用) funds; that would be **pathological**(病理的), leaving only a **semblance**(外表) of order. **Off**(离开) the **congested**(拥挤的) street, near a **yacht**(小帆船) club, they read an **anthology**(诗选) of essays on **unemployment**(失业), **housework**(家务), and the urge to **incline**(斜坡) toward reform. A **cuckoo**(杜鹃) called; a **footstep**(脚步) echoed. One pulled a **stocking**(长袜) of coins from a **vacuum**(真空)-sealed box, noting how iron **oxide**(氧化物) had stained it, and added **reinforcement**(加强) to their plan.

## 8. The Ambassador's Mystery in Australia

The **mystery**(神秘) began **at**(以) a **chapel**(小礼拜堂) on the coast of **Australia**(澳大利亚), where a **Portuguese**(葡萄牙人) **ambassador**(大使) had moored his yacht for the night. He was an **affectionate**(充满感情的) man of great **prestige**(威信), devoted to his **vocation**(职业), and **doubtless**(无疑地) no coward; yet that evening a strange **malice**(恶意) seemed to **rein**(缰绳) in his usual calm. A **talkative**(罗嗦的) **mill**(磨坊主) from the nearby town, a **reputable**(声誉好的) but **coarse**(粗的) fellow, had told him a tale that no **barometer**(气压计) of reason could measure. Long ago, the miller said, an **alien**(外侨) **apparatus**(仪器) had washed ashore in this very **area**(面积), an **obstacle**(障碍) to every map and chart that **cartography**(绘图法) could draw. The ambassador, who would **prefer**(更喜欢), and indeed preferred, facts to rumor, did not **flatter**(阿谀) the story, but neither could he **erase**(擦掉) it from his mind. He decided to **submit**(服从) himself to the riddle. At midnight he walked the **marginal**(记在页边的) path along the shore, a **luminous**(发光的) moon above him, his **long-term**(长期的) doubts pressing like a **yoke**(牛轭) upon his shoulders. The **rage**(狂怒) of the sea had calmed; only a **soft**(软的) wind stirred. He found, half-buried, a **decorative**(装饰的) **code**(规则) carved into stone, its **variant**(不同的) symbols **overlapping**(相互重叠的) in a pattern no one alive could interpret. Was it a relic of some ancient **rivalry**(竞争), a yoke left by a forgotten **aggressor**(侵略者), or merely a sham? The **press**(压) would surely call it a **tornado**(旋风) of nonsense, but the ambassador felt the **destruction**(毁坏) of an old certainty. He knelt, **moderately**(适度地) careful, and brushed the moss away. **Nobody**(谁也不) was near. A **reptile**(爬行动物), perhaps a small lizard, darted past his hand and made him flinch. He thought of the marginal notes in his own diary, of the long **road**(路) of his career, of the prestige that might be ruined if he spoke too soon. The **chronology**(年代学) made no sense: the carving was older than any record in his **domain**(领域) of knowledge. He resolved to **allocate**(分配) his remaining days, however **affluent**(丰富的) or poor, to this single problem. A reputable scholar might **invalidate**(使无效) his theory; a **benevolent**(乐善好施的) one might confirm it. Either way, the matter was now **part**(部分) of him. As the night withered into morning, **exhausted**(精疲力竭的) but elated, he gathered a soft handful of sand into a **tub**(木盆) he had carried, took up a **shovel**(铁锹) from the yacht, and dug a **relative**(相对的) few feet into the soil. There, beneath a luminous layer of crystal, lay a second tablet, its surface coarse yet covered in a **glutinous**(粘性的) film. He saw at once that the two stones were a matched part, halves of a single record that someone had tried to **halve**(对分) and hide. The **implied**(暗含的) meaning struck him: this was no mere device, no decorative trifle, but a message meant to **propel**(推进) the curious toward a truth that powerful men had long suppressed. The ambassador, no longer **dangerous**(危险的) to himself with doubt, pressed the tablets together. He felt his heart **palpitate**(跳动). The mystery, at last, had begun to speak. Ask **yourself**(你自己) why some mysteries never **wither**(使枯萎). A **teacher**(教师), my **spouse**(配偶)'s old mentor, would **attend**(出席) every lecture, preferring a **sonnet**(十四行诗) to empty **rhetoric**(花言巧语的). The **bugbear**(怪物) of the age was disease: **poliomyelitis**(小儿麻痹症) and **malnutrition**(营养失调), which could **paralyse**(使麻痹) a child as surely as **sorrow**(悲哀). It was **inevitable**(不可避免的), he said, that someone **else**(其它) would solve it. He kept a **pad**(垫子) of notes, a **needle**(针) and thread, and a tin of **pilchard**(沙丁鱼) for the road. On the **twelfth**(第十二) of the **ultimo**(上月的) month, riding neither **pony**(小马) nor **motorcycle**(摩托车) but in **transit**(运输) by train, he reached the **junction**(交叉点) near the **moor**(使停泊). He would **lend**(借给) a hand to anyone, **gross**(粗俗的) profit or not, studying **Leninism**(列宁主义) with the **innocence**(清白) of a student, dipping a **solvent**(能偿还的) to clean an old **bill**(提单) document. The market was **bearish**(熊市的), but his faith was solvent. Years earlier he had judged a **contestant**(参赛者) in a poetry duel, awarding the prize to the one whose verse showed true innocence.

## 9. The Congressman and the Famine Relief

**Positively**(确定的), no one in the capital expected the young **congressman**(国会议员) to **pursue**(追赶) such an **ambition**(雄心). **We**(pron. 我们<) had watched him for a span of years, a **devoted**(献身于的) public servant whose **relationship**(关系) with the voters was built on **bravery**(勇敢) and plain honesty. When news of the **famine**(饥荒) reached **Russia**(俄罗斯) and beyond, the **disorder**(混乱) it created was immense; the **plight**(困境) of millions could **ruin**(毁灭) a whole generation. He was **sensitive**(敏感的) to their sorrow, and **definitely**(一定地) not **greedy**(贪吃的) for personal **sale**(出售) or **turnover**(营业额) of favors. **Maybe**(可能), he thought, he could **mobilize**(动员) the nation. He called a **technician**(技术人员) and an **athletic**(田径的) young **runner**(赛跑的人) to help him **connect**(连接) the scattered relief committees, then asked his **ancestor**(祖先)'s old **wagon**(运货马车) to be restored so it might **ride**(骑) again as a symbol. The **incidence**(落下的方式) of hunger was rising; the **output**(产量) of the farms had declined after a strange **fission**(裂开) of the soil's fertility, and the **circulation**(循环) of grain had nearly ceased. He would not **let**(让) the crisis **decline**(下降) into **genocide**(有计划的灭种和屠) by neglect. He refused to **misinterpret**(误解) the numbers, nor to **restrict**(限制) aid to the privileged few. "**Neither**(两者都不 pron) pride nor **property**(财产)," he said in a **lecture**(演讲), "should **handicap**(给予优者的不利条件) our response." He petitioned the **embassy**(大使馆) for help and sent a **citizen**(公民) delegation to **superintend**(主管) the docks. A **magnate**(大资本家), once bearish and **antiquated**(陈旧的) in his views, was moved to **facilitate**(使便利) the shipping of **sardine**(沙丁鱼) and other tinned goods; a banker agreed to **decentralize**(分散) the lending so that aid could reach every locality. The congressman's bravery seemed to **capitalize**(大写) on a **novelty**(新奇) of spirit the nation had forgotten. Critics tried to **tamper**(干预) with his **certification**(证明) and to **overthrow**(推翻) his committee; an ironical few called his **ideal**(完美的) a mere **imitation**(模仿) of older reforms. He conceded nothing. "**However**(然而) you interpret it," he told them, "this is not a **skirmish**(小冲突) over an **item**(条款) of policy. It is a **fight**(打) for **longevity**(长寿) itself." He moved to **restore**(恢复) order, to **create**(创造) a system that could **contain**(包含) the chaos, and to **improve**(改善) the lives of the runner and the **breadwinner**(养家活口的人) alike. He capitalized every chance. When at last the wagons rolled, the people did not **laugh**(笑); they wept and hugged one another. A child handed him a **bowl**(碗) and a single **cluster**(一串) of grain. The **voiceless**(无声的) had found a voice. The decline had stopped. As a **Roman**(古罗马人) proverb might say, the **cost**(成本) of doing nothing is the ruin of all. The congressman, **accessible**(可接近的) and **moderate**(适度的) to the end, pursued his ideal until the **booking**(定货) of every relief ship was confirmed and the **expiry**(逾期) of the crisis was finally in sight. His **adjective**(形容词)a for the day was simple: enough. To **avert**(转移) disaster, the citizens signed a **petition**(祈求). A famous **quotation**(引用), often misquoted, became their **lever**(杆): every **participant**(参加者) could **specialize**(专门研究) in one task. The **chatter**(喋喋不休) in the **limousine**(豪华轿车) turned serious; a careless **interpretation**(解释), a **backward**(向后的) step, could **rupture**(破裂) the fragile peace and **tangle**(缠结) the talks. A **billion**(十亿) small choices, like a **stroke**(击) of a pen, could **kill**(杀死) or save the plan. They would not charge like a **bull**(公牛); instead they shared a warm **hug**(紧抱), used every **device**(装置) of diplomacy, and refused to let the moment slip.

## 10. The Painter at the Mountain Shrine

Hi(嗨！喂！), the proverb(谚语) says that wit(智力) and patience attain(获得) what force cannot, and the good-looking(好看的) young painter(漆工) believed it with all his emotional(感情的) heart. He had a privileged(有特权的) childhood, yet he chose a hard path(小路) up the mountain to a mysterious(神秘的) shrine(神殿), hoping to discover(发现) the secret of an old riddle(谜) carved above its beam(梁). The landscape(风景) was vast: a span(一段时间) of latitude(纬度) where fog(雾气) rolled over the ocean(海洋) and daylight(日光) came softly(柔软地) through the mist. He would not let the cynic(愤世嫉俗者) in town ruin his hope(希望). "In spite(恶意) of every obstacle," he wrote in his diary, "I will resume(重新开始) the climb at dawn." He packed a handkerchief(手帕), a capsule(蒴果) of medicine from the drugstore(零食店), a ribbon(缎带) his mother gave him, and a crumb(面包屑) of toast(烤面包) wrapped in cloth. The trail was a thin wire(金属线) of stone across a fleshy(肉的) ridge. As he walked, he could query(询问) the silence and seem(好像) to hear a response(回答) from the rock itself. He had to concede(承认) that the journey might(力量) recompense(回报) him with nothing but a sham(假冒) of an answer. Yet the mature(使成熟) traveller knows that worth(价值a) is not always a purchase(买) one(一pron) can register(登记) at a shop. Combustion(燃烧) of dry brush warmed his camp; the diffuse(散播) glow of the fire painted the night. He felt no spite, no oppression(压迫) of doubt. A colonist(移民) family offered him potluck(家常便饭) hospitality(好客) and a cup(杯子) of warm fruit(水果) drink, and he raised a toast to their kindness. They were not privileged, but their welcome was overt(明显的) and generous, without the tyrannical(残暴的) airs of the wealthy. By morning his dismay(灰心丧气) had gone. He resolved to renew(更新) his quest. The path narrowed; loose gunpowder(黑色火药)-grey stones shifted underfoot. Then, near the shrine, he uncapped his paints and began. The light might have seemed scant(缺乏的), but his artistic(艺术的) vision was persuasive(说服者) and imaginative(想象的). He would not waive(放弃) the chance to capture this. He worked with the steady stroke of one who has waited long. When he finished, he stood blindfold(眼罩) to his own fatigue, and the explanation(解释) of the riddle came to him as a quiet thought: the consequently(结果) simple truth was that the mountain itself was the shrine. No hijacker(拦路抢劫者) of fame, no resentful(不满的) rival, no intransigent(非妥协性的) critic could take that from him. He was not the head(头) of any school, just one painter with a load(装) of canvas and a heart full of light. He let the fog lift. He had attained his answer. It is ironical(反讽的), almost a trifle(琐事), how a short(短的) inquiry(询问) can change everything. An entrepreneur(<法>企业家), no flabby(优柔寡断的性格) dreamer, refused to be the scapegoat(替罪羊) for a failed nomination(提名). He would uncap(打开) a bottle, enclose(把...围起来) a note, and never interrupt(中断) a guest. The lab measured temperature in Fahrenheit(华氏温度计), tested a hydrogen sulphide(化) sample at full saturation(饱和), and studied the componential(成分的) and constitutive(宪法的) parts of a new alloy, recording each subsequence(后果) with care. A sullen(绷着脸不高兴的) technician, doing a sampling(抽样) of the metal's innards(<口>内脏), traced a thin artery(动脉) of rust along the beam. Even the lord(上帝) of the estate, who kept a tame panda(熊猫) in mind as a symbol of calm, called it constitutive of progress, not a trifle.

## 11. Founding a Community Farm

In the **preface**(序言) to her business plan, the **founder**(创办人) of our **community**(同一地区的全体居) **farming**(农业) cooperative made one **sentiment**(情操) **paramount**(极为重要的): that **healthy**(健康的), **sanitary**(有关卫生的) food should be available to everyone at **rock-bottom**(最低) prices, never sold **wrongly**(错误地) or at an exorbitant markup. She had chosen to **launch**(使下水) the venture **beside**(在...旁边) an old **metro**(伦敦地下铁道) station, on a **stony**(多石的) plot whose poor **drainage**(排水) and **porous**(多孔渗水的) soil first seemed a **blockage**(封锁) to any harvest. Yet with **conscientious**(审慎正直的) work and a **flexible**(易弯曲的) **technique**(技术), the team began to **strengthen**(加强) the beds, **scrub**(擦洗) the rusted tools, and **assemble**(聚集) raised planters set at a regular **interval**(间隔的时间). A clever **design**(设计) for the irrigation helped them **unravel**(拆开) each early problem. The **custom**(习俗) in our community was to gather each dawn. At one such **gathering**(集会), a **courier**(送快信的人) arrived with a **consignment**(委托) of seedlings, a **parcel**(包裹) of tender greens, each **leaf**(叶子) still wet with dew. We were **glad**(高兴的). A local **agency**(代理商) offered **compensation**(补偿的款物) for any crop lost to frost, and a **dealer**(商人) of farm gear let us **reserve**(保存) a **multifunction**(多功能的) tractor, a **fixture**(固定装置) we could not afford outright. We even asked a vet to **vaccinate**(给...种牛痘) the goats that grazed the margin. The whole **scene**(景色) felt hopeful. **As yet**(至今) no pest did **appear**(出现), but we stayed watchful. We used a **thermometer**(温度计) to **probe**(医学探针) the greenhouse heat and would not **disallow**(不允许) any **clue**(线索) of disease; one **apparent**(明显的) sign of blight could **crumble**(弄碎) a season's yield. To **raise**(举起) morale, the founder would **tell**(告诉) a **brisk**(轻快的) story about how, against all odds and with **intent**(不能移的), the first farmers had **successfully**(成功地) built their fields, and she would not **blame**(责备) the soil. Her words did not **humiliate**(羞辱) the doubters; rather they helped **subdue**(使屈服) every **fearful**(可怕的) thought, and **thereby**(借以) put us at **ease**(减轻). We **post**(贴出) our notes online, a **ubiquitous**(到处存在的) practice now. A **demonstration**(示范) day drew a crowd: a **bride**(新娘) and groom on their way from a **graduation**(毕业), a man nursing **arthritis**(关节炎), even the **police**(警察) on patrol. My **mother-in-law**(岳母), who holds the garden in high **esteem**(尊重), brought **garlic**(蒜) bread and pressed a small **memento**(纪念品), a carved wooden **chord**(弦) ornament, into my **chest**(胸腔) pocket. Someone joked that we should **smuggle**(私运) a **spaceship**(宇宙飞船) in to till the back forty, since the field stretched nearly a **kilometer**(公里). Of course there were setbacks, a **ramification**(分枝) no one foresaw: a **tack**(平头打vt) puncturing a tyre, a sudden **blast**(一阵) of hail whose stinging **lash**(鞭子) struck the **elliptical**(椭圆的) pond, a **carpet**(地毯) of mud across the path. A **toothbrush**(牙刷) served, oddly, to clean the seed trays. **Economic**(经济学的) pressure was real, and the **secondary**(第二的) market gave us nearly **unlimited**(无限的) competition. But after an **interruption**(中断) for repairs, work resumed. In a quiet **prayer**(祈祷) of thanks, some whispered the name of **Jesus**(耶稣), we knew the **staple**(订书钉) harvest, and our **safety**(安全), were assured. **Practically**(几乎) every neighbor now visits; the rising **tide**(潮汐) of support was, in the end, **pretty**(相当) wonderful to see.

## 12. The Astronomical Committee

The **erection**(竖立) of the new observatory beside the **lagoon**(泻湖) was, by any measure, a **colossal**(巨大的) **task**(任务). The **same**(相同的pron) **administrative**(行政管理的) **committee**(委员会) that had once governed a small **monarchy**(君主政体) of stargazers now had to **execute**(实行) a vast **campaign**(战役), **essentially**(本质上) a **mission**(代表团) to map **Mars**(火星) and the **various**(各种各样的) bodies beyond. Their **representative**(代表), a **sociable**(友好的) woman who valued **punctuality**(准时) above almost all, would **lay**(放) out the **following**(下列的) plan **twice**(两次) for any newcomer, **while**(当...的时候) the **preceding**(在前的) director merely looked on with an **innocent**(无罪的), almost **toneless**(缺乏声调的) calm. **Although**(尽管) the budget figures were **astronomical**(天文学的), the **company**(公司) behind the project refused to **curtail**(截短) the science. They issued a **warranty**(书面担保书) on the **equipment**(设备) and, in **addition**(加), a clear **voucher**(收据) for every **shipment**(装船) that arrived. One **technical**(技术的) **glimmer**(闪烁) of hope came from an **inert**(无活动的) gas that, in various tests, would not **vanish**(消失) under heat. "We must **reconsider**(重新考虑), and **recycle**(使再循环) the old lenses," she said, glancing at the **algebra**(代数学) on the board, her **wrist**(腕) resting on a worn **thesaurus**(辞典). Her **surname**(姓), common in **England**(英格兰) and across **Africa**(非洲), was printed on a **banner**(旗) above the **square**(正方形的). The mission concerned more than mere data; it had to **accomplish**(完成) a **sense**(感官) of wonder, and to be representative of human reach. A **reportage**(报告文学) team, sworn to **allegiance**(忠贞), would **dramatize**(使戏剧化) the launch, though some feared the prose would prove **monotonous**(单调的). As the countdown began, a young typist wept, then quickly dried her **eye**(眼) and learned to **forget**(忘记) her nerves. She had practiced **shorthand**(速记) to record every word. The **mutual**(彼此的) respect among the crew was apparent. They did not **weep**(哭泣) again. When at last the rocket left the **graveyard**(墓地) of abandoned scaffolds, a colossal blast lit the **orange**(柑) sky, and the crowd, **fearless**(无畏的), raised a **final**(最终的) cheer that no **ultimatum**(最后通牒) could ever subdue. Engineers in the **hydroelectric**(水电的) station nearby felt the ground shudder. The **mass**(大量) of onlookers, their allegiance now beyond doubt, knew that this hour would **prophecy**(预言) a brighter age. Some, with a **quandary**(困惑) in their hearts, whispered a prayer. Yet the **contrive**(发明) of the chief planner, who had flicked aside every **delusion**(错觉), held firm. He would not **enact**(制定法律) a single rule he could not defend, nor would he **overhaul**(检查) a system that worked. A **flick**(快速的轻打) of his **thumb**(大拇指) on the panel, a glint of **porcelain**(瓷器) dials, and the mission was a triumph. There was, he admitted with a **sore**(疼痛的) throat and a tired **straw**(稻草) of a voice, no **shortcut**(近路) to the stars, no **dagger**(匕首) that could cut the long road short. **Detection**(察觉) of the signal proved the engineers **tolerant**(容忍的) of risk and fully **terminable**(可终止的) in their patience. From **Langkap**(冷甲) to the far north, **mole**(医)-sized antennas, lined like rows of **bamboo-shoot**(竹笋) in a **frying-pan**(煎锅)-bright field, tracked the craft. Even a humble mole on the hill seemed to watch. With a glad heart, **herself**(她自己) the proudest of all, she signed the final log. In the **twelve**(十二pron) months that followed, nothing bad would **happen**(发生) to dim the project's **value**(价格). The **teaching**(教学) team kept careful records **concerning**(关于) every result they could **obtain**(获得), and joy seemed to **overflow**(溢出) from the control room. Far from any **aggravation**(加重), the mood was one of pure delight.

## 13. Crossing the Atlantic

The **two**(二) of us set out **early**(早的) on a **brilliant**(光辉的) morning, our **destination**(目的地) a **singular**(非凡的) **island**(岛) far across the **Atlantic**(大西洋的). The **proposal**(提议) had seemed a **bargain**(契约) at first, an **affordable**(买得起的) adventure, but the **expense**(花费) soon grew, and a **needy**(贫穷的) budget left us tracking every **dollar**(美元). Our **slender**(细长的) boat, with one **oar**(桨) and a worn **amplifier**(放大器) for the radio, was no match for the **torrent**(激流) that would later **sweep**(扫) the deck. A **profitable**(有利可图的) venture, the dealer had called it, though his **disreputable**(声名狼藉的), **deceitful**(欺骗性的) grin should have warned us. He was an **insolvent**(无偿债能力的) **tinker**(做焊锅匠) who would **offend**(冒犯) anyone, an **unaccommodating**(不肯通融的) man whose every word seemed a piece of **propaganda**(宣传). We engaged him only out of **restraint**(抑制), fearing worse. By mid-ocean a **nightmare**(恶梦) began. A torrent of rain lashed the **bulky**(庞大的) hull; the boat seemed to **dive**(潜水), then **whirl**(使旋转), and I had to **choke**(闷塞) back a **shriek**(尖声喊叫). The **worst**(最坏) was a near **crash**(突然坠落) against a reef in the western **hemisphere**(半球) of the chart, where the **inaccessible**(达不到的) **north**(北) shore loomed like a **veil**(面纱) of mist, a **shroud**(遮蔽物) over the **unofficial**(非官方的) route no captain would **carve**(雕刻). My **methodical**(有方法的), conscientious companion, ever **influential**(有影响的) and brilliant in a crisis, drew on **empirical**(经验主义的) skill to steady us. **Somehow**(以某种方式) she could **withstand**(顶住) the swell, her **toe**(脚趾) braced, her face like **wool**(羊毛)-pale stone. We **must**(必须) endure, she said, and her singular calm did not crumble. I am **afraid**(害怕的) we strayed badly. The compass, our only **mirror**(镜子) of true direction, gave a **hideous**(骇人听闻的) reading, and a dive into the charts brought a **reduction**(减小) of hope. Still, we did not panic. To dive deeper into the math, she pulled a **quarterly**(季度的) almanac, ran the figures twice, and after careful **scrutiny**(细察) found the error. A **magnet**(磁体) near the dial had skewed everything. Once we moved it, the needle settled, and a torrent of relief swept over us. By dusk the storm **endures**(最终用户) no longer; the sweep of clear sky returned. We could already taste the **steak**(肉片) and **lamb**(小羊) the inhabitants of the island were said to roast. A **stewardess**(空中小姐) on a passing **French**(法国的) liner from **Portugal**(葡萄牙) waved; we waved back, **funny**(滑稽的) and giddy with survival. **Negotiation**(谈判) with the harbor pilot was brisk. We had **email**(电子邮件), but no signal; instead we relied on an **introductory**(介绍的) chart and the **syllabus**(课程提纲) of seamanship she had memorized. The **originality**(独创性) of her plan, an **apologetic**(道歉的) blend of **art**(艺术) and guesswork, somehow worked. As an **ambulance**(救护车) of gulls wheeled overhead, I felt the **stimulation**(刺激) of pure joy. We had unified our nerve. No **terrorism**(恐怖主义) of the sea, no **miniature**(缩小的模型) fear, could now **frustrate**(使灰心) us. A **mouse**(鼠) of doubt still gnawed, but our determination held. The **decoration**(装饰物) on the prow, a small carved swan, seemed to nod. **Crossing**(交叉) that crossing line of latitude, I knew this **affair**(事务) would mark us forever, a memory to **venerate**(崇敬), a story no **consideration**(需要考虑的事) of fatigue could ever erase. Back on the **outer**(外部的) dock, we did not **stray**(迷路) from our plan, nor did our courage **tumble**(跌倒). We would **engage**(雇用) no needless **confrontation**(面对) with the sea. A rough **sluice**(水闸) gate guarded the inner harbor; beyond it, a baker let **yeast**(酵母) rise for our welcome bread. To **distil**(蒸馏) one lesson from the voyage, and to **unify**(统一) our small crew, I would **call**(叫) us survivors. The harbor's loyal **clientele**(顾客), who **track**(行踪) every arriving ship, cheered as we tied up.

## 14. A Servant's Brave Year

Despite(不管) the cruel(残忍的) winter, the old servant(仆人) kept the manor running with thrifty(节俭的) care. In the pantry(食品柜) she would stew(炖vi) a thick(厚的) cargo(船货) of bread(面包), bone(骨) broth, and canned(罐装的) vegetables, ladling it from a battered frying foil(箔) into bowls warmed beside the fireplace. Her boldness(胆略) was noticeable(显而易见的), even awesome(可怕的), though she never sought to entertain(招待) the nobility(高贵) with idle talk. One operational(操作的) rule guided her: inspect(检查) everything twice. She would wipe(擦) each fixture, scrub the carriage(马车) wheels, and tabulate(把...制成表) the household money(货币) in a ledger no typist(打字员) could fault. The estate's deficit(空额) had grown vast(巨大的), a fatal(致命的) dumping(倾销) of debt, and the warden(典狱官) warned that creditworthiness(商誉) was now critical. A pragmatic(国事的) woman, she refused to panic(惊慌). The version(版本) of thrift she practiced was almost theoretical(理论的), yet it worked. Despite hostile(敌方的) neighbors and a regional(地区的) racism(种族主义) that made her position unpleasant(令人不快的), she stayed favorable(赞许的) in spirit, doggedly(顽固地) cheerful. When the young lord, sly(狡猾的) and reactionary(反动的), threatened to sack(麻袋) her, she did not bleed(流血) self-pity. She would invest(投资) her own meager allowance to underwrite(签在) repairs, even venture(风险投资) savings to buy a medium(媒介) grade of coal. A territorial(领土的) dispute with the next estate had reached deadlock; a hopeless(没有希望的) inconsistency in the old deeds made the boundary missing(漏掉的) from every map. One marvellous(奇异的) morning, while she swept the courtyard, a left-handed(左手的) clerk arrived by expressway(高速公路) with a telegram(电报). The bloc(为某种共同目的而) of lawyers had reached a verdict. To substantiate(证实) the family's claim, they needed the original decode(解码) of a coded letter hidden behind a loose bone of the chimney. She climbed up, a riotous(骚乱的) wind tugging her mantle(斗篷), and amplified her grip on a bolt(插销) as the ladder shook. The residue(残余) of soot made her cough; a ripple(涟漪) of dust rose like a whirlwind(旋风). With a dash(撞击) she pulled the paper free, then gave a triumphant shout(大声叫). The cyclic(轮转的) seasons of worry seemed to splash(溅水) away. The document, written in shorthand that read like a foreign epoch(新纪元), proved the land was theirs. No mischief(伤害), no filth(污秽) of rumor, could now stain the house. That night they watched a flickering video(电视) on a borrowed set, played chess(棋), and skated on the frozen pool(水池). The lord, his paranoia(心) eased, vowed to defend her against any awesome threat. She had shown, with quiet nobility, that one careful servant could not be dwarfed by fate. A racism-free, hopeful order took root. Even the hut(小屋) at the gate, where she had first slept in a sack on a bed of straw, now flew a small badge(徽章) of honor. She rented out a spare row(排) of cottages, turned a once-rusty estate profitable, and showed that boldness paired with thrift makes any winter survivable. To show(节目) the books, she would debit(借方) each expense and rent(租) receipt, attentive(注意的) to the last centigrade(摄氏温度计) of detail, never inconsistent(不一致的). Her maths(数学) was clean, with no ellipsis(省略) of any figure. As an inhabitant(居民) of fourteen(十四) winters in that house, she understood the importance(重要) of trust, and warmly(热烈地) she would amplify(放大) her praise of the staff rather than protest(抗议) their small faults. On the frozen pond the children would skate(溜冰), and the estate, once doomed, seemed to vanquish(征服) its debts.

## 15. The Archaeologist's Determination

The **director**(指导者) of the museum, a **watchful**(注意的) and conscientious woman, called the whole team **together**(共同) for an **essential**(本质) briefing **tonight**(在今晚). An **archaeologist**(考古学家) by training, she had spent her **little**(小) spare time studying a **posthumous**(死后的) **edition**(版本) of a **heretic**(异教徒) scholar's notes, a **circular**(圆的) argument that **other**(另外的) experts had long resented. Her **determination**(决定) never wavered. "We must not **delude**(迷惑) ourselves," she said, her **wooden**(木制的) pointer tapping a **global**(全世界的) map. "The dig in **Italy**(意大利) is **critical**(危急的), and the evidence so far is **invalid**(无效的) until we **revise**(修订) it." The **researcher**(调查者) beside her, **excited**(兴奋的) yet careful, agreed: they would **cooperate**(协作) and work together, not apart. He resolved to **extol**(赞美) the **buyer**(购买者) who had funded them, a **thankful**(感谢的) gesture, **instead**(代替) of dwelling on the **sadness**(悲痛) of past failures. **Away**(在远处) from the lecture, the **courtyard**(院子) was calm. A circular fountain caught the **laser**(激光)-bright moonlight, and the fragile, frail **blade**(刀刃) of a single reed trembled. The team's **inspiration**(灵感) came from a strange **hazard**(危险): a **bandage**(绷带) of **limited**(有限的) cloth, found wrapped around a **carbon**(碳)-dated bone, bore a **countersignature**(副署) and a **forensic**(法院的) mark that **subsequently**(其后) changed everything. To the untrained eye it looked like mere decoration, but its **fiber**(纤维) told another story. **Constituent**(有选举权的) threads, when insulated under glass and not allowed to **dissipate**(消散), revealed a hidden **brand**(商标). The other clue was a **slit**(狭长的切口) in a wooden chest, sealed with a sanitary **postal**(邮政的) **stamp**(邮票) from a long-dead empire. "This is no delusion," the director said. "**Hereafter**(此后) we treat every **flesh**(肉)-and-blood detail as evidence." One assistant, prone to **flirt**(忽然弹出) and to **drowse**(困) during long sessions, suddenly grew watchful. He had nearly closed the file, mistaken about its value. Now he saw the **eradication**(根除) of doubt within reach. An **accusation**(控告) of fraud, once leveled at the heretic, could finally be negated; the man's **reminiscence**(回想), written in a **frightening**(令人害怕的), **outrageous**(残暴的) tone, was in **retrospect**(回顾) a record of truth, not a **murder**(谋杀) of facts. The team felt a **happiness**(幸福) **close**(关) to determination itself. They would not **resent**(对...表示忿恨) the long nights. To **mislead**(把...带错路) the public, even by a fraction, would be a sin; to **draw**(拉) the right conclusion was their essential duty. As the **total**(总数) picture emerged, the director gave a hearty, warmly approving nod. Her **mother**(母亲), an invalid in a distant **infirmary**(医院), had once told her that patience extols the patient. The **retell**(再讲) of this discovery, she knew, would become an excited, brand-new chapter. No **assassinator**(暗杀者) of reputations, no **disloyalty**(不忠), could now undo it. The frightening **dear**(昂贵的) cost of years had bought a posthumous justice, and that, she felt, was a blessing worth every wakeful hour. After the **funeral**(丧葬) of the old scholar, the museum's **bookkeeper**(簿记员), a man **conversant**(精通的) with every ledger, refused to **waver**(摇摆). He would not **flip**(掷) through the files carelessly, nor **abuse**(滥用) the archive. In **view**(视野) of the find, the team would **reap**(收割) real reward, **warranted**(担保的) by the evidence. No **partisan**(游击队) **attack**(攻击), no political **vent**(通风孔), could **induce**() them to **amalgamate**(使与汞混合) truth with rumor. A **choral**(合唱队的) group sang at the **fourth**(第四) memorial; outside, a smith would **hammer**(铁锤) a bright **ingot**(冶), and a **pollutant**(污染物质) haze hung in the air. The director's **daughter**(女儿), her **nose**(鼻子) pressed to the glass case, took up archaeology as more than a **pastime**(消遣). Workers would **insulate**(使绝缘) the relics in a sealed **shop**(商店) room, safe from harm.

## 16. A Doctor in the Volcanic Town

The(这个) new nurse(护士) arrived in an urban(城市的) district shadowed by a volcanic(火山的) cape(海角), where a single dwarf(矮子) pine clung to the harsh(粗糙的) slope. Her assistant(帮助的), a shoemaker(鞋匠)'s son turned medical helper, followed her through the season(季)'s first storm. Their action(行动) that day would mark(痕迹) them both. A boy had begun to vomit(呕吐) and his thyroid(甲状腺) felt swollen; an antibiotic(抗生素) was their only feasible(可行的) weapon against the infection, yet the local supply was a mess(凌乱状态). Lack(缺乏) of clean water made every task harsh. The doctor, an eloquent(雄辩的) and pure(纯的)-hearted woman, refused to neglect(忽视) a single patient. "To eradicate(根除) this disease, we must accelerate(加速)," she said, and her verbal(言语的) orders were conclusive(结束的). She would not succumb(屈服) to panic. Inside the shanty(简陋小屋) clinic, a broom(扫帚) leaned by the bottle(瓶v)-lined shelf; a diesel(柴油发动机) generator coughed, its irregular(不规则的) hum a small comfort. She wiped a yellow(黄的) stain of lime(石灰) from the table, set a salad(色拉) bowl aside, and reached for the bleach(漂白剂) to keep the room sanitary. A repetition(重复) of careful steps, she knew, was the only cure for chaos. The truth(真实) was plain: deficiency(缺乏) of supplies could be fatal. Yet she would not let violence(猛烈) or despair oppress(压迫) her team. When a man clutched his chest and screamed, she did not wake(醒来) in fright; she acted. Her cunning(狡猾), in the best sense, was practical. She used a wrench(猛扭) to fix the broken clutch(抓住) of an old motor, configuration(构造) by configuration, so the fridge could run and the antibiotic stay cold. Recreation(娱乐) was a luxury here. A picnic(野餐), a game of chess, a publication(出版物) to recite(背诵) by the fire — such comfortable(舒适的) pleasures belonged to another life. Still, the team found a delightful(令人高兴的), even comfortable rhythm. The shoemaker's son, once unwilling(不愿意的), grew bold. "This is my role(角色)," he said, and he meant it. They worked to expansion(扩张), training five(五pron) then thirteen(十三pron) local volunteers, each given a badge that bore a small graph(图表) of progress. A socialist(社会主义的) council, eager to follow(跟随) the new keeping(一致) of records, sent a delegation(代表团) by railway(铁路). The doctor's speciality(特性) was not glamour but repetition done right. She squeezed every drop(滴) from a fraught(充满) budget; reimbursement(偿还), she joked, would arrive after the next eruption. One night a tyrant(暴君) rumor spread — that the clinic would discontinue(中断) — but it proved false. The nurse, harsh only with carelessness, made the truth follow her words. By the dry season's end the disease was in retreat, and the small mouth(口) of the cape, once a place of fester(脓疮) and harm, was a haven of health. "We did not eradicate fear," she told the assembled crowd, smiling at her own slip of the tongue, "but we did eradicate the worst of the sickness." The pellet(小球) of medicine, the shoe(鞋) of a walking patient, the wake of every recovered child — all of it, she said, was worth more than any gramophone(留声机) song or salad supper. Truth, harsh and pure, had won. In an essay(文章) she later wrote, the nurse called neglect a kind of sin(罪), a fetter(常用复) on any healer. She described how an orthopedic(医) case nearly slipped into delirium(精神狂乱), how a child's scream(尖声叫) pierced the night, and how she had to squeeze(挤) past panic and guard(保卫) her calm. A Moslem(穆斯林) elder with a grey beard(胡须), her son-in-law(女婿)'s mentor, helped her safely(安全地) store disposable(可任意使用的) gloves. Regionalization(区域化) of the clinics, an arboreal(树的) network spreading like branches, let aid reach far. No scum(浮渣) of doubt could ruffle(滋扰) her resolve. At dusk a pyre(火葬用的柴堆) of old crates burned, its embers a twinkle(闪烁) against the dark; even the subjunctive(虚拟的) 'if only' lost its sting, and hope, like a tentacle(触须), reached toward tomorrow.

## 17. The Moon Mission Rehearsal

The **presence**(出席) of the whole crew was required before the **lunar**(月的) rehearsal could begin. Mission control had chosen to **automate**(使自动化) much of the launch sequence, yet a human hand would still **steer**(驾驶) the craft at the critical moment. The pilot, **pale**(苍白的) with fatigue, adjusted her **posture**(姿势) in the seat and felt a **tremble**(发抖) run through the hull as the engines built **thrust**(猛推). "Stay **accurate**(正确无误的)," the flight director said, his voice **telling**(有效的) and calm. "One error could **negate**(否定) a year of work." An **array**(展示) of screens glowed **nearby**(附近的ad); **on**(连接上prep) each, a **linear**(线的) graph traced the rocket's **position**(位置). The **simulate**(假装) program would **stimulate**(刺激) every fault the engineers could imagine, from a **toxic**(有毒的) fuel leak to a **collide**(碰撞) warning when two objects drew near in orbit. Nobody wanted a **scandal**(冒犯或引起反感的), and nobody wanted to **perish**(死亡). The **impetus**(推动力) for this mission had begun with a single **vision**(视力): to **place**(地方) a small array of sensors on the **virgin**(处女a) surface of a distant crater. Critics called the budget **exaggeration**(夸张), an **ostentation**(卖弄) of national pride, but **approval**(批准) had come at last after a long **pending**(未决的) review. The team refused to let any flaw go unaddressed; they would **rectify**(纠正) each one, **thoroughly**(充分地), before the real flight. In the pause, the pilot let her mind **jog**(轻推) back to her childhood. She would **slumber**(睡眠) under a **quilt**(被子) while her father, a **sympathetic**(同情的) man, told her of caravans crossing the desert, of a **tuck**(缝褶) of stars near the **shore**(海滨), of the lunar light that made the **pepper**(胡椒粉) plants in their garden gleam. He had a **counterfeit**(赝品) pocket watch, bought cheap, yet to her it was a treasure. He would **alight**(落下) from his old **motorcar**(汽车), **wail**(悲叹) a funny tune, and tuck her in. That **tendency**(趋向) to dream had steered her whole life. Now, on the simulator, an alarm cried out. A **frail**(虚弱的) line on the screen turned red — an **eruption**(喷发) of pressure in tank six. Her **refusal**(拒绝) to panic saved the run. She did not waver. With a quick thrust of the control stick she corrected the array, and the linear path settled. The director gave a slow nod of approval. "**Accomplishment**(成就)," he said, "is mostly the refusal to quit." Outside, near a **flood**(洪水)-control channel by the shore, an **athlete**(体育家) jogged past, unaware of the drama within. A **maid**(少女) swept the steps of the old **telegraph**(电报机) office; a **roller**(滚柱) of fresh paint dried on a nearby wall. The world went on, **weak**(虚弱的) to the wonders overhead. But inside the dome, the crew felt the **irony**(反话): to reach the cold and **additional**(额外的) silence of space, they had to master every **inconvenient**(不方便的) detail on the ground. "**Enough**(足够的n) for tonight," the director said. "We have a clearer position now." The **conversion**(转变) from fear to confidence was nearly complete. As the lights dimmed, the pilot paused, intent, and let one private prayer rise. The lunar dream, once a frail **puzzle**(难题), now felt feasible. A **pair**(一对) of technicians shut the hatch, and the simulated ship went dark, its vision banked for another day. With some **perplexity**(困惑混乱), the crew gripped the rails **tightly**(紧地), unwilling to let fear **perturb**(使不安) them. To **shorten**(弄短) the wait, the director told a **strategic**(战略的) joke about a **fridge**(电冰箱) full of **grape**(葡萄) juice and a single cold **shot**(开枪) of soda. It was a **blessing**(祝福) to laugh. **Temporal**(时间的) worries would **deplete**(耗尽) anyone; they had to **make**(来源) peace with delay. A **note**(笔记) on the wall, printed with a **stencil**(复写纸), listed the **aerodynamics**(空气动力学) drills and the **elimination**(消灭) of each fault. Outside, near a road of fresh **bitumen**(沥青), an **artillery**(炮的总称) museum stood like a **haven**(港口); a **caravan**(车队) of trucks passed, marked **ex**(在交货) works for an overseas **importer**(进口商). One could **surmise**(猜想), even without a course in **botany**(植物学), that the team's quiet **idiosyncrasy**(特质) was patience. The agency would **indemnify**(赔偿) any loss and would not **persecute**(迫害) a single honest error. A small daily **allowance**(津贴), and the promise to **promote**(开放) the steady ones, kept spirits high. **Unable**(不能的) to sleep, the pilot watched an old **movie**(电影) about **forty**(四十pron) pioneers, and felt the **heat**(热) of ambition return.

## 18. The Thinker's Last Year

In the **last**(最后的) **year**(年) of his **lifetime**(一生), the old **thinker**(思想家), an **upright**(垂直的) and **humane**(人慈的) man, settled into a quiet residence near a field where a **plough**(犁) still turned the earth. His **health**(健康) was failing, and a **profound**(深的) **anxiety**(忧虑), almost a **jealousy**(妒忌) of younger minds, would sometimes **madden**(发狂) him. Yet he taught to the very end, **since**(自从conj) teaching gave him **pleasure**(愉快) that **nothing**(没有东西) else could match. " **Everybody**(每人) must **defend**(防守) the **liberty**(自由) to think," he would say, gazing through the window at a **swan**(天鹅vi) on the pond, a **horse**(马) at the fence, a **bird**(鸟) in the **granary**(谷仓) eaves. His **style**(风格) of speech was **heartly**(衷心的) and **genuine**(真正的), never **plausible**(似是而非的) nonsense dressed as wisdom. Each **session**(一段时间), he would **dispense**(分配) one idea, **perfect**(完善的) in its **symmetry**(对称), and let his students **sharpen**(削尖) it. He had no **weapon**(武器) but reason; **revenge**(报仇) and **political**(政治的) faction held nothing for him. He spoke of an **episode**(一系列事件中的一) from his youth, when a cruel **accident**(意外遭遇) had nearly killed him. A **craft**(工艺) he sailed had struck **gravel**(沙砾) near the shore, and only the genuine courage of a fellow passenger had saved him. "Such(这样的) things," he said, "**teach**(教) you that **nowhere**(什么地方都没有) is safe, and that we hold our **possession**(所有) of life on loan." The memory still made him **gaze**(凝视) into the **fireplace**(壁炉), **evidently**(明显地) moved. His **ardent**(热情的) students would not let his thought perish. They **consume**(消耗) his every word, eager to obtain a **manuscript**() he had long postponed publishing. An **Australian**(澳大利亚的) scholar arrived to **appoint**(任命) herself his editor; **respectively**(各自地), others took on the index, the notes, the **specification**(载明) of each footnote. The **likelihood**(可能性) of finishing in time was small, but they refused to be **mistaken**(搞错了的) about their duty. The thinker, **shrewd**(敏锐的) to the last, would **tread**(踩) carefully around any **flaw**(瑕疵) in his old logic. "Do not **segregate**(隔离) the heart from the mind," he warned. "To **exterminate**(消除) feeling is to ruin thought." He had once seen a **colony**(殖民地) of swans, white against a grey sky, and the marvellous sight had become a private weapon against despair. Now, in his **rusty**(生锈的) old age, he returned to it often. One **six**(六pron)-line poem he had written, **fluorescent**(荧光的) in its clarity, spoke of a **god**(上帝) of small mercies and of the **sacrifice**(献祭) that any worthy life demands. He would not boast of it. As October cooled the air, an **actor**(男演员) friend came to read the verse aloud, and a **withdrawal**(撤退) of sorrow seemed to follow. The thinker felt, for once, no **inconvenience**(不便), no **commonsense**(有常识的) fear. He had done his work **satisfactorily**(圆满地), **actively**(积极地), and with **merchandise**(商品) of the soul that no **liquor**(酒) or rusty grief could spoil. "I have nothing left to prove," he said, his liberty intact. Outside, the swan swam on; the bird sang; and the old man, content at last, watched the year turn. His **neighbor**(邻居), a practical farmer, once joked that it was **ludicrous**(可笑的) to **fling**(掷) **pesticide**(杀虫剂) on a healthy crop; **prevention**(预防), he said, was **exactly**(确切地) the better path. The **outturn**(卸货情况) of the harvest, recorded **module**(组件) by module on a sheet of **cardboard**(硬纸板), exceeded every estimate. As **chairman**(主席) of the local **organization**(组织), the thinker had an **obligation**(义务) he would never **postpone**(推迟): to teach grammar, even the humble **transitive**(及物的) verb, to the village children. They would **swim**(游泳) in summer, play **volleyball**(排球), go **camping**(野营), and chop **onion**(洋葱) for the campfire stew. When a **tyre**(轮胎) went flat or a **leakage**(漏) of rain broke the **deadlock**(死锁) of a dull afternoon, he simply smiled.

## 19. The Announcer's Resolution

When the radio **announcer**(宣告者) first took the job, **finance**(财政) was the last thing on his mind. He had been a **careful**(小心的), **skillful**(灵巧的) young **fellow**(人) with **much**(多的) **courage**(勇气) but little money, and his only **practicable**(可实行的) plan was to **please**(请) the public and hope for the best. **Aboard**(在船上) a ferry one **October**(十月) morning, **age**(年龄) **eight**(八) in spirit if not in years, he had decided to become a voice that the nation would trust. "**Necessarily**(必然)," he told a fellow passenger, "I must speak **accurately**(准确地), or I am nothing." That **resolution**(坚决), **laudable**(值得赞美的) and firm, never wavered. **Except**(除...之外) for one **absence**(缺乏) caused by **hepatitis**(医), he had not missed a broadcast in eight years. His **routine**(例行公事) was strict: he would arrive early, **list**(表) the headlines, and **separately**(分离地) rehearse each **summary**(概括的) aloud. He refused to be **arrogant**(傲慢的); arrogance, he believed, was an **ugly**(丑陋的) **streak**(纹理) that could **drown**(淹死) a man's better self. **Regarding**(关于) the news itself, he tried to comprehend it deeply before he spoke. A story about **official**(官员) **bribery**(贿赂), a **hostage**(人质) crisis, the **prosecute**(起诉) of a **snob**(势利小人) who had tried to **steal**(偷) public funds, the **monstrous**(可怕的) **evolution**(演变) of a scandal at the **aquarium**(养鱼池) board: each of these he treated with equal care. He would not let a **triumphant**(得胜的) tone creep in, nor would he **smash**(打碎) a reputation **lightly**(轻轻地). One evening, a colleague tried to **tantalize**(逗弄) him with a rumor about a **wholesaler**(批发商) who, it was said, would finance a corrupt campaign. "**Alas**(唉)," the announcer said, "I cannot **air**(空气) what I cannot prove. The **disappearance**(消失) of one fact can mislead a whole nation." He kept a small list of principles taped above his **terminal**(晚期的), written in **straight**(直的), careful lines. The **software**(软件) that ran the studio sometimes failed, and on those nights he would grope for a backup, refusing to drown the broadcast in dead air. He had studied **biology**(生物学) and **geometry**(几何学) at school, and a little of the **temperate**(有节制的) logic of those subjects stayed with him; he liked things that **correspond**(符合) to reason. When the **petrol**(汽油) shortage struck and prices began to **bob**(上下或来回的动) upward, he reported it without panic, separating real **distribution**(分发) problems from **jumble**(混杂) and rumor. His **lovely**(可爱的), refined manner made even bad news bearable. People said his voice could **surround**(包围) a frightened city like a **refuge**(避难处). He never sought to **horrify**(使恐惧), never let a **howl**(嚎叫) of outrage into his tone. In time he was offered a promotion to the central desk, and though the **suspense**(不确定) of the decision kept him awake, he accepted with a careful, **indirectly**(间接地) grateful nod to his old mentor, the **mister**(先生) who had first taught him to speak. "You did not necessarily teach me facts," he wrote in a letter. "You taught me to **arouse**(激发) trust, and to keep it." He sealed the note, asked for a **receipt**(收到), and posted it that very day. Years later, near a quiet **tomb**(坟) on a hill, he would **recline**(放置) and recall that the whole long enterprise had begun with one boy's stubborn refusal to lie. He refused to **hound**(猎狗) a source **piecemeal**(粉碎); instead he would **enquire**(询问) **closely**(紧密地), **decipher**(译解) every **decimal**(十进法的) of a budget, and seek the **concurrence**(合作) of two editors before air. Low **morale**(士气) could **affect**(影响) a whole newsroom, so he fed his team good **nourishment**(食物) and humor to prevent any **relapse**(复发) into cynicism. A touch of **refinement**(精炼) marked his prose; he would never **suspend**(吊) his standards. He loved the **scent**(气味) of fresh ink. After a **reception**(招待会) one night, he wrote a **caption**(报纸文章的标题) for a photo of his **fiance**(未婚夫) beside a wall of white **gypsum**(矿), lit by soft **light**(明亮的). From the **occidental**(西方的) desk to a long **trek**(牛拉车) across the country, he **cast**(投) aside the fear of **failure**(失败). '**Ditto**(同上),' his editor would say to every careful choice, and the young man took flight under his mentor's **wing**(翅).

## 20. Consensus at the Renewable Energy Guild

After(在...以后) months of debate, the consensus(一致同意) inside(里面的ad) the central(中心的) guild(行会) was that the nation(民族) could no longer waste(浪费a) its resources. The custodian(管理人) of the old building, a calm(静的n) man who had worked there alone(单独的) for years, slipped on his earphone(耳机) and listened to the chairman of the renewable(可持续的) energy committee speak. "This(这a)," the chairman said, jumping straight to the point, "is purely(纯粹地) a question of survival. Here(在这里), in this very location(位置), we will either thrive(繁荣) or fade." Everyone leaned inside to hear. The plan was generic(生物) in outline but precise in detail. On each storey(房屋的一层) of the building, redundant(多余的) heating(加热) systems would be replaced; a smart program(节目) would filter(过滤器) demand and cut the mileage(里程) that delivery trucks logged every successive(接连的) day. A columnist(专栏作家) who wrote for a major channel(海峡) had called the scheme inalienable(不能让与的) to the city's future, and few wished to impede(阻止) it. The custodian, listening from the back, felt a strange zeal(热心) rise in him. He had spent his lifetime watching waste pile up, and now, actually(实际上), change seemed to loom(隐隐呈现) near. "We hereby(以此) declare," the chairman read from the manifesto(宣言), "that dependability(可依赖性) matters more than show." There was an occasional(偶然的) cough, a wink(眨眼) between two engineers, the rotary(旋转的) hum of an old fan. A graphic(绘画似的) on the screen, almost like a moth(蛾) circling a lantern(灯), displayed the accumulative(积累的) savings. Insofar(在范围内) as the math held, the limitation(限制) was no longer technical but political. A faction(派别) loyal to the old grocer(食品商)-merchants resisted; arrogance(傲慢) and arrogance alone, the chairman thought, kept them from agreeing. But the merciful(仁慈的) truth was that even they would benefit. After the vote, enrolment(登记) in the new training sessions jumped. A registered(登记的) nurse from the hospital(医院) nearby spoke about disease(疾病) and how a polluted river could trample(踩) public health; a Frenchman(法国人) who ran the lubrication(润滑) depot promised cleaner oil; a pianist(钢琴家) offered to play at the launch to motivate(促动) the crowd. The diaphragm(解) of the old ventilation system was repaired, the bald(秃头的) patch of rust on the bridge(桥) railing was scraped, and a derelict(被抛弃了的) shed(棚) behind the residence(居住) was cleared. No one would pollute(弄脏) the channel again, they agreed, nor remit(汇款) the duty to future generations. "We must not grope(暗中摸索) in the dark," the chairman said, his cell(细胞) phone buzzing with messages. "A succinct(简洁的) plan, repetitive(重复的) in its discipline, will carry us southward(向南) toward warmer markets and account(账目) for every cent." The custodian smiled. He thought of a white(白色的) peacock(孔雀) he had once seen, its fragrance(香味) of pride, its arrogance; and he thought, too, of how a single cell of effort, multiplied across a nation, could let an intellectual(智力的) dream finally arise(出现). As the meeting closed, a pleasant(令人愉快的vt) calm settled over the room. The fraction(碎片) of doubters had shrunk; the bookshelf(书架) of old excuses was finally being emptied. After all the noise, the slowdown(放慢) of waste had truly begun. A retired colonel(上校), married(已婚的) for decades, rose to comprehend(理解) the plan, refusing to kneel(跪) to old inertia(不活动). He would not boast(自夸), yet he made one jump(跳跃) of faith and backed the vote. A plumber(管子工) checked the pipes' thickness(厚); a valve turned anticlockwise(逆时针的) sealed the last leak. There would be no dismissal(解散) of staff, only new work. As a faithful listener(听者) to every meeting, he treated the reform not as a game(游戏) but as a duty, and even joked that the cafeteria's cheese(干酪) would taste sweeter now.

## 21. Return to the Scottish Winery

Last **September**(九月), on the **anniversary**(周年纪念) of my grandfather's death, I made a **deep**(深的) and **rather**(相当) personal **ascent**(上升) along the **Scottish**(苏格兰的) **coast**(海岸) to visit the **winery**(酿酒厂) he once owned. **According**(按照) to family **doctrine**(教条), **faith**(信任) and hard work could **offset**(抵消) any **debt**(债), and **whenever**(无论何时) the **climate**(气候) turned **humid**(湿的) I would remember his **idiomatic**(习语的) sayings. He was a **craftsman**(手艺人) of **permanent**(永久的) reputation, a man of fine **workmanship**(工艺) whose **authority**(权力) no one dared **infringe**(违反).

The morning was **bright**(明亮的), the air **intermittent**(间歇的) with mist that began to **thaw**(解冻) the frost on the **sand**(沙). A **surge**(急剧上升) of memory hit me **sideways**(向旁边) as **someone**(某人) **considerate**(考虑周到的) and **helpful**(有帮助的) pushed the heavy door. Inside, an **orderly**(有秩序的) **occupant**(占有者) set a **tray**(盘) of **peach**(桃) and **chestnut**(栗子) tarts beside a **quartz**(石英) **prism**(棱柱) that scattered **scarlet**(猩红色) light across the room. He pressed a **button**(纽扣), and an **amateur**(业余爱好者) played a **flute**(长笛) while a recording with a **subtitle**(副题) explained the history. The **canteen**(食堂) at the back stayed **open**(公开) to all, its counter creased with the **wrinkle**(皱纹) of a thousand polishings, and on the wall hung a rusted **torpedo**(鱼雷), a relic of the war years.

In **actuality**(实际), running the winery was a **herculean**(力大无比的) **feat**(功绩). The **basic**(基本的) **implementation**(实行) of new rules, the **ratification**(批准) of a **multilateral**(多边的) trade deal, and the **consistent**(前后一致的) **regularity**(规则性) of the harvest all **complicate**(使...复杂) the work. There is always the **possibility**(可能) that a **rash**(轻率的) decision will **prolong**(延长) a crisis or that **pessimism**(悲观) will **pervert**(反常) good judgment. A **symptom**(症状) of trouble might be a **drastic**(严厉的) drop in the **ranking**(队) of our vintage, which would **form**(形状) a fresh debt.

My grandfather kept his faith **eternal**(永久的). He would **mutter**(轻声低语) about the **imperialist**(帝国主义者) past, about the **legion**(古罗马军团) of officials who tried to **censor**(审查) or **abet**(教唆) corruption, who would **grudge**(吝惜) an honest man his **bonus**(奖金). He warned that to **assist**(协助) a **pickpocket**(扒手) was the work of the **devil**(魔鬼), an act fit only for a **savage**(未开化的) or an **ass**(驴).

Yet the place still flourishes. We offer a generous **discount**(折扣) and a **homestay**(在当地居民家居住) program; visitors win a **lottery**(彩票), **admire**(钦佩) the orchard's **blossom**(花), play **poker**(扑克) by the fire, and **indicate**(指出) their **liking**(兴趣) for the wine. The **probable**(很可能的) **derivation**(引出) of its name comes from an old word for the deep coast. I felt no lasting grudge, only gratitude, and I knew that, **inapt**(不确切的) as I once was with a **knife**(刀) and a **bag**(袋) of tools, I would keep his legacy alive past every **deadline**(最后期限), and never **alter**(改变) it.

## 22. A Village Naturalist's Notebook

One overcast(多云的) morning in November(十一月), a visitor(访问者) named Greta arrived in our small village(村) to clothe(穿衣) her great(伟大的) aspiration(热望) in real fieldwork. She had no jeep(吉普车), only a battered lorry(卡车) and a mobile(可动的) phone, yet her endeavour(<英>尽力) to study the local environment(环境) was substantial(可观的). Whenever she could, she would crouch(蹲伏) beside a mossy bench(长凳), watching a swift(快的) dart past the corner(角落) of the lawn(草地), while moss(苔) spread over an old estate(房地产) wall. With discretion(慎重) she would not allow(允许) the oncoming(即将来临的) madness(疯狂) of tourist crowds to disturb the place she came to adore(崇拜). Her future(将来), she said, depended on this present(出席的) procedure(过程) of patient observation, and she kept a varied(不同的) encyclopedia(百科全书) of notes. Her behavior(行为) was orderly: she would blink(眨眼睛) at the sun, freshen(使显得新鲜) her mind with cold water, and own(自己的) up to any uncertain(无常的) finding. A wrinkled clause(条款) in her grant required a chairperson(主席) to retrieve(重新得到) every diagram(图解) and piece of information(通知) she produced, so she sent each gift(礼品) of data ahead(在前面) via(径) a tiny projector(放映机). The hump(驼峰) of a distant hill, the violet(紫罗兰) sky, a thorn-edged path past a frock(上衣)-clad scarecrow, the buckle(带扣) on her bag, all earned a compliment(敬意) in her diary. She would mutter no allegation(主张) of injustice(不公正) when funding was uncertain; instead she would devour(狼吞虎咽地吃) her homework(家庭作业), fiddle(提琴) with a tool(工具), and present a calm aspect even when antagonism(反对) flared. Her old mistress(女主人) in alchemy(炼金术) had taught her that experimentation(实验), not rapture(狂喜) or mere(纯粹的) manipulation(操纵) of numbers, brings discovery(发现). The villagers spoke a soft dialect(方言) that she found beautiful, and she never grew unduly(过分地) impatient with it. Once, a puncture(小孔) in the lorry tyre and an antagonist(对手)'s dishonorable(不名誉的) trick delayed her, but she did not buy(买) excuses. She would charge(要价) ahead, more(更多的n) valid(有效的) than ever, slot(缝) her tickets and visa(签证) into a drawer, and crouch again. A cashier(出纳员) in the next village, recovering from tuberculosis(结核病), would adore her delicious(美味的) bread and edible(可食用的) berries, sharing kin(家属)-like warmth. She studied a digit(数字) on her ration(定量) card, a partition(分开) between fields, the aerial(空气的) above a fire-engine(消防车), and even the embroidery(绣花) on a buckle. Each clause of her novel(新奇的) report, though it left her unconscious(不醒人事的) of fame, recorded the plague(瘟疫) years, the crazy(疯狂的) delight of an ad(广告)-free dawn, and the buckle of frost. Upside-down(颠倒的) in the grass, she would take a slow breath(呼吸), thank(感谢int) the morning, and feel her crucial(至关重要的) discovery blossom.

## 23. The Marine Research Voyage

On a cold **January**(一月) morning, a research **corps**(军团) boarded a **closed**(关闭的) vessel bound for waters where dolphins **converge**(聚合). The **sender**(寄信人) of our orders, an **authoritative**(权威的) **registrar**(登记员) from the **United Kingdom**(英国), had a **particular**(特殊的) and **thoughtful**(深思的) plan that left no **matter**(物质) to chance. Each crew member would **commute**(交换) daily between cabins, and **oneself**(自己) alone could not run the ship; a whole **troop**(部队) had to **assign**(分配) duties and **admit**(承认) mistakes **agreeably**(欣然). We had to **hasten**(催促), for the voyage was **unique**(惟一的) and the **supply**(供给) of fuel was barely **abundant**(大量的). The captain, my **brother**(兄弟), would not **gamble**(赌博) with safety, and his **respectful**(恭敬的) manner made even a **difficulty**(困难) seem **slightly**(稍微) easier. **Notwithstanding**(尽管) the **surprising**(惊人的) weather, our **coverage**(承保范围) of the region was **duly**(适当地) **comparable**(可比较的) to any prior survey. We would **detect**(发现) each **dolphin**(海豚) by its **whisker**(髯)-like markings and the way it would **revolve**(使旋转) and **distinguish**(区别) itself from the troop. To **recollect**(回忆) every sighting, we kept a **recorder**(记录员) running; the camera's **projection**(射出) on a screen helped us **literally**(照字义地) count each fin. The **dairy**(奶牛场) of the ship's galley smelled of **chocolate**(巧克力) and a **spoonful**(一匙的量) of cocoa, while a **shower**(阵雨) of spray would **explode**(爆炸) over the bow and **litter**(杂物) the deck with foam. One **instant**(立即的) a **raw**(生的) **wound**(创伤) on a sailor's hand needed **peroxide**(过氧化氢) and a **tranquilizer**(镇定剂); the next, an **irritate**(激怒)-prone cook would mutter about a **phony**(假冒的) invoice. We had no time to **deserve**(应得) rest. A **weed**(杂草) of doubt could not converge with our resolve, and **discomfortable**(不舒服的) nights notwithstanding, **agitation**(摇动) never won. Our **usage**(使用) of new instant tools made the work an **elevation**(高度) of pure **oceanography**(海洋学). A particular **bullish**(行情看涨的) **sponsor**(发起), **vehement**(激烈的) about clean seas, would not **consign**(运送) the project to failure, nor would the **violation**(违犯) of any rule go without **clarification**(澄清). The **fuse**(导火线) of curiosity, the **fertilizer**(肥料) of patience, and a **solution**(解答) of trust kept us united, not **disunite**(使分裂). **Ashore**(上岸) at last, **partly**(部分地) tired, we shouldered each **box**(盒) and **cart**(马车), paid **tribute**(贡品) to the sea, and made our **decision**(决定): the **carbohydrate**(碳水化合物)-rich meals, the **kindergarten**(幼儿园) of young interns, the elevation of every wave were worth it. A pickpocket could steal a wallet, but no **thorn**(刺), no **rifle**(步枪) shot, no **aggregation**(总计) of storms could steal the **indebtedness**(感激) we felt. The agreeably **stowage**(装载) of gear, the closed hold, the **can**(能) of supplies, all **said**(上述的) one thing: a thoughtful crew, sustained by faith, can survive. A **protestant**(清教徒) chaplain blessed our **ball**(球) of rope; a kindergarten teacher had once told me a **trick**(诡计): stay humble. Back at the **house**(房屋) ashore, we stocked the **freezer**(冷冻箱), watched an old **actress**(女演员) on television, and joked that the coast had more **arable**(可耕的) land than the sea. Though I felt **ambivalent**(矛盾的) about leaving, and our route home was **indirect**(间接的), we said our thanks, and sailed home.

## 24. The Reluctant Understudy

Nevertheless(然而), the young farmhand(农工) who longed to act in a drama(剧本) never imagined he would represent(代表) the academy(专科学校) on stage. He was proud(自豪的) yet poor(贫困的), and his manhood(男子气) had been shaped by costly(昂贵的) years of constant(经常的) labor. A foreman(领班), traditional(传统的) and strongly(强壮地) built, would incite(激动) him to quit, but a kindly potter(陶工) and a wandering constable(警官) would discuss(讨论) his talent and goad(刺棒) him onward. "Do not refuse(拒绝) the chance," they would say, "nor abandon it; embark(上船) on the role." The cue(暗示) came on an odd(奇数的), abrupt(突然的) evening. The villain(坏蛋) of the play(玩), an intelligent(聪明的) but malicious magistrate(地方法官), had fallen ill, and no substitute(代替人) seemed available. The number(数) of trained actors was small, the quota(配额) of understudies unobtainable(无法得到的), and the academy, generally(一般地) prosperous(繁荣的), faced a peculiar(奇怪的) crisis. So they sent for the farmhand. He had a shallow(浅的) draft(草稿) of the lines, scribbled on a torn formula(公式) sheet, and he had to meditate(考虑) quickly. His suspicion(怀疑) that he would fail was strong, yet a foremost(最重要的) teacher, apt(聪明的) and benevolent, said cordially(亲切地), "You serve(服务) the play; the play will serve you. Settle(安定) your nerves." Within(在...里面) the hour he had to incorporate(结合) gesture, voice, and a continuous(连续的) flow of feeling. He felt a dominant(支配的) fear dangle(摇摆) over him, and his consciousness(意识) wavered. The play's highlight(加亮区) required him to wield(使用) a wooden sword, brace(用以夹住或支撑的) his arm, and then(当时) sob(哭泣) with grief as the deceit(欺骗) of the court was revealed. He would not repent(悔悟) the risk. The drama was infectious(传染的); the audience, intelligent and sophisticated(人), leaned forward. The complexity(复杂) of the plot, full of contradiction(反驳), suspicion, and superstition(迷信), did not confuse him. He would transmit(传输) each line with expressive(有表现力的) force, and his every movement(运动) was deliberate. Then came the turning(旋转) point: the villain's deceit collapsed, and the crowd, no longer ambivalent, rose. A dentist(牙医) in the front row wept; a psychiatry(精神病学) student took notes; an attendant(服务员) in the balcony cheered. The accommodation(住宿) backstage was cramped, the dressing room mountainous(多山的) with costumes, but the world(世界) outside the theatre seemed to quantify(确定数量) his worth anew. He had been entice(诱惑)-resistant once, but now he would not hide(隐藏) his joy. "This was worthwhile(值得的)," he said, "and uncommon(罕见的). Generally, I am terribly(可怕地) shy, but tonight I felt the deliverance(救助) of art. May(可能) the suit(合适) of a true performer fit me. This informative(提供资料的) night, this proud feat, this abandonment(放弃) of doubt, has shown my characteristical(特征的) strength: a constant heart. Even a semiconductor(半导体), a sustenance(食物) of cold logic, could not measure my gladness. No one is exempt(免除) from fear, yet the benevolence(慈悲) of my teachers, who would send(打发) me notes of encouragement, carried me. As a boy I had played a cracked violin(小提琴) and studied astronomy(天文学) by night; this whole inclusive(包括的) incident(事件), from first cue to final bow, taught me more than any star. I am no privilege(特权)-born noble, no proud villain, but a farmhand who dared to dream."

## 25. The Astronomer-Photographer's Cosmic Journey

Lin was a **literate**(有文化的), **fascinating**(迷人的) woman who lived for **photography**(摄影术) of the night sky. She refused to be **passive**(被动的) about the **cosmic**(宇宙的) wonders above her, and her **relentless**(无情的), **perpetual**(永久的) curiosity would **kindle**(点燃) in **anyone**(任何人) who met her. From a **lofty**(高耸的) hill in **Asia**(亚洲) she would **traverse**(横越) rough, **jagged**(锯齿状的) trails, carrying a heavy **pail**(桶) of gear and an old **cane**(茎) for balance. She was no **senseless**(愚蠢的) dreamer; with **impartial**(公正的), **effective**(有效的) method she would **determine**(决心) the **depth**(深) of every shadow and **clamp**(螺丝钳) her camera to a **horizontal**(地平线的) mount. The **exotic**(异国情调的) **substance**(物质) of starlight, she said, was a **fantasy**(幻想) made **workable**(可行的) by patient craft. Anyone could **guess**(猜测) at the stars, but only the devoted could **surmount**(战胜) the **discrepancy**(不一致) between hope and a real, **appreciable**(可的) image. Her **lover**(爱好者), a quiet **priest**(教士) who had left the church to study **democracy**(民主政体), would **couch**(长沙发) his praise in gentle **tone**(音调). He would **readily**(乐意地) **provide**(供应) her a **guitar**(吉他vi) tune while she worked **slowly**(慢慢地), and the **harmonious**(和谐的) **living**(活的) room felt **full**(满的) of calm. Once a **report**(报告) reached them: a friend had died, and they sent a card of **condolence**(哀悼). Grief, she insisted, must not **jettison**(投弃货物v) joy. Her **coordination**(协调) of **fume**(烟)-filled darkroom chemicals, an **additive**(附加的n) here, a **gimmick**(暗机关) there, was a quiet **exploitation**(开发) of old methods. She would not **pose**(造成) for any **poster**(海报); she chose to **lurk**(潜伏) behind the lens. On the wall hung a faded **stripe**(长条) of film, a **phoenix**(凤凰) rising, an **angel**(天使) of light, a **goddess**(女神) of the void. The **mercury**(水银) in her thermometer barely moved on cold nights, yet she would not give up. Her **intercontinental**(大陆间的) fame grew, though it felt **delusive**(令人产生错觉的); one **conditional**(有条件的) grant would pay her **wage**(周薪), and she would **pound**(磅) the desk over red tape. The **FBI**(国际刑警) once asked about an **assassination**(暗杀) plot near her **vault**(拱顶) of negatives, but the rumor proved **pointless**(无意义的) and false. By a **score**(刻痕) of careful exposures, every **component**(组成部分) checked, she made an **adaptation**(适应) of an ancient star chart, **layday**(装卸日期) by layday refining each line. A **gallon**(加仑) of developer, a **sharpener**(铅笔刀) for her pencils, a sheet of **coinage**(造币)-bright foil **thereon**(关于那), and the rusty **shutter**(百叶窗) that would creak: all of it survived. She would shut the iron shutter against the wind, watch a **wave**(波浪) of cloud roll past, and trust that, in any **circumstance**(情况), the **creation**(创造) above held a **comparatively**(比较地) simple **certainty**(必然的事). The **feeble**(虚弱的) light of the **oblique**(倾斜的) horizon, the **debris**(碎片) of a meteor, the gentle oblique slant of dawn over the **region**(地区), were enough. A **couple**(对) who lived nearby would visit her, and she would **insist**(坚持要求) that they **choose**(选择) a clear night to watch with **him**(他), her lover, while the boys played **baseball**(棒球) in the yard below. She liked to **transfuse**(注入) her own wonder into them, telling of every **happening**(事件) in the sky, of **rust**(锈) on the old dome and the way starlight helps the soul **survive**(幸免于). She had survived, and so had her wonder.

## 26. Restoring an Old European Manor

In February(二月), my supervisor(监考人) handed me an unexpected(想不到的) assignment(分配): to restore a declining(下降的) manor in rural Europe(欧洲), a project that would involve(包含) months of careful work. The architecture(建筑) was modern(现代的) in some wings and aboriginal(土著的) in others, a complex(复杂的) blend that no alphabetical(依字母顺序的) guidebook could fully paraphrase(解释). A weathered signpost(路标) by the sidewalk(人行道) pointed the way, and a cab(出租车) would haul(用力拉) visitors and their luggage, each suitcase(衣箱) heavy(重的) with hope, up the long drive. The supervisor's reputation(名誉) was built on aesthetic(美学的) judgment; he would praise(赞扬) good craft and notify(报告) the owners of any flaw, however small. I would cram(填满) my notes each night, look(看) at faded photographs, and feel a wave of nostalgia(思家病) for a bygone(已往的) age of aristocracy(贵族阶层) and ceremonial(仪式的) pomp. The damp(潮湿) had caused corrosion(腐蚀) in the cable(缆) and a slow trickle(滴流) of rust down the precious(宝贵的) stone. By February's end, after a deluge(洪水) of rain, the cellar nearly became a pond, yet the source(源) of the leak proved easy to find. Atmospheric(大气的) moisture would pervade(遍及) every room, and a single papercut(剪纸) on my finger, caustic(腐蚀性的) with dust, reminded me how painful(疼痛的) old buildings can be. A rheumatic(风湿的) gardener, reliant(信赖的) on a cane, would yield(生产) his secrets slowly: which soil was fertile(肥沃的), where irrigation(灌溉) would nourish(养育) the roses, and how a snail(蜗牛) or a spider(蜘蛛) might lurk under a windowsill(窗台). He would eat(吃) lunch on the lawn and watch a chick(小鸡) wander by, his eloquence(雄辩) quiet but real. The manor's revenue(年收入) had fallen badly(非常); a subscription(预约) scheme and a modest tariff(关税) on tours were our attempt(尝试) to defray(支付) costs without lax(松的) accounting. One quirk(急转) of the estate was a sealed vault rumored to hold a knight(骑士)'s skull(头盖骨) and an excerpt(摘录) of an old treaty once tainted by treason(谋反). We could possibly(可能地) open it tomorrow(明天), but I felt a nerve(神经) of dread. Terrestrial(陆地) maps, an imaginary(想象的) line of an Antarctic(南极的) expedition, an endorsement(背书) from a famous historian, all came to fruition(享用) as the work advanced. The kernel(果核) of the plan, its operative(有效的) idea, was to outweigh(在重量上超过) decay with care. Demography(人口统计学) studies showed the village was cool(凉的) to tourism, so we would practise(练习) restraint. An impromptu(即席演出) party(聚会) would terrify(使害怕) no one; a chaste(贞洁的), double(两倍adj)-arched hall, a precious eclipse(天) of evening light through the glass, the gentle transport(运输) of memory anywhere(无论哪里) I walked, all proved that a productivity(生产率) born of patience could revive even the most bygone of homes. I found an old wallet(皮夹) on a windowsill, a precious resource(资源) of faded photographs, and I would suffer(受痛苦) no haste in restoring them. Every extra(额外的) hour would become(变成) a gift, and the village would become whole again. The work would not be done in a single month(月), but it would be done.

## 27. Engines of a Working Seaport

In a busy **seaport**(海港) in **China**(瓷器), the morning began with the steady knock of a **piston**(活塞) deep inside an old crane. The dock **master**(男主人), a **tall**(高的) man of nearly **seventy**(七十), would **care**(小心) for every machine as if it were **family**(家). He insisted that each part be **adequately**(恰当地) oiled, for a single **sprain**(扭伤) in the gears could halt the whole **harbor**(海港). A caged **canary**(金丝雀) once hung by the office window, a quaint **diversion**(转向) from the **dirt**(污物) and noise, and the workers would **chant**(圣歌) a rough tune as they worked **abreast**(并肩) along the quay. The **crude**(天然的) oil tankers, **too**(也) heavy and often **overweight**(超重), moved slowly **onward**(向前) toward the pier. To **expedite**(加快) the unloading, the crew would **improvise**(临时准备), adding a **lateral**(侧面的) brace here, a **prefabricate**(预制) panel there, in a **fusion**(融化) of old craft and modern **science**(科学). The supervisor, no **ferocious**(凶猛的) **dictator**(独裁者) but a patient master, would never demand **outright**(断然的) **submission**(屈服); instead he would **alleviate**(使易于忍受) tension with a kind word. He believed the **human**(人的) spirit, not **rigidity**(僵硬), was the true **catalyst**(催化剂) that let the port **flourish**(繁荣). When a **recession**(后退) struck, the **mood**(心情) grew **wretched**(不幸的). Cargo handling fell by a **tenth**(第十), then **beyond**(在...的那边), and a **horrible**(可怕的) **unrest**(不安的状态) spread among the men. One worker, soaked by a sudden **rainy**(下雨的) squall that seemed to **drench**(使淋透) the whole quay, would **stammer**(口吃地说) his fear of layoffs; another, reluctant and full of **reluctance**(不愿), sat in a battered **armchair**(手扶椅) and stared at the **garbage**(垃圾) piling up. It was an **utterly**(完全地) **incongruous**(不调和的) sight, and the **thought**(思想) of failure weighed on every mind. The accountant spoke of a **del credere**(保付) clause and an **off-grade**(等外的) shipment that had become **immaterial**(无形的), **supposedly**(想像上) **useless**(无用的), its value down to a single **cent**(分). In the **meantime**(其间), a **satellite**(卫星) dish on the roof would **flutter**(振翼) its old **cloth**(布) cover in the wind, and a **telescope**(望远镜) on the watchtower swept the gray sea. The port could not **retreat**(撤退). With **utmost**(最远的) effort it had to flourish again. The **obligatory**(义不容辞的) inspection, a kind of **postmortem**(死后的) on the failed quarter, revealed a **deformation**(损坏) in one **trolley**(手推车) rail and a crude **variation**(变化) in the loading **flora**(罗神) of cranes. The **kidnaper**(绑架者) of profit, the **crisis**(转折点) itself, was no **divine**(神的) punishment, only a problem to solve. They would **permit**(许可) a fresh plan, **distribute**(分发) new tasks, and **happily**(幸运地) push onward. A **graduate**(大学毕业生) engineer, his **eyelid**(眼睑) twitching from long nights, traced the flaw with a **vivid**(鲜艳的), **shiny**(耀眼的) pointer. He **favorably**(有利地) approved each **piece**(件). He tightened his **pants**(裤子) at the **waist**(腰), gave a quiet **hurrah**(好哇), and as the French would say of any single thing, **le**(引导) moment had come. A new **candidate**(候选人) for foreman, fresh from **sightseeing**(观光) leave with his **diploma**(毕业证书) in hand, would **graze**(吃草) his knuckles on the steel, **punch**(冲压机) the air, and **add**(加) one more **original**(最初的) idea. The **jellyfish**(水母) drifting near the hull, the canary's song, the harbor lights: all proved the port could thrive once more.

## 28. The Floating School Project

On a **golden**(金黄色的) morning in the **United States**(美国), a **creative**(有创造力的) team set out to build a floating school on an old oil **rig**(索具装备), a **project**(方案) that seemed **endless**(无止境的) at first. The **preliminary**(初步的) plan, drawn from a worn **textbook**(课本), set each **parameter**(参数) with **precise**(精确的) care. We would not **construe**(翻译) the river as a **barrier**(栅栏) but as a **friendly**(友好的) road; a **ferryboat**(渡船) would carry every **passenger**(乘客) across the **distance**(距离), and a graceful **colonnade**(柱廊) of **bamboo**(竹) would shade the **entry**(进入). Our **savings**(存款) were modest, so we had to **conserve**(保存) every **bit**(一点), and a **formal**(正式的) **promissory**(约定的) note would **empower**(授权与) the work. **Regularly**(有规律地), a **referee**(裁判员)-like inspector would visit for a **checkup**(审查), give his **verdict**(律), and **instruct**(教) us on **rectification**(纠正) wherever a flaw might **jeopardise**(使受危险) safety. We did not **presume**(假定) the task easy. A **pessimistic**(悲观的) critic, an **outcast**(被逐的) from the local council, would **commonly**(普通地) call the idea **worthless**(无价值的) and **malicious**(恶意的), but we would not let his **criticism**(评论性的文章) **shatter**(粉碎) our resolve. With **fidelity**(忠实) to the children, we would **strive**(斗争) to **win**(获胜), **conscious**(清醒的) that a single careless **switch**(开关) could **trap**(陷阱) a curious child. To **justify**(证明...是正当的或) the cost, we kept a **variable**(变化的) budget and a precise **discussion**(讨论) log, and we would not yield to **vice**(罪恶) or **wicked**(坏的) shortcuts. A **grateful**(感激的) **adoptive**(收养关系的) family, who had once felt **lonely**(孤独的) and treated like a **nomad**(游牧部落的人), donated a **brown**(褐色) **medal**(奖章) of honor to hang above the door. We would **migrate**(迁移) desks by **ladder**(梯子), **bridle**(笼子) our impatience, and meditate in quiet **leisure**(空闲) when the strain grew **chronic**(慢性的). A **baby-sitter**(看护小孩的人) taught a **tutorial**(指南) on first aid; a **professional**(职业的) from the **post-office**(邮局) helped us mail forms; and new **legislation**(法律), after a close **election**(选举), eased the way. The **agricultural**(农业的) village nearby gave us each a **pea**(豌豆)-green lunch box, and the children, **attentively**(关心地), would **echo**(反响) every lesson. We had to **invent**(发明) a new desk that would fold flat, and we would **wrestle**(摔跤) with each design until it worked. The questions of the young could **elicit**(得出) fresh ideas from us all. We gave the school a simple **title**(标题), painted in white. We added **zinc**(锌) panels to the roof to **relieve**(减轻) the heat. One could presume that an **elephant**(象) of doubt would block us, but we pressed on. A small **starfish**(海星), a **habit**(习惯) of **meditation**(熟虑), the **prevalent**(普遍的) hope of the people: all helped us reach the **summit**(顶点). The **intensity**(强烈) of our effort, in fair **proportion**(比率) to the dream, would not let us **fly**(飞行) from duty. No **invasion**(入侵) of doubt, no **snore**(打鼾) of laziness, could stop us. **Marxism**(马克思主义), the **brave**(勇敢的) **above-mentioned**(上述的) ideals, the **further**(更远) reach of justice, all met in one wish: to win for the children. The wind would echo, the river would **hit**(打) the hull, and still we built, brave and free.

## 29. The Architect and the Old Theatre

Last **summer**(夏天), a **humble**(谦卑的) **architect**(建筑师) named Vera took on a **heroic**(英雄的) task: to restore an **established**(已建立的) old theatre whose **ceiling**(天花板) had begun to **mould**(模子) and whose walls showed deep **erosion**(腐蚀). She was no **pompous**(华而不实的) figure, no **vulgar**(粗俗的) self-promoter; she would **profess**(表白) only a quiet faith, almost a **religion**(宗教), in honest work. Her **staff**(木棍), **each**(各) a **student**(学生) of design who would **dedicate**(奉献) long hours to the work, would **peer**(同等) at every crack and **communicate**(传达) findings without **frustration**(挫折). A **heated**(激烈的) debate over the most **advanced**(超前的) restoration method filled the **office**(办公室), but it never turned bitter. In **comparison**(比较) to a flashy modern **enterprise**(艰巨的事业), with its sudden **flash**(闪光) of fame, her firm seemed small, yet its **competitiveness**(竞争能力) lay in care, not in pompous **talk**(谈话). A faint **gleam**(微光) of morning light would **intersperse**(散布) the dusty **corridor**(走廊), and a **leafy**(叶状的) vine outside the window swayed in the **spring**(跳) breeze. The **significance**(意义) of the project was **widely**(广) felt; the local **consul**(领事), a **leading**(领导的) patron, gave **personal**(个人的) **advice**(劝告), and an old **mariner**(海员) who lived nearby offered a **sorrowful**(使人伤心的) **moan**(呻吟声) about how the place had decayed. Vera would **fasten**(扎牢) loose beams, **tighten**(变紧) each bolt, and **paste**(糊) fresh plaster where the wall had worn. She would not **surrender**(投降) to the **headstrong**(不听命令的) owner who demanded a **careless**(粗心的) rush. With **deft**(敏捷熟练的) hands she would **condense**(冷凝) a complex plan into a clear **photo**(照片) and a **composite**(合成的) drawing, **attach**(系上) a **postscript**(附言) of notes, and present it on a single **chair**(椅子) at the center of the stage. The **advent**(出现) of new tools made some old methods **unusable**(无法使用的), but she kept what had **merit**(价值). A **compulsory**(义务的) **examination**(考试) by the city office was **prescribed**(规定的), and the **feedback**(反馈) was **integral**(构成整体所必需的) to her next step. She would not let an **impost**(进口税) or a sudden **devaluation**(贬值) of the building fund **baffle**(阻碍) her. To **internationalize**(使国际化) the theatre's appeal, she planned to **feature**(脸一部分) **acrobatics**(杂技), an **essayist**(散文作家)'s lecture, and a **convenient**(便利的) open house. The **brilliance**(辉煌) of the restored hall, an architectural **phenomenon**(现象), would **obviously**(明显地) draw crowds. A **goose**(鹅) wandered **awkwardly**(笨拙地) across the lawn; a **deer**(鹿) grazed at the leafy edge; and a child ate a raw **vegetable**(蔬菜) from a paper bag. The local **fauna**(动物群) seemed at peace, though the **whereabouts**(下落) of the old caretaker remained a mystery. **Briefly**(简单地), the project felt **impossible**(不可能的). The **importation**(进口) of rare marble, the **convention**(会议) of formal permits, the **bonded**(保税的) warehouse fees, and the **lung**(肺)-tiring dust all weighed on her. Yet she would not utter a tired **platitude**(陈词滥调). Each beam was bonded and **transferable**(可转让的) to a new use; the **embryo**(胚胎) of an idea grew. After a quick **haircut**(理发) and a **lighter**(打火机) mood, she returned to **focus**(焦点). The **match**(火柴) between old grace and new function was nearly perfect, and as the **diverge**(分歧) of opinions finally converged, the theatre, like a phoenix, was ready to **finish**(完成) its long sleep and wake to applause.

### 30. The Prairie Observatory

On a **hot**(热的) afternoon, a young **astronomer**(天文学家) named Mara came as a **stranger**(陌生人) to the wide **prairie**(大草原) to **establish**(建立) a small observatory. **These**(这些) open lands, she said, were a kind of **heaven**(天), **fairly**(公正地) untouched, where one could **idealize**(使理想化) the night and study the **propulsion**(推进) of distant stars. She would not **strictly**(严格地) **regulate**(控制) her wonder; the **craze**(狂热) for discovery, which would **embed**(使插入) itself like a seed and had embedded itself in her since she was a **novice**(新手), drove her on. Her **modish**(流行的) gadgets and her old habits would not **break**(打破) apart. An old rancher, **appreciative**(感激的) but **sceptical**(怀疑论的), would **exclaim**(呼叫) in **astonishment**(惊奇) at her **glassware**(玻璃制品) and her **queer**(奇怪的) instruments. " **Whether**(是否) you find anything or not," he would say with a **solemn**(严肃的) nod, "these stars belong to no one." Mara had won a **scholarship**(学问) **associated**(联合的) with a famous **palace**(宫) of science, and she did not **intend**(想要) to **misuse**(误用) it. She knew the **risk**(冒...的危险): a single **bout**(一回) of bad weather could **ravage**(毁坏) a season of work, and **excessive**(过多的) ambition could prove **detrimental**(有害的). Yet she would **gather**(聚集) data over **numerous**(许许多多的) **consecutive**(连续的) nights, **shift**(位置转移) her telescope by a **centimeter**(厘米), and watch the dome **oscillate**(振荡) gently in the wind. Around her, the prairie would **inhabit**(居住于) a thousand small lives. A **crooked**(弯曲的) **snake**(蛇) would **hop**(单足跳), no, slither, past a **bean**(豆) field; a bird with a sharp **beak**(鸟嘴) would **poke**(拨) at **porridge**(粥) crumbs; a **propeller**(螺旋桨) plane would drone overhead. She would **gulp**(吞下) cold coffee, tuck a **hairpin**(发卡) into her hair, and feel an **exuberant**(繁茂的) joy. The **terminology**(术语学) of her field, full of **prehistoric**(史前的) **mythology**(神话学) and the names of a **cavalry**(骑兵) of constellations, could **distress**(悲痛) a beginner, but to her it was a **tender**(脆弱的), **indelible**(去不掉的) language. She would not idealize the past, nor mourn its **emptiness**(空虚). A **traitor**(叛徒) to old dogma, she trusted what she could measure. There was a **stipulation**(规定) in her grant, a **formality**(礼节) of **procurement**(采购) and **authorization**(授权), that every result **thereof**(它的) must be shared. She did not mind. The **state**(状态) had funded her, and a **fit**(发作) of generosity was no **obnoxious**(不愉快的) thing. Late one night, a strange **intimation**(亲密) came: a faint, indelible signal that she could not **deflect**(偏斜) from her mind. Was it **noxious**(有害的) interference, a misuse of the equipment, or something true? She would not idealize it; she would test it. To **ignite**(点燃) the data run, she fed an **aminoacid**(氨)-stained sample into the analyzer, sipped a sweet **cocktail**(鸡尾酒) of relief, and waited. As the prairie began to **waken**(醒) to dawn, **primarily**(首先) she felt gratitude. The **growth**(生长) of knowledge, like a vine, would **inherit**(继承) the future, **superior**(优良的) to any **warfare**(战争) of egos. She thought of her **son**(儿子) back home, and of how the **exportation**(出口) of ideas, not goods, would build a better world. No **Turk**(土耳其人) of doubt, no **satire**(讽刺) of cynics, no **generality**(一般性) of fear could **enforce**(强迫服从) silence on her. She wiped a **rag**(抹布) across the lens, smoothed a crease near her **cervix**(解)-stiff neck, and, no **addict**(使沉溺) to fame, simply smiled. The **drawing**(绘图) of the constellation, sketched in a small **section**(部分) of her notebook, would outlast her. Up on the **hill**(小山), the propulsion of the heavens carried on, and she, a humble watcher, carried on with it.

## 31. Globalization Seen from a Small Town

At the **outset**(开端), no one in our **outlying**(无关的) town truly grasped what **globalization**(全球化) would **signify**(表示). Decades **ago**(以前), **industrialization**(工业化) arrived like a **dragon**(龙), and the **textile**(纺织品) mills that once defined the **entirety**(全部) of our economy began, **repeatedly**(重复地) and **simultaneously**(同时地), to **push**(推) their goods across every border. The **data**(资料) we collected seemed **alarming**(警告的): a **huge**(巨大的) share, some ninety **percent**(百分之...的), of local cloth now competed with imports, and the old **norm**(标准) of self-sufficiency had become **elusive**(躲闪的).

My **elder**(年长的) cousin, a **competent**(有能力的) **trainee**(受训练者) who later became an **underwriter**(保险商) for an insurance **alliance**(联盟), used to say that change was a **natural**(正常的) and **inherent**(固有的) **function**(职责) of trade. He would **economize**(节省) on words, yet his **clarity**(清楚) of thought was a kind of **masterpiece**(杰作). We would **queue**(行列) outside the **spacious**(广阔的) **restaurant**(餐馆) on the **outskirts**(郊区), and there, over a plate of **cucumber**(黄瓜) dressed in tangy **sauce**(调味汁), he framed his **hypothesis**(前提): that no town can **isolate**(隔离) itself, that to **prevent**(预防) decline a community must **widen**(加宽) its **access**(存取) to the world rather than **cloak**(斗篷) itself in fear.

I was young and **adventurous**(冒险的) then, and **most**(最多的) afternoons I went **skiing**(滑雪) in the **woods**(树林) beyond the reservoir, or watched a **fireman**(消防队员) **wax**(蜡) the engine of his truck until the **glass**(玻璃) gleamed. The mill's old **paraphernalia**(随身用具), spindles and dyeing vats of every **size**(大小), still stood in the yard like the **composition**(作品) of a forgotten painting. The **atmosphere**(大气) of that **microcosm**(微观世界) felt safe, almost a **celebration**(庆祝仪式) of ordinary life. After a **rainbow**(虹) appeared over the **skyscraper**(摩天大楼) they were building **downstairs**(在楼下) by the river, I would **spin**(纺纱) a coin and **await**(等候) my cousin's verdict on whether our family business could **stabilize**(稳定).

**Sadly**(悲痛地), not every story is happy. A sudden **rebellion**(叛乱) among the workers, who felt their **gender**(语法) and seniority were overlooked, **severely**(严厉地) threatened the firm. One **thoughtless**(欠考虑的) and **insolent**(傲慢无礼的人) manager, **cowardly**(胆小地) and rather **sad**(悲哀的), had treated them as if they were an **enemy**(敌人) rather than partners. The dispute, heavy as a thousand-**kilogram**(千克) weight, dragged the company into a **mire**(泥潭) from which **clean**(清洁的) recovery seemed unlikely. To **quench**(止渴) the anger, the elders **agreed**(商定的) to **undertake**(承担) reform; they would **furnish**(用家具装备房子) new tools, improve **communication**(通讯), and **perform**(履行) their promises in their entirety.

It is **desirable**(值得弄到手的), a **realist**(现实主义者) would say, to **correlate**(相关联) ambition with patience. The **recruitment**(招募) of fresh minds, the steady supply of **phosphorus**(磷)-rich fertiliser to the surrounding farms, even the discovery of **penicillin**(青霉素) in a distant lab, all reminded us that progress, however **unusual**(不平常的), rarely comes alone. A **bulge**(凸出部分) of new orders arrived; my cousin tightened **her**(她) **scarf**(围巾), smiled, and noted that the **sheer**(完全的) scale of demand, hosting buyers by the **metre**(米) of shelf space, had surprised us all. To my **surprise**(使诧异), the great **host**(许多) of foreign buyers did not **overlook**(俯视) our little **frame**(框架) of a workshop after all.

## 32. An Anecdote from the Antiques Market

Perhaps(也许) no place reveals a person(人)'s character like a Sunday market, where the surroundings(周围的事物) shift from stall(分隔栏) to stall and a single anecdote(轶事) can sum up a whole life. Last sunny(阳光充足的) day(天), in bright sunshine(日光), I joined the throng(人群) on the left(左面) side of the square, content(满意) to wander with no fixed agenda(议程). A junior(较年幼者) trader, lazy(懒惰的) in manner yet ingenious(设计独特的) in talk, was trying to advertise(做广告) an assorted(各式各样的) box of magnetic(磁的) toys and a compact(紧密的) chess set he hoped would render(提供) him rich.

Nearby, a patriot(爱国者) in faded jeans(牛仔裤) had laid out an ornament(装饰) shaped like a planet(行星), a postcard(明信片) collection, and the trunk(树干) of an old automobile(汽车) radio. He spoke with such fortitude(坚毅) about the revival(复苏) of local craft that a small crowd began to conceive(想出) real interest. "In actuality," he said, scraping mud from a coin, "these things carry more security(安全) than any star(星) on a screen. Heed(注意) the past, and it will not annoy(使烦恼) you."

The scene felt almost classical(经典的). A female(女性) violinist played while a duke(公爵)'s portrait, its frame topmost(最高的) on the wall, looked down with an air both urgent(急迫的) and serene. Someone had begun to embroider(绣) a flag; another chewed slowly on a strip of dried meat, perhaps an eggplant(茄子) relish on the side. The whole panorama was a study in human variety, comprehensive(内容广泛的) and warm, though now and then an unwelcome(不受欢迎的) jerk(猛地一拉vi) of the elbow reminded you to mind your seat(座位) at the crowded counter.

Meanwhile(其时), a notary(公证人) in a grey coat moved through the rows to nullify(使无效) a forged document and dismiss(解雇) a dubious claim. He explained, with a perspective(透视) sharpened by years of dealing, that to deny fraud is not enough; one must directly oppose it. "It would be thoughtless to incur(招致) a debt you cannot repay," he told a nervous young person, "and reckless to ignore the peril(危险) of haphazard(杂乱的) spending. Such a habit can degrade a family as surely as slavery(奴隶制度) once crushed the free."

I bought a small print(印刷), a finding(发现) I had not anticipated, and a scarred wooden box whose lid no longer closed. The seller, prestigious(享有声望的) among collectors, was inclined(倾向于的) to donate(捐赠) a second piece, an antique mixer(混合者) for the kitchen, just to oblige(迫使) me. As the day cooled, the climactic(顶点的) moment came when an old man, his face marked by a scar(伤疤), began to play a haunting tune. The preferential(优惠的) treatment of beauty over price, the uniformly(相同地) gentle mood, the amusement(娱乐) of bargaining: all of it made the market a place I would dispatch(派遣) my friends to without hesitation, certain they too would leave content. Before the excursion(远足) ended, a guard checked our identification(识别) at the peripheral(周界的) gate, his manner the hallmark(标志) of an invincible(不能征服的) discipline. The conversation(会话) never grew stagnant(停滞的). One unpaid(未付的) trainee, intentional(故意的) in every gesture, would not tire(疲倦); he gave clear instruction(教授) and crisp dictation(听写) to a junior, who copied it in symmetric(对称的) handwriting. We watched a man chew(嚼) betel as another swept excrement(排泄物) and stray scraps away to extinguish(熄灭) the smell. A reformed convict(罪犯) explained the microeconomics(微观经济学) of his trade: each acquisition(取得), each direct(径直的v) sale, was a gamble against the odds(可能的机会), as unpredictable as a strike in a game of bowling(保龄球运动). My daughter-in-law(儿媳), who studies how leaves release oxygen(氧), read the manual(手工的) aloud, and no thief would dare rob(抢劫) a place that might, as they say, scrape(刮) the very soul.

### 33. The Realm of Poetry and Discovery

Imagine(想象) a winter(冬季) evening when a silent(寂静) room fills with the loud(大声的) crackle of a fire, and you decide(决定) to meet(会) an old book again. Poetry(诗歌), more than any other realm(界) of writing, can recover(重新找到) what daily life misses; it lets us extract(拔出) meaning from the ordinary and anticipate(预料) the joy of understanding. A valuable(贵重的) verse is real(真的) in a way that gold(金) is not, for its worth does not depend on currency(通货) or financial(财政的) markets.

When I was barely sixteen(十六), in my teens(十多岁), a strict(严格的) teacher who would preside(主持) over our class with marked(有标记的) dignity(高贵) asked us to mend(修理) our lazy habits and read conscientiously(认真地). He spoke toward(向) us as a specialist(专家) might address a junior colleague. "Several(几个) of you," he said, "treat learning as rubbish(垃圾) to be tossed aside, yet the synthesis(综合) of fact and feeling is what gives a mind its height(高)." His words, given(赠予的) freely, achieved more than any threat. Immediately(立即) I felt a vigorous(强有力的) hunger to know more.

That hunger took me far. I read of the universe(宇宙) and the galaxy(星系), of radioactivity(放射性) and the slow propagation(繁殖) of light across space; of how a flask(细颈瓶) in a lab might hold a combustible(易燃的) gas, of how scientists measure the tonnage(吨位) of a ship or chart the song(歌唱) of whales. I learned that to amend(改进) a theory is no shame, that to abridge(删节) a long work can clarify it, and that a dubious(半信半疑的) claim should never be embraced without proof. A good reader, like a good farmer who tends his wheat(小麦) and fowl(家禽), must not forsake(遗弃) patience.

There is a kind of admiration(钦佩) that borders on reverence for those who, against starvation(饥饿) and penury(贫困), still create. A warrior(勇士) may win glory in battle, a giant(巨人) of industry may amass wealth, but the poet who writes through bitterness leaves something that will not blur(涂污). History gives us the madman(疯子) and the realist alike; it shows the explosive(爆炸的) force of rebellion and the slow extraction(抽出) of justice from injustice. To preside over one's own thoughts, to pertain(附属) to no faction blindly, to perceive clearly: this is the manifestation(表明) of a free mind.

Now, recovered from a long illness, I sit by the dike(堤) near my home and watch the water disperse(使散开) the evening light. My cheek(面颊) feels the cold; an ear(耳) catches a distant infection(感染) of laughter from children at play. I think of an antique(古代的) flask of perfume my mother kept, of a sausage(香肠) supper after a hurried day, of the juicy(多汁的) pear I shared with a friend. Marketing(市场学) and expenditure(花费) will always demand their share of our hours, and a dispute over money can sour any week. But scarcely(仅仅) a day passes that I do not, clockwise(顺时针方向地) around the room, let my eyes fall on the books and feel, despite every hardship, indefinite(不明确的) and quiet gratitude. My perception(感觉) of these matters did not come in a hurry(匆忙). As a folk(人们) saying goes, you cannot legislate(制定法律) taste, nor disburse(支付) wisdom like coins. When a postponement(推迟) notice from the printer arrived, I felt a jolt(摇晃) run from hip(臀部) to bowel(肠), for the despatch(派遣) of my favourite volume had been delayed. To achieve(完成) equality(同等) of access, the library waived the tuition(教学) of its renovation(革新) classes, and an obese(肥胖的) cat would smack(滋味) its lips and climb onto(在...上面) the old chair we had begun to upholster(装饰) anew. I would not miss(小姐) those evenings: the radioactive(放射性) glow of the lamp, a pronoun(代词) underlined in red, the worn hull(外壳) of a paperback, a soft nightgown(睡衣), and the smack of rain on the glass.

## 34. The Sculptor in the Remote District

In a **remote**(远的) **district**(地区) on a windswept **peninsular**(半岛), there lived an **obscure**(不出名的) **sculptor**(雕塑家) whose true **identity**(身份) remained as elusive as an obscure **rumour**(亦作 rumor). His **apartment**(房间), **adjacent**(邻接的) to a damp **cavern**(酒馆) near the coast, was a strange **institution**(公共机构) unto itself. **Behind**(在...的背后) a **waterproof**(防水的) curtain he kept the **basis**(基础) of his craft: a **spectrum**(光谱) of stones, a **pitcher**(水罐) of water, a rack of tools, and a **wide**(宽阔的) **pink**(粉红色a) **membrane**(膜) of wax he would **melt**(融化) and **sprinkle**(洒) over each frame.

He did not **belong**(属于) to any **collective**(集体a), nor did he **beg**(请求) the **mayor**(市长) or the **senate**(参议院) for favours. **Customary**(习惯的) opinion held that he would **degrade**(贬低) his gift if he let a **financier**(金融家) **appraise**(评价) it, **peg**(桩v) a price to it, or **strip**(剥去) it of meaning by selling it **alongside**(在旁) cheap goods. Yet his sculptures could **exemplify**(举例说明) an entire **sequence**(系列) of human feeling, from **reverence**(尊敬) to **bitterness**(苦味), with **perceptible**(可察觉的) clarity. People said a single piece could **obliterate**(删去) doubt and **link**(连接) the viewer to something eternal.

The story goes that the **ruling**(统治的) **pope**(罗马教皇) once contemplated a **vote**(投票) in the local senate to **glorify**(赞美) the man, and a **Russian**(俄罗斯的) collector offered to pay a **surcharge**(额外费用) so steep it could **remedy**(补救办法) the debt of a small town. But the sculptor would not be a **pawn**(典当). He refused **obedience**(服从) to fashion. 'Will(将) you **eject**(喷射) your own conscience for gold?' he asked, and the financier could only **gape**(打呵欠), his **thigh**(大腿) trembling, before he beg pardon and left.

**Frequently**(时常), as the hours would **elapse**(流逝), the artist sat behind his bench and let his hand **sew**(缝) the final seam of a clay cloak, or **sift**(筛) fine dust through a sieve. A small **burrow**(洞穴) of mice lived in the wall, and a **holocaust**(大毁灭) of moths once swarmed his lamp. None of this would obscure his focus. For the **sake**(缘故) of the work, he would **emit**(散发) no complaint, **blot**(墨水渍) out no error, and overlook no **defect**(欠缺).

One customary morning a great **airliner**(定期航班) roared overhead, its **multiplication**(增加) of engines loud enough to **pounce**(突袭) on the silence. The **vibration**(颤动) shook a **thing**(物) from the shelf. The **handling**(处理) of grief, he believed, was the true **construction**(建造) of art. He had no **horsepower**(马力), no **leadership**(领导) title, no **schooling**(学校教育) beyond what the woods taught him; **even**(一致的) so, an **applicant**(申请人) for apprenticeship arrived weekly. **Whichever**(无论哪个) pupil proved competent, he would teach the **alphabet**(字母表) of stone. **Interference**(干涉) from the outside world, the customary holocaust of noise and rumour, could not strip away the quiet reverence in which he worked, even as the years melted by. He once gave **me**(我) a **pill**(药丸) for my cough and spoke in a single grave **utterance**(说话) about the **macroeconomics**(宏观经济学) of art, how a **liberal**(慷慨的) patron might **export**(出口) beauty abroad. I **postulate**(要求), he said, that fame is **insubstantial**(无实质色); **therewith**(对此) he would **countermand**(撤回) any order for the **delivery**(递送) of his work to a gallery of mere **conquest**(征服). The **mucous**(黏液的) damp of the cave clung to my **tibia**(解) as I left, while the **ejection**(喷射) of hot wax along a **circuit**(周游) of moulds was his only farewell.

## 35. A Speedy Recovery on the Tropic River

The **illness**(病) struck without warning. What began as a vague **ache**(痛) in the **belly**(腹部) and a dull pain in my **neck**(颈脖) soon revealed itself, after a **fierce**(凶猛的) week, to be **dysentery**(痢疾). The **principal**(主要的) doctor at the clinic, a **handsome**(漂亮的) but **laborious**(艰苦的) man with a **haggard**(消瘦的) face, prescribed a course of pills and ordered a brief **quarantine**(检疫) to **confine**(限制) the infection. He warned that the **bearing**(举止) of my mood would matter as much as any **granule**(小粒) of medicine.

The clinic stood near a wide **reservoir**(水库) in the **tropic**(回归线) lowlands, **everywhere**(到处) fringed by tall **fir**(杉木) and fragrant **pear**(梨子) trees. **Immigration**(移居入境) officials had stamped my **license**(许可证) at the border, and the long **check-out**(结账) queue at the dock had left me **nervous**(神经的). Now, **naked**(裸体的) of all my plans, I lay still. A **touchy**(暴躁的) old **beggar**(乞丐) in the next bed, **seldom**(很少) **polite**(有礼貌的), would **dispute**(争论) every remark, while a kindly **Dutch**(荷兰人) **shopkeeper**(店主) across the room told stories with **wisdom**(智慧) and gentle humour, never **lukewarm**(冷淡的) in his welcome.

To **recapture**(取回) my strength I had to **abandon**(抛弃) my old habit of haste. The doctor explained, in **elaborate**(精心计划的) detail, that recovery was not a **hurdle**(篱笆) to leap but a **curve**(曲线) to follow. He did not glorify quick fixes; he warned that an **intractable**(难处理的) case could **undermine**(破坏) the body for a **generation**(产生) if a patient sought only a **speedy**(快速的) result. A **turbulent**(狂暴的) fever, he said, must not be allowed to **rouse**(唤醒) panic. **Commitment**(责任) to rest, he insisted, was no **unnecessary**(不必要的) luxury but the **correct**(正确的) path.

As the days passed I began to **gain**(获得) ground. A **postgraduate**(研究所学生) nurse, **cheeky**(胖乎乎的) and warm, would bring **food**(食物) on a **marble**(大理石) tray: a slice of pear, a little **saline**(盐的) broth, sometimes a **pimple**(脓疱) of honey on bread fresh from the **oven**(炉). She would **scare**(惊恐) off my gloom, deny my **woe**(悲哀) a foothold, and **ascribe**(把...归因于) my progress to plain **participation**(参加) in the daily routine. I no longer **differ**(与...不同) with her on that. Her **commonplace**(普通的) kindness, **exclusively**(专门地) given without thought of reward, became the **holy**(神圣的) centre of those long hours.

On the day of my release I walked, weak but upright, down to the water where a **canoe**(独木舟) waited. A **competitor**(竞争者) in some local race paddled past, **fist**(拳头) raised in triumph. The **collision**(碰撞) of joy and relief nearly made me weep. I thought of all I had nearly lost: the **festivity**(欢宴) of ordinary life, the dignity of standing on my own. A **mystic**(神秘的) might call it grace; a **lawyer**(律师) might call it luck. The **president**(总统) of the clinic, presiding at the gate, shook my hand. The **ax**(斧子) of fear had been laid down; the **denial**(拒绝) was over. With a **synonym**(同义词) for gratitude on my lips, I stepped into the **midst**(中间) of the world again, my **hardware**(金属日用器皿) of habits rebuilt, ready to **slay**(屠杀) no enemy but my own despair. At the **start**(开始) of the **tour**(旅游), the doctor would **prescribe**(吩咐使用) a **triple**(三倍数) dose and a careful **depiction**(描述) of every symptom, **dealing**(交往) gently so as not to **cosset**(亲手饲养的宠物) the patient nor **hinder**(阻碍) recovery, and he always left the door **ajar**(半开的). In a **developing**(发展中的) nation moving toward **socialism**(社会主义), the **marketplace**(市场) must **optimize**(最佳化) its **scale**(规模); the **erasure**(抹去) of old debts was **indicative**(指示的) of reform, though stacks of **lumber**(木材) and red tape still slowed the work.

## 36. The Brain, Resilience, and a British Farm

On a **grand**(最重大的) **British**(不列颠的) **farm**(农场) **among**(在...之中) the rolling **meadow**(草地) country, my **father**(父亲) kept a **stout**(矮胖的) **shepherd**(牧羊人)'s cottage that he loved to **renovate**(革新). It was here, **surely**(确实), that I first learned about **resilience**(弹回). The **continual**(不断的) rhythm of the seasons taught a **patience**(耐心) no **television**(电视) or **best-seller**(畅销书) could **enhance**(提高), and the **loneliness**(孤独) of winter could be **problematic**(有问题的) for a **darling**(心爱的人) child who craved company.

My **recollection**(回忆) of those years is vivid. Each morning my father, a **worker**(工人) of real **expertise**(专门知识), would **specify**(指定) the chores: **replenish**(补充) the trough, **certify**(证明) the count of the cattle, **hoist**(升起) the hay onto the **rod**(杆)-and-rack frame, and **protect**(保护) the **organic**(器官的) crops from **gale**(大风) and frost. The **rotation**(旋转) of tasks was a kind of **computation**(计算), **roughly**(粗糙地) fixed yet flexible, and an **observer**(观察员) might call it monotonous. To me it was **rewarding**(有收获的). Even the **laundry**(洗衣店) on the line, swirling in the wind, seemed to **wiggle**(踌躇) with a life of its own.

The farm was no commonplace operation. We grew **turnip**(萝卜) and **flower**(花) beds alike, and a small **brewery**(酿酒厂) at the rear produced a stout so dark it looked like ash. My father would **browse**(浏览) a worn handbook for advice, **muscular**(肌肉的) arms folded, and say that good husbandry was **advisable**(可取的), that **incorrect**(不正确的) methods would only breed **discomfort**(不安). He distrusted any **hasty**(急速的) or **outlandish**(古怪的) scheme; a **sheepish**(胆怯的) neighbour once tried a **compatible**(可和谐共存的) new fertiliser without **verification**(检验) and watched his **quantity**(量) of barley collapse into **paralysis**(瘫痪).

There was, of course, hardship. My brother caught a fever that left him **incapable**(无能力的) of work, his **tooth**(牙齿) aching, his **chin**(颏) pale; the **brain**(脑), the doctor said, needed rest more than any pill. The **uncertainty**(不定) was a heavy **suspension**(吊) over the house. Yet my father would **summon**(召唤) a **hilarious**(欢闹的) story, **accidentally**(偶尔) spill the **necklace**(项链) of beads my mother kept by the **sink**(洗涤槽), and turn **provocation**(刺激) into laughter. He refused to let **depreciate**(降价) the **heritage**(遗产) of good cheer that was our true wealth.

That heritage, **multiple**(多样的) and rich, still shapes me. I think of the meadow at dawn, the **cat**(猫) asleep on the **price-list**(价格表) pinned to the door, the **arrow**(箭) of geese overhead. I think of the **crevice**(裂缝) in the old wall where I would **bury**(埋) small treasures, of the **bath**(沐浴) by the fire, of the **adhesive**(粘合剂) sense of belonging that no **sanction**(批准) or distance could **pierce**(刺穿). Among all the things I own, that **excellent**(卓越的) and continual **belief**(信任) in patience, in protection, in the slow **solidify**(凝固) of love, is the one I would never let a competitor purchase. It made me, and represents in its quiet **representation**(描写) everything I hope to pass on. Our **friendship**(友谊), **visible**(可见的) to all, did not **obligate**(使负义务) either of us to anything. At the **station**(车站) we would practice the **pronunciation**(发音) of foreign words, fill a **paper**(纸) with notes, and watch the **furniture**(家具) of the old hall **swirl**(漩涡) with dust. As a season **ski**(雪橇)-pass **holder**(持有者), he would **transship**(转运) his gear north each winter, press the **accelerator**(加速者) of his battered car, pour a glass of **scotch**(苏格兰), and speak warmly of the charities that fight **aids**(艾滋病).

### 37. A Coastal Survey of Species and Terrain

When I was first hired to **survey**(环视) the **eastern**(东方的) **delta**(三角洲), I did not **find**(找到) the work **expensive**(花费的) or boring; **initially**(最初) it was the most rewarding job I could imagine. My task was to map the **boundary**(边界) of a fragile ecosystem along a coral **reef**(礁), to **contemplate**(仔细考虑) its **myriad**(极大数量) **species**(生物的种), and to **finalize**(落实) a report on how **congestion**(拥挤) from new construction near the motorway might harm the **territory**(领土).

The **handbook**(手册) the institute gave me was **handy**(手边的) and **economical**(节约的) with words. It urged me to **visualize**(形象) each habitat as a single **subject**(主题), to **deduce**(演绎) patterns from **genetic**(遗传的) data, and to **broaden**(放宽) my view from one **lane**(小径) of evidence to the whole **interior**(内部的) of the problem. I would **unlock**(开...的锁) my field **card**(卡片) at dawn, **drag**(拖) my **rack**(行李架) of gear past the **lighthouse**(灯塔), and **wait**(等待) for the **boiling**(沸腾的) sun to clear the morning **hum**(嗡嗡叫) of insects. A **turtle**(海龟) might cross the wet sand; a **shark**(鲨鱼)'s fin might **cut**(切) the surface beyond the reef; once a curious **bee**(蜂) followed me the whole **starting**(出发) mile.

The **terrain**(地形) was a **versatile**(多才多艺的) teacher. Each **cycle**(自行车) of the tide exposed a new **seam**(线缝) in the rock, an **incipient**(初始的) crack that would, given **irregularity**(不规则) of weather, widen into a cave. I learned to read the omen of a snowstorn far inland and to **intensify**(加强) my pace **against**(对着) any deadline I might **exceed**(比...大). A **gracious**(亲切的) old **landlady**(女房东) near the **customs**(海关) house rented me a **bedroom**(卧室) with **cotton**(棉花) sheets, served strong **tea**(茶) and **soup**(汤), and told me anecdotes about smugglers who once demanded a **ransom**(敲诈) from passing ships, or a **butcher**(屠夫) who would **extort**(敲诈) and **entangle**(使缠上) honest traders in petty schemes.

Not everything was **fair**(公平的). A **by-product**(副产品) of tourism was a flood of cheap **commodity**(日用品) stalls; an **alloy**(合金) of greed and haste, you might say. Some vendors, **lavish**(非常大方的) in promises, were less than **legitimate**(合法的), and their **etiquette**(礼节) toward the species we studied was appalling. They would pluck **cosmetic**(化妆品) shells, drag nets across the reef, and leave the **outland**(偏僻地区) fringes of the marsh in ruins. **Considerably**(相当) more troubling, a **garrison**(要塞) of developers contemplated a synthetic harbour that would obscure the wild shore forever.

My **certificate**(证书) of completion came with a **designation**(指定) I was proud of, and **freely**(自由地) I admit the **triumph**(凯旋) felt sweet. The survey would, I hoped, broaden public belief in conservation. As I packed my **jacket**(短上衣), rolled down my **sleeve**(袖子), knelt on one **knee**(膝) to seal the last crate, and signed against the **flag**(旗) of the field office, I felt the **independence**(独立) of useful labour. The **reactor**(反应堆) of my own ambition had cooled into something **serviceable**(有用的): a calm wish to **absorb**(吸收) what the world teaches and, in turn, to defend it. In his **autobiography**(自传) he made a brief **appearance**(出现) as a **vegetarian**(素食者) cook who could **envision**(想象) an entire menu from the **marrow**(髓) of a single idea. During the **snowstorm**(暴风雪) we stayed **indoor**(室内的), sipped **beer**(啤酒) and chewed **candy**(糖果), and watched the slow **upcreep**(上涨) of prices on the board. The **greenhouse**(温室) owner offered me a fair **remuneration**(酬劳) to **hire**(雇用) a guide, and with a polite **bow**(鞠躬) I accepted.

## 38. A Centenary at the Harbour Museum

The **notice**(通知) on the bulletin board was **patently**(明白地) **momentous**(重要的): our harbour town would mark its **centenary**(一百年) with a grand festival, and the new **museum**(博物馆) by the **quay**(码头) would open its doors. **So**(那么) many people had worked to **bring**(拿来) this day about that the mere **idea**(想法) of failure now seemed **outdated**(过时的). A **provisional**(临时的) committee, **active**(活跃的) since spring, had drawn up an agenda, and a cheerful **counsellor**(顾问) with a healthy **complexion**(面色) was certain everything would be **o.k.**(对)

I walked along the **gulf**(海湾) at **departure**(离开) of light, past a **tombstone**(墓碑)-grey wall and a row of **croissant**(新月形面包) shops, to **analyze**(分析) the **panorama**(全景) for the souvenir postcard I planned to sell. From the **ballroom**(舞厅) window one could **perceive**(察觉) the whole **sector**(战区) of coast: the **fishery**(渔业) boats **laden**(装满的) with the night's catch, the old **tunnel**(隧道) cut through the headland, a **brook**(小溪vt) that fed a pond fringed with **vegetation**(植). A **pedestrian**(步行者a) in a **wet**(湿的) coat paused to **applaud**(鼓掌欢迎) a street musician whose **musical**(音乐的) talent was **impressive**(给人深刻印象的), while children chased a butterfly past a **hanger**(衣架) of drying nets.

Inside, the curator showed **admission**(准许进入) to a **sufficient**(足够的) crowd. He had a **hint**(暗示) of the showman about him. In **A.D.**(公元) ninety-two, he began, a **baron**(男爵) had built the first warehouse here. He spoke of the harsh era of **imperialism**(帝国主义), of a **riot**(暴乱) and the **democrat**(民主党人) who quelled it, of a **wreck**(破坏) whose **ash**(灰) and broken **mold**(模子) still lay in the deep. A glass case held a coin, a **clasp**(扣子), a tube of antique **toothpaste**(牙膏), and an **eyeball**(眼球)-shaped lamp once used to certify cargo. The **continuity**(连续性) of these objects, he said, was an **acknowledgment**(承认) of every worker who had shaped the place.

Not all the exhibits were **peaceful**(和平的). One alcove was **particularly**(特别) grim: it depicted a **raid**(袭击) in which an opponent fleet had stormed the bay. A faded **omen**(预兆), painted on a **shilling**(先令)-sized medal, hinted at the **diarrhea**(痢疾) and dysentery that swept the garrison afterward. The **herbivorous**(食草的) deer carved into a **groove**(槽vt) of stone seemed to **swing**(摆动) between sorrow and hope, a **tinge**(淡色) of grief in their eyes.

By dusk the **vogue**(流行物) of the day had not faded. A **centrifugal**(离心的) energy pulled the crowd toward the square, where a **coach**(长途公共汽车) unloaded **baggage**(行李) for visitors travelling **westward**(向西的). Someone shouted a cheerful exhortation; another would **exhort**(劝诫) the band to play on. I **normalize**(使正常) my breathing, **pluck**(采) up courage, and stepped onto the platform. To my surprise the speech went well, **identical**(同一的) in spirit to the one I had rehearsed, **buoyant**(有浮力的) and **gratifying**(可喜的). An **applicable**(可应用的) lesson, I think, for anyone who fears a crowd: the **relief**(减轻) of finishing is its own reward, and the **avenge**(报复) of nerves is simply to begin. Far from **boring**(讨厌的), the **institute**(学会) planned to **upgrade**(升级) its **stock**(存货) of exhibits before the crowds **depart**(离开). A **positive**(确定的) **sum**(总数) of donations, free of any **opaque**(不透光的) **capitalization**(资本化) scheme, would **shelter**(掩蔽) the **synthetic**(人工合成的) models from the **remoteness**(遥远) of decay. In neat **notation**(符号) a **comrade**(同志) catalogued each **cricket**(板球)-shaped brooch in careful **alignment**(队列), and the **notional**(概念的) value, an **exporter**(出口商) once joked, lay beyond the **cave**(洞) of any vault.

### 39. The Diligent Lexicographer in the Alpine Town

It was a **frightful**(可怕的) winter when I first arrived in the **alpine**(高山的) town, and **indeed**(确实) the cold seemed to **gratify**(使满足) nothing but my growing loneliness. I had come, **increasingly**(不断增加地) certain of my plan, to compile a **best-selling**(畅销的) dictionary, for **lexicography**(词典编纂) had been my passion since my school **class**(班级) days. The **feasibility**(可行性) of the project once seemed infinite; now, **motionless**(不动的) at my desk, I would **stare**(盯) at a blank page and feel like a **victim**(牺牲品) of my own ambition.

My landlord, a **cordial**(热诚的) old **resident**(居民) with a **witty**(机智的) tongue, did much to refresh my spirits. He would **devise**(设计) small comforts: a **banquet**(宴会) of **mince**(切碎) pies, a **drum**(鼓) of **refreshment**(点心) by the fire, **honey**(蜜) for my tea. "A **pessimist**(悲观) sees only **shadow**(阴影)," he said, "but a **diligent**(勤奋的) man sees **variety**(种种)." He had **previously**(先前) worked at the **shipyard**(船坞), and the **consistency**(一致) of his good cheer, in **defiance**(挑战) of his **dental**(牙齿的) aches and frequent **headache**(头痛), was a marvel to me. He kept a **parakeet**(鸟) in the **attic**(阁楼) and a **salmon**(鲑) smoking in the shed.

Each morning I would **hike**(徒步旅行) past the **gymnasium**(体育馆) and the **memorial**(记忆的) in the **precinct**(区域) square, then **walk**(走) along a path of **flagstone**(石板) toward the lake, where the water was **navigable**(可航行的) only in summer. I learned to **bake**(烤) bread, to mince herbs, to **coordinate**(使协调) my hours so that no **fortuity**(偶然事件) could derail the work. A previously published **bulletin**(公报) had testified that the region's **economics**(经济学) depended on its **ecosystem**(生态系统), and I would marvel at how a whole **business**(商业) could **grow**(生长) from such a fragile **relation**(关系) between people and land.

The town itself was a kind of memorial to endurance. An old **uprising**(起义) was commemorated by a **plaster**(膏药) relief on the town hall; a **coin**(铸币) minted for that occasion still passed from hand to hand. The **distributor**(分销商) of the local paper, a **manly**(男子气概的) figure with the **decency**(体面) of a saint, told me that the **prevailing**(占上风的) mood after the revolt had been one of solidarity. A **chairwoman**(女主席) of the council, qualified and gracious, had backdated certain pardons so that no rebel's **remains**(剩余) went unhonoured.

My own **learning**(知识) deepened. I came to **differentiate**(区别) the **permissible**(可允许的) from the merely fashionable, and to **confront**(使面对) each doubtful entry with patience and **accuracy**(准确). When at last the manuscript arrived at completion, I felt its **meteoric**(流星的) **sweetness**(甜蜜), a **pearl**(珍珠) of effort polished over many months. To celebrate, I would **baby-sit**(看护小孩) my neighbour's child, pitch a **tent**(帐篷) by the brook, and **invert**(转化的) my old habits of worry. The **documentation**(提供文件) alone filled a tent's worth of boxes; an **enclosure**(围住) of notes, an **alarm**(警报) clock that I no longer needed, and a **sieve**(细筛) of discarded ideas. **Strange**(奇怪的) as it sounds, the work that had once seemed a **sclerosis**(医) of the mind became, in the end, the purest enjoyment I had ever known. To good **effect**(结果) I would **loung**(懒洋洋地倚) **amidst**(在) my **luggage**(行李) in the **flat**(平坦的) above the lounge and **spell**(拼写) out new entries. I **reckon**(计算) a **prerequisite**(先决条件) of the craft is patience, for the damp would **necessitate**(使成为必需) scraping **mildew**(霉) from the walls. I can **testify**(作证) that even a single **kilowatt**(千瓦) of heat helped. A **painting**(上油漆) of an **ape**(猿猴) hung crooked; whenever I would **arrive**(到达) each morning I made the same **substitution**(代替) of words and would **backdate**(回溯) my notes, and the school's move to **coeducation**(男女同校), I reckoned, had a fine effect on the town.

## 40. The Punctual Receptionist and the International Match

Today(在今天), everyone(每人) at the international(国际的) sports club knew that the chess final was imminent(迫近的). I am the receptionist(接待员) there(在那儿), a punctual(准时的) and qualified(有资格的) worker, and basically(基本上) my job is to count(数) guests, sign(记号) forms, and see(看见) that no one feels like an illiterate(文盲) outsider. There is always a chance(机会) that some(几个) workaholic(工作第一的人) designer(设计者) or a conservative(守旧的) baron will arrive late, but I dare(敢) not let the schedule deteriorate(恶化).

The champion's opponent(对手) this year was a first-rate(第一流的) proletarian(无产阶级) player from a distant commonwealth(全体国民), a man of dogged(顽固的), magnanimous(宽宏大量的) spirit. He had survived bronchitis(医) as a child, broken his femur(解) in a fall, and once seemed a victim of every misfortune. People used to suspect(疑有) his nerve would collapse(倒塌), that his form was rotten(腐烂的) and his confidence insoluble(不能溶解的). Yet he refused to dodge(躲闪) the contention(争夺); with quiet solidarity(团结一致) among his fans, he turned each match into a marvel(奇迹).

Before the storm(暴风雨) of the final, the hall was tense(时态v). I deduct(扣除) nothing from the drama when I say the air felt drowsy(昏昏欲睡的) yet electric, as if some omen hung above the platform(月台). A series(连续) of officials, diplomatic(外交的) and needful(必要的) of order, tried to clarify(澄清) the rules and modulate(调整) the rising uproar(骚动). One absent-minded(心不在焉的) count kept toying with a walnut(胡桃), while an aunt(姨母) of the champion peeled a butterfly(蝴蝶)-shaped pastry and offered it around. A premium(保险费) had been paid for the freight(货运) that brought the engraved trophy, and rejection(拒绝) of any late entry was final; the committee would shelve(置于架子上) no complaint.

The game itself was an infinite(无限的) pleasure to watch. Each player would stretch(伸长) his thinking, tense as a spring, and the stimulus(刺激物) of the clock made every move ragged(粗糙的) with risk. Protein(蛋白质) bars and luxury(奢侈) chocolates lay untouched. When the challenger forced a merge(兼并) of his rooks and a sudden sign of weakness appeared in the champion's defence, a ridiculous(可笑的), joyful uproar broke out. It was pure fun(玩笑), intelligible(可理解的) even to a kid(小孩) who had wandered in from the zoo(动物园) trip next door.

The pertinence(有关性) of the result was clear to all. The flight(飞翔) home would carry a new hero. As the players signed the scoresheet, I felt the enjoyment(享受) of an ordinary(普通的) day made extraordinary. A dependant(受赡养者) of the old champion, drowsy in his seat, woke to applaud. Some said the dynasty had ended; others insisted it had merely undergone a consolidation(团结). There was no conspiracy(阴谋), no profane(亵渎的) trick, no parody(模仿滑稽作品) of sport, only a clean victory. The motorway(汽车道) outside filled with cars, and as the pulp(果肉) of the day's newspapers spun off the presses with my photograph in the corner, I let myself, for once, simply marvel and seclude(隔离) my doubts. Because(因为) the existing(现存的) engine(发动机) could hardly(几乎不) start, we left it under a blanket(毯子) in the barn(谷仓). I would peel(剥皮) an orange and write a letter(信) in a calm voice(声音), careful not to harass(烦恼) anyone. A scientific(科学上的) spirit of stewardship(乘务员的职位) should permeate(弥漫) every page rather than leave it blank(没有写字的), yet a child's toy(玩具vi) lay forgotten where the cold would permeate the boards.

## 41. The Playwright's Exhibition

The **eminent**(著名的) **playwright**(剧作家) reached the **port**(港口) at **twenty**(二十pron) past four **p.m.**(下午), gripping a worn **purse**(钱包) and a wooden case of **cutlery**(刀具) he had bought near the **strait**(海峡). He was a **bona fide**(真诚的) artist, never a **liar**(说谎的人), though hostile critics called his prose **wordy**(冗长的) and his manner full of **conceit**(自负) and **vanity**(自大). That **so-called**(所谓的) judgment was **unwarranted**(无根据的), he thought, and it filled him with quiet **wrath**(暴怒) rather than **merry**(欢乐的) calm. He refused to **ignore**(不理) it, but he refused to let it **grip**(紧握) his heart either.

His new **exhibition**(展览会) would **depict**(描绘) the **universal**(普遍的) **battle**(战役) of people overcoming **illiteracy**(文盲), and the theme was deeply **inspiring**(灌输的). The **arrangement**(整理) of the gallery was **tricky**(巧妙的) and **involved**(涉及的): a **subtle**(微妙的) **combination**(结合) of **optic**(眼的) illusions, a model **whale**(鲸) suspended overhead, and a **microscope**(显微镜) under which visitors could watch **residual**(剩余的) crystals **shiver**(颤抖). The **exposition**(说明) panels were written in a **straightforward**(正直的), **agreeable**(令人愉快的) style. A wealthy **patron**(赞助人) had agreed to **endow**(捐款) the show and **ratify**(批准) the budget, though the final figure was still **negotiable**(可谈判的), quoted almost like a **fob**(离岸价) price at the **bureau**(署) of trade.

A **gang**(一组) of workers unloaded a **truck**(卡车) near the **warehouse**(仓库) **gate**(大门), their **marking**(唛头) pens smudging the crates. One **employee**(雇工), with **bristle**(短而硬的毛) on his chin and a **toothache**(牙疼), wiped his face with a **towel**(毛巾) to **lighten**(照亮) the mood. The **stuffy**(不透气的) hall made it hard to **breathe**(呼吸), so a **pneumatic**(空气的) fan cooled the air, raising the **tempo**(速度) of the work. The **custody**(保管) of the rarest piece, a chunk of ore that resembled **uranium**(铀) from a **refinery**(精炼厂), was handled with great **sensitivity**(敏感); its **resemblance**(相似) to a real specimen was uncanny.

After the team had to **intervene**(插入) to stop the rising **clamor**(喧闹) over an **ambiguous**(引起歧义的) label, the playwright advised everyone **directly**(直接地): do not **transgress**(违反) the rules, for any **unlawful**(不合法的) act, like the threat to **kidnap**(诱拐) a rival's idea, was simply not done here. As crowds began to **parade**(阅兵整队) and **outstrip**(超过) the room's capacity, the **increasing**(不断增长的) flow nearly overran the doors. **Pursuant**(追踪的) to the plan, guards near the **shoal**(浅滩) of visitors kept order. Later they would **dine**(吃饭) in a **mansion**(大厦), far from the **wilderness**(荒地) where he once hunted **goat**(山羊) and **rock**(岩石) pools near a passing **liner**(大客轮). A man, **prostrate**(降伏的) with fatigue but proud, he saw no **confusion**(困惑) in his life's work: **preservation**(保存) of art, free of **judicial**(司法的) dispute, was its own reward. Even the **unknown**(不知道的) future, with its **proximity**(接近) to fame, the **tennis**(网球) matches and **broadcasting**(广播节目) deals, could not lessen that **orient**(东方) pull toward truth. I **advise**(忠告) you to let curiosity **overrun**(泛滥成灾) your fear; raise a **finger**(手指) to point at every new idea, and **hunt**(打猎) for meaning the way our ancestors once did.

## 42. The Riverside Motel

It is no **myth**(神话) that the old **motel**(汽车旅馆) by the **river**(河流) was a **fantastic**(极好的) place, **eminently**(不寻常地) **lovable**(可爱的) despite its problems. Each **room**(房间) was an **oblong**(长方形) box with a **nylon**(尼龙) curtain, a single **plate**(金属板), and a **boiler**(锅炉) that would **screech**(尖叫) like **jazz**(爵士乐) when you turned the **meter**(米) past forty watts. The owner, a **clerk**(职员) with a **hairy**(毛发的) chin and **partial**(不完全的) deafness, liked to **loll**(懒洋洋地倚靠) behind the desk and **carry**(运送) on a long **discourse**(论文) about **citizenship**(公民权), **nationality**(国籍), and the **status**(身分) of every guest who would **enter**(进入).

"**Goodness**(善良), what a **treasure**(财宝) of a **county**(郡) this is," he would say, **vainly**(徒劳地) waving a **brochure**(有插图的小册子) like a **placard**(布告). He had a **mania**(医) for **psychology**(心理学) and would **allude**(暗指) to **calculus**(微积分) and **equilibrium**(平衡) as if every **problem**(问题) in life could be subdivided and solved. As an **example**(例子), he insisted that the **density**(密集) of **maple**(槭树) trees by the river was **due**(正当的) to some cosmic **policy**(政策), a **point**(尖) he made with comic **horror**(恐怖). His **argument**(争论) would **bend**(弯) and **slip**(滑) until it became **abortive**(无效果的), and the **annoyance**(烦恼) was real, yet his manner was so agreeable you could not **mock**(嘲笑) him.

A **messenger**(送信者) arrived one **March**(行军) morning, sent to **allot**(分配) rooms to a **flock**(群) of tourists. A **swarm**(一大群) of **adolescent**(青少年a) travelers began to **hustle**(奔忙) and **squat**(蹲下) in the lobby, eager to **develop**(发展) their plans. One had the **mumps**(腮腺炎); the staff feared it might **infect**(传染) the others, so they kept that **calf**(小牛)-eyed boy apart. The **conductor**(管理者) of their tour, who would **insure**(保险) the group and **entrust**(委托) their bags to a porter, asked the owner to **orientate**(向东) them. "You must **tend**(趋向) to **your**(你的) luggage," the owner said, tagging each **kilo**(公斤) of baggage as the guests would **interact**(互相作用) and trade tips.

The **alternation**(改变) of sun and rain over the river gave the place a charm that no **closedown**(倒闭) could erase. After a **mishap**(不幸的事) with a leaking pipe, the owner did not **stoop**(弯腰) to blame anyone; he simply set out a tray of **mint**(薄荷) **liqueur**(利口酒) to **tempt**(诱惑) his guests and **exhibit**(展出) his hospitality. The **dip**(蘸湿) in the road, the **large**(大的) maple shading the porch, the rare and **infrequent**(不经常的) peace of it all **comprise**(包含) a **picture**(画) I treasure. No **breach**(缺口) of trust, no **martyr**(烈士)'s complaint could spoil that **retention**(保持力) of memory. To this very day the **capability**(能力) of that humble inn to **ship**(船舶) a weary soul toward calm feels almost holy. My old **companion**(同伴) still keeps a **phrase**(短语) from that place tagged on a card: "No **watt**(瓦) of worry, no **grill**(烤架) of **fear**(害怕), can spoil a quiet river." My companion and I would grill fish on the porch each night, watching a single watt of light flicker; I learned to **subdivide**(把...再分) the bill and **tag**(标签) each item, repeating the phrase he taught me with no fear at all.

## 43. Notes from a Field Researcher

During my **first**(第一) **semester**(学期) abroad in **Spain**(西班牙), I kept a stack **of**(...的) **papers**(文件) in a **wood**(木材)-paneled **library**(图书馆), determined to **deepen**(加深) my study of human **survival**(幸存者) in remote regions. The work was **burdensome**(沉重的), yet a strange **adrenalin**(生化) kept my **pulse**(脉搏) quick. My **attorney**(律师) back home, a **haughty**(傲慢的) **Mr.**(先生) Vance, would **usually**(通常) send an **envelope**(信封) each **week**(星期) with a small **dole**(施舍品) of funds and **equivocal**(意义不明确的) advice that did little to **deter**(阻止) my **worry**(烦恼).

My **dissertation**(论文) **concerned**(有关的) the **diversity**(多样化) of communities living **southeast**(东南) and **southwest**(西南) of a **mighty**(强大的) river and its narrow **tributary**(进贡的). To reach them I would travel **rapidly**(迅速地) by **aircraft**(飞机), then **continuously**(连续不断地) by foot, carrying little more than spare **underwear**(衬衣), a **comb**(梳子v), and a **minicomputer**(微型计算机) for **warehousing**(仓储) my **reading**(读书) notes. I learned to **soak**(浸泡) dried **lobster**(龙虾), to **erect**(建立) a tent before the **lightning**(闪电a) **fell**(击倒), and to hold a **spear**(矛) without letting my **ankle**(足踝) buckle on the slope.

The elders there were deeply **versed**(精通的) in old **skill**(技能) and ritual. They would burn **incense**(香) and **preach**(传教) against any **racial**(种的) or social **taboo**(禁忌), treating **subordination**(服从) of the weak as a kind of **hypocrisy**(伪善). One **paradox**(似非而是的论点) struck me: their society had no **lock-up**(锁), no **dungeon**(地牢), yet crime was rare. A **debtor**(债务人) was never made to **lie**(躺) low in shame; instead the community offered him **remission**(免除) and a chance to **reproduce**(生殖) his standing through honest work. **Liberation**(解放), to them, was not an abstract **column**(柱) in a treatise but a daily **treatment**(待遇) of the spirit.

I watched their economy turn on a slow **axis**(轴). A **lump**(团) of **capital**(首都) might **rattle**(发出格格声) through many hands as the village pushed toward **modernization**(现代化). There was no **bottle-neck**(影响的环节) of greed, no **headlong**(头向前的) rush to **spoil**(破坏) the land. They spoke of **normalization**(正常化) not in **dynamic**(动力的) market terms but as a matter of **convenience**(便利) and balance, as natural as **magnetism**(磁). When I asked one chief, **mechanically**(机械地) taking notes, whether **masculinity**(男性) defined their leaders, he only smiled. Survival here, he said, owed nothing to a genetic **mutation**(变化) or some special **qualification**(资格). It owed everything to care. Years later, in **retirement**(退休), I still **slice**(片) that memory thin, as a **reference**(证明) and a quiet pulse of gratitude. **Beneath**(在...下边) a torn map, I would **pump**(泵) water into a tin, watch a **tear**(眼泪) of dew slide down, and store spare notes in a small **compartment**(间隔间) for safe **storage**(贮藏). No **anonymous**(匿名的) **poll**(民意测验) could capture it; people there were not **alike**(同样的), yet none would **yell**(大叫) in anger. The **transition**(转变) from one season to the next, free of any modern **syndrome**(综合病症), was as natural as a **preoperative**(外科手术前的) calm before surgery, and the gross weight of my pack, minus its **tare**(皮重), felt light against such peace. Beneath the surface of my notes lay a tear of homesickness; I would yell across the compartment of a train, alike to no one, while a poll of fellow travelers ignored me. I had to pump water into a small tank for storage, keep my anonymous identity from the preoperative clerk at the clinic, and mark the slow transition of seasons. The whole syndrome of exile, I joked, was a kind of tare to subtract before weighing what I had truly gained.

## 44. The Editor's Long Afternoon

Where(在哪) the river met a misty(雾蒙蒙的) harbor, an experienced(有经验的) editor(编辑) named Pavel sat in his cluttered workshop(车间), certain that destiny(命运) had a tricky disposition(排列). His colleague(同事), a blunt(钝的) stylist(时装设计师) with extraordinary(非常的) talent, had just quit, and the overlap(与...互搭) of their duties now fell wholly(完全地) on him. He had to trim(整洁的) a defective(有缺点的) manuscript, soften(使软化vi) its angry(生气的) tone, and somehow impart(给予) shape(形状) to a legend(传说) that wandered without any definite(明确的) ultimate(最后的) point.

The author was a senator(参议员) from Switzerland(瑞士) who liked to parade his richness(富饶) and astound(使惊讶) readers with a mosaic(镶嵌) of textual(课文的) tricks. He would quote(引用) obscure musicians, lament(悲伤) lost opportunity(机会), and confide(委托) intangible(无形的) regrets, yet his prose remained as overhead(在头顶上的) and slim(细长的) on substance as a bubble(气泡). Pavel's expectation(预期) had been modest, but even minimal(最小的) hope began to erupt(爆发) into irritation. "Why(为什么)," he muttered, "must every notion(概念) engross(用大字体书写) three pages?"

His tolerance(容忍), he admitted, had a polarity(极性): patience for genuine scenery(风景), none for vanity. He would not let the text encroach(侵占) on the reader's goodwill, nor bully(欺凌弱小者) an audience into belief. A good calculation(计算) of pacing, a fair portion(一部分) of restraint, and the usefulness(用处) of plain spelling(拼法)—these were his countermeasure(对策) against bloated drama. So he set to work. He cut a feud(纠纷) here, an offence(犯罪) there, harnessed the runaway plot, and added a farewell(再见) scene of quiet civilize(使文明)-and-reconcile tenderness.

By the time the lamp burned low, the transaction(办理) felt complete. The installation(安装) of new chapters was tenable, the availability(有效) of meaning restored. He would not boycott(联合抵制) the book, nor let theft(偷盗) of the reader's time stand. Fortunately(幸运地), the chronological(按年代顺序排列的) order now held. He logged the changes herewith(与此一道), noting each ounce(盎司) of improvement, and posted a draft to the web(网). A bruise(青肿) of doubt lingered—was it possible(可能的) he had been too soft, the negligence(疏忽) too generous?—but the irresistible(不可抗拒的) wish(希望) to be done won out. He found(建立), thus(如此), a strange peace: the founded text, once a wilderness of words, now read like a clear refrigerator(冰箱) light in a dark kitchen. He could rely(依赖) on it. He could, at last, retire(退休) to bed. Before he could turn(转动) the lamp off, though, he had to transact(交易) one more chore: he would fish(鱼) a third(第三) draft from the drawer, check that no abrogation(取消) of the old contract was needed, and believe(相信) in the work. A musician(音乐家) friend who sold ketchup(调味蕃茄酱) and petroleum(石油) stocks on the side had warned him near a supermarket(超级市场) factory(工厂) furnace(炉子) that fame was a precipice(悬崖); you could stalk(茎) it for years, find many(许多的) doors closed, and still feel the harness(挽具) of doubt. Pavel only adjusted his adjustable(可调整的) chair, tucked the manuscript under one arm(手臂), gripped it like a stalk of wheat, and smiled.

## 45. The Lexicographer's Curious Renaissance

At the old **university**(大学), a **staid**(沉静的) **lexicographer**(词典编纂者) named Mona had a **curious**(好奇的) habit: she would **inquire**(询问) into the **difference**(差别) between every pair of words, hunting for the subtle **ratio**(比率) of meaning that gave each its **useful**(有用的) shape. Her **secretary**(秘书) thought it **gossip**(流言蜚语)-worthy that a single scholar could be so **dedicated**(专注的), yet **undoubtedly**(无疑地) Mona's **affection**(喜爱) for language was **hereditary**(世袭的). Her **cousin**(堂兄弟姐妹), a **historian**(历史学家), said the family had **innumerable**(数不清的) word-lovers, **and**(和) that this passion had been a kind of personal **renaissance**(文艺复兴) for each of them.

One misty morning, **hard**(坚硬的) at work, Mona tried to **characterize**(表示...的特性) a **contextual**(上下文的) puzzle. The **foregoing**(先行的) entry, written by a careless **singer**(歌唱家) of slang, was **exaggerated**(言过其辞的) and **muddy**(多泥的), full of **cheating**(欺骗行为) shortcuts. She felt a flash of **anger**(愤怒), then a **successful**(圆满的) calm. "Be **amiable**(和蔼可亲的)," she told herself, "and **gently**(文雅地) **purify**(使纯净) the text." She would not **smother**(窒息) the author's voice, only consolidate it. The **resultant**(作为结果而发生的) clarity, she hoped, would **evoke**(唤起) a quiet **excitement**(刺激) in readers and **enlighten**(启发) them without seeming **extravagant**(奢侈的).

To **spare**(空闲的) herself fatigue she took a **snack**(小吃)—a biscuit and a slice of **camel**(骆驼)-shaped cake left over from a **matinee**(日场演出)—and glanced at the **crater**(弹坑)-like coffee stain on her **coat**(上衣). Through the window she could see the **metal**(金属) **rim**(边) of an **incinerator**(焚化装置) near the **mosque**(清真寺), **copper**(铜) pipes **catching**(传染的) the **dew**(露水), and a stray **wolf**(狼)-dog sniffing at the **crossroads**(交叉路口). The scenery, **hereto**(对此) unnoticed, gave her a fresh **impression**(印象). Even the **carousel**(喧闹的酒会) in the distant park, where **fifteen**(十五pron) children spun in merry circles, seemed to characterize the **union**(联合) of work and **peace**(和平).

Her **choice**(选择) was made. She would **marry**(结婚) precision to warmth and **excel**(杰出) where others failed. The **monetary**(钱的) reward was small; **profit**(利益), after all, was a **surplus**(余款) rarely seen in scholarship. But her **sweetheart**(心肝), a **vein**(血管)-thin **amphibian**(两栖类的) biologist who studied **ecology**(生态学) by the muddy pond, had once said something that stuck: that to **stipulate**(规定) good **hygiene**(卫生) of thought, you must **flee**(逃走) from sloppy habits. So, with a **moustache**(胡子) of chalk dust on her own lip and her **shorts**(短裤) dusted from kneeling at low shelves, she enlightened one more entry, and the **manure**(肥料) of confusion turned, at last, into clear and innumerable bloom. "**Hey**(嗨)," her secretary called, waving a roll of **microfilm**(摄), "don't **misunderstand**(误解) me, but this is **hell**(地狱) to file." Mona laughed; she would not be **unreasonable**(不讲道理的). She had once studied **Buddhism**(佛教) near a stone **pyramid**(金字塔), learning that calm takes **precedence**(在前) over **hysteria**(歇斯底里), and that a steady hand on the ship's **mast**(桅杆) matters more than panic. A **carrier**(运货人) pigeon, a **bat**(球拍) asleep **underneath**(在...下面) the eaves, a **butt**(大酒桶) of an old **whisky**(威士忌酒) barrel turned planter, the soft **recitation**(朗诵) of a poem, the delicate art of **papercutting**(剪纸艺术) she had **specially**(专门地) mastered, a single **consolidated**(加固的) note of gratitude—all of these reminded her why the work mattered.

## 46. A Disastrous Day at the Steel Mill Tower

It was a **disastrous**(灾难性的) morning along the production **line**(线). A **part-time**(计时的) clerk had left a tray of **pastry**(面粉糕饼) and **stationery**(文具) on a **quaint**(离奇有趣的) shelf beyond the **limit**(界限) of the safe zone, and **altogether**(完全) the mess seemed to **constitute**(组成) a **payable**(支付给的) fine. The **terrible**(很糟的) smell of **gasoline**(美) made everyone **struggle**(斗争). I will **illustrate**(举例或以图表说明) the scene: a **voluptuous**(艳丽的) old **steel**(钢) **tower**(塔), a cracked **vase**(花瓶) on a desk, and a **mathematical**(数学的) chart from yesterday's **reconnaissance**(探索) hanging **loose**(松的) on the wall, recording a **solo**(独奏) flight over the **mill**(磨粉机).

The foreman, a man of fierce **devotion**(献身), gave a **meagre**(瘦的) nod and turned to **blush**(脸红) at his own mistake. Once **historic**(有历史意义的) and **glorious**(辉煌的), the **windmill**(风车) beside the factory now caught only a feeble **gust**(阵风) of wind. **Henceforth**(今后), he vowed, no **perverse**(不正当的) **middleman**(中人) would handle the **eventful**(多事的) contracts; he would **withdraw**(收回) from any deal that left him unconvinced. The **cute**(可爱的) **parrot**(鹦鹉) in the office could recite an **abstract**(抽象的) phrase to **save**(救) the day, but it could not **convert**(转变) chaos into order.

**Frugal**(俭朴的) as ever, **they**(商店) decided to **better-off**(经济情况较好的) themselves through **speculation**(推测) no longer. Under the **lamp**(灯), a **buffalo**(水牛) of a worker—broad as a **turbot**(大比目鱼)—studied the **installment**(分期付款) plan. **Thereafter**(此后), the **compression**(压缩) **valve**(阀) was checked: **majestic**(宏伟的) in its **dating**(约会) from an earlier age, it held. A **prisoner**(囚犯) of routine, the **instructor**(指导者) watched the **progressive**(进步的) **consonant**(辅音) hum of machinery, a **serious**(严肃的) and **considerable**(相当大的) sound. **Tourism**(旅游事业) brochures called the place a **hindrance**(障碍) to nature, an **unacceptable**(不能接受的) scar; some thought that **absurd**(荒谬的).

The **analysis**(分析) was simple. We had **iodine**(碘) in the **prospectus**(内容说明书), **acid**(酸的) in the tanks, a **plume**(羽毛) of smoke rising past the **captive**(俘虏) birds, and a **rare**(稀有的) **federal**(联邦的) grant worth a **million**(百万). We would **install**(任命) a **cohesive**(粘合性的) **chain**(链) of safety checks on **both**(两者) ends, **asymmetric**(不均匀的) only where the **disarray**(混乱) demanded it. A **premier**(首相) engineer, **tenable**(可维持的) in his logic, would **wreath**(环绕盘旋) the old pipes in new sensors. **Approximate**(近似的) though the budget was, the **hazardous**(危险的) gaps—**attributable**(归于的) to neglect—would close. The **provision**(准备) was set; the **gradually**(逐渐地) rising confidence felt, at last, **exceptional**(优越的). I was **interested**(感兴趣的) and finally **convinced**(信服的): with **widespread**(分布广泛的) **pressure**(压) easing, our **eighteen**(十八)-person crew would not falter. A **guide**(领路人) handed me a **ball-pointpen**(圆珠笔) to sign the log, and we moved on.

## 47. A Painstaking Expedition to a Tropical Coast

It was **painstaking**(苦干) work, and a slight **fever**(发热) made the **multitude**(大批) of tasks harder. With **silky**(丝绸般的) **Mediterranean**(地中海) light on the **bank**(银行), we marked one clear **distinction**(区别): the easy days would soon **disappear**(不见). On **tiptoe**(用脚尖走) we crossed the **tropical**(热带的) sand near a **eucalyptus**(植) grove, where a **Spanish**(西班牙的) guide kept us **safe**(安全的) from a leaping **kangaroo**(袋鼠). "I **accede**(同意)," he said, pointing to a **branch**(条), "this is my **favorite**(最喜欢的人或物) spot." The **administration**(经营) had sent a **librarian**(图书管理员) to log the **futures**(期货) of the project and to **streamline**(流线型的vt) our route down the **slope**(斜线).

My **father-in-law**(岳父), watching the boats **float**(浮子) on a **rampant**(猖獗的) tide, said they would **resemble**(像), in any **atlas**(地图册), a **string**(线) of beads. We tried to **synthesize**(综合) the data, but our **clumsy**(笨拙的) **vessel**(容器) made that an awkward **attribute**(归因于). After a **barbecue**(吃烤烧肉的野餐), a wandering **toddler**(初学走路的孩子) chased a **miraculous**(奇迹的) spark of light, and the whole **group**(群), still **afloat**(航行中的), followed by **instinct**(本能). The **serpent**(蛇) coiled under a **table**(桌子) in the **garden**(园) was, the **scout**(侦察员) insisted, perfectly **viable**(能养活的) proof of a **sacred**(神圣的) local **talent**(才能) for survival.

On one **occasion**(的时刻) the **initial**(最初的) map showed a **chromosome**(生物)-shaped river; the very **being**(生物) of the place spoke of **backwardness**(落后), yet also of **insurance**(保险) against time. A long **dynasty**(王朝) had once ruled here. They could **compel**(强迫) loyalty, but a **disloyal**(不忠的) **officer**(官员) once smuggled a **narcotic**(麻醉药) past the **border**(边). Now only the **hiss**(嘶嘶声vi) of waves remained, and the **nucleus**(原子核) of an old fort. **Imprison**(关押) the past? No. As **sleet**(雨加雪) never falls here, the **inauguration**(开幕) of the new reserve felt **right**(右的).

Our **diction**(措辞) grew softer on the **deck**(甲板). A **Mexican**(墨西哥人) sailor, near the border, taught a young **eagle**(鹰) to **nurture**(养育) its first flight; we watched it **curl**(卷毛), then **loaf**(一块面包) on a warm **gloss**(光泽的表面) of rock. Like **Santa Claus**(圣诞老人) arriving early, supplies came. "Don't **bother**(麻烦)," the captain said, "just **rain**(雨) or shine, we **resolve**(决心) to go on, **discreetly**(慎重地)." The **mechanism**(机械装置) was **spicy**(加很多香料的) and strange: each **tourist**(旅游者) learned that **termination**(终止), **reliance**(信任), and **stigma**(污名) were all **salable**(有销路的) myths. No one would **jeer**(嘲笑) at the **inshore**(近海岸的) crew. **Per**(每) the manifest, every **object**(物体)—**if**(是否) **assured**(感到放心的) by **Incoterms**(国际贸易术语)—was logged. The **prominent**(突起的) result: we had made it. My own **upbringing**(抚育) had not prepared me for this, yet here I was **again**(再次), ready to **matriculate**(被录取入学) into a harder, wilder school of life.

## 48. The Composer's Symphony of Rescue

To **symbolize**(象征) the **moment**(片刻) of crisis, the **composer**(作曲家) began his **symphony**(交响乐) with a single **electric**(电的) chord, **deliberate**(故意的) and **stable**(稳定的). It was a **fact**(事实) that, a **century**(世纪) ago, a flood had forced the town to **evacuate**(疏散); the army had to **raft**(筏) people across the swollen river, **hand**(手) over hand, with a **porter**(守门人) hauling **ammunition**(弹药) and grain. A **census**(人口普查) taken that **ninety**(九十)-degree summer recorded **enormous**(庞大的) loss, and the **weight**(重量) of memory still made the **literary**(文学上的) mind shiver.

In the **sitting-room**(起居室) of his **royal**(王室的) patron, the composer found the theme **appealing**(有吸引力的). He would **weave**(织) a tale both **meticulous**(谨小慎微的) and **physiological**(生理学的), tracing how the human heart can **tickle**(挠) with hope and then **bounce**(反跳) back from despair. The **proprietor**(所有者) of the hall, an **imperial**(皇帝的) figure with **ample**(充足的) funds, offered an **invaluable**(无价的), if **impractical**(不可行的), idea: to **totally**(统统) **augment**(增加) the orchestra with a **monkey**(猴子)-bell, a **zip**(合上或打开)-like rattle, and a **sandwich**(三明治) of brass and string. The composer would not **rave**(咆哮) against it; instead he let it **conduce**(导致) to a richer sound.

A **spokesman**(发言人) read a **leaflet**(散页的印刷品) to the **patient**(有耐心的) crowd. "We **continue**(继续)," he said, "with a **competitive**(竞争的) spirit and a **vertical**(垂直的) climb toward art." The **mainstream**(主流) press, **ready**(准备好的) to **diminish**(减小) any **youngster**(小伙子)'s **career**(事业), sent a **photographer**(摄影师) to capture the scene. One critic, **lame**(跛的) in judgment, filed a **plea**(抗辩) of complaint, but the **omission**(省略) of his name from the **periodical**(周期的) was no great loss. The **overwhelming**(势不可挡的) applause would **propagate**(繁殖) the work far beyond the **pasture**(牧场) and the **daybreak**(破晓) fields.

Backstage, a **faculty**(才能) of musicians prepared. **Know-how**(专项技术) met **rumor**(传闻): was the new piece **intact**(完整无缺的), or a mere **fragment**(碎片)? They would **dilute**(使变淡) no passion. With a **thousand**(一千) candles and the **arch**(拱) of the old hall above them, they tuned. A nurse stood by with an **injection**(注射) and **tweezers**(镊子) in case the heat made anyone faint; a **burner**(灯头) warmed the tea. The **format**(格式) was clear. As the **swallow**(吞) of the first note drifted up, no one could **interrogate**(审问) its truth. This was not a **martial**(战争的) march to imprison the spirit, nor a **fool**(傻子)'s rumor to **implore**(乞求) pity. It was **rescue**(援救), set to music—a **tournament**(比赛) of feeling that, against **unstable**(不稳固的) odds, would not be lost. "Yes(是)," the composer whispered, his fingers smelling faintly of **dung**(粪) from the stable and **nitrate**(化) from the old fireworks. He would **apprize**(通知) his patron that the work, though **related**(与有关的) to an ancient **earthquake**(地震), was no **club**(俱乐部) anthem or street **slang**(俚语), but a pure **concept**(概念) of grief. The **bullion**(金块) of his fortune, a stack of **plastics**(塑料) and coins, lay forgotten on a sagging **mattress**(床垫); he had once nursed a friend through **malaria**(疟疾) here, and no critic, however cruel, would **prostitute**(妓女) that memory. He let the final note **drift**(漂流) into silence.

## 49. A Decade in the Wild Settlement

Admittedly(明白地), the repairmen(修理工) who first reached the desert(丢弃) settlement(解决) looked shapeless(不定形的) and wild(野性的) after a decade(十年) of travel. Mrs.(夫人) Olsen, a wealthy(富有的) widow with a humorous(富于幽默感的) streak, watched them stumble(绊跌) from the steamer(蒸笼) at A.M.(上午) light. She would not pretend(假装) to know their ideology(意识形态), though one was a Marxist(马克思主义的n) and another a fanatic(狂热的) for clearance(清除) and reform. They had come to commence(开始) an exploration(考察), to file(锉) a record(记录), and to escort(护卫者) a fragile peace into(到...里面) a region torn by discrimination(辨别).

The land was good and also(而且) harsh. A jungle(丛林) of vines pressed against granite(花岗岩) cliffs; a waterfall(瀑布) fed a stem(茎) of cold water past a single(单人的) granular(由小粒而成的) slope of sand. Pneumonia(肺炎) and malaria-like fever could sting(刺) a man before he could recommend(推荐) a cure. Yet the soil could bloom(花). Lemon(柠檬) and corn would suffice(足够) to feed the young(年轻的), and a beneficial(有益的) settlement might radiate(辐射) hope. The wager(赌) was extreme(极度的), the engagement(约会) indefinitely(不明确地) long.

Each morning the cooker(厨具) hissed while a monk(和尚) read from an antecedent(先行的) text, a Greek(希腊的) copy(抄本) of brittle paper, its scaly(鱼鳞状的) margins flaking like a shred(碎片) of skin. He would mumble(咕哝) a warning(警告), weigh(称...重量) his words, and spit(吐) out a serene(宁静的) blessing. Discipline(训练) held the camp together. To quit(离开) was to lose(丢失); to abort(异常中断) the mission would betray the dead. So they would follow up, immature(不成熟的) as the plan seemed, and try(尝试).

By night, mammals crept near—a pig(猪) rooting at the fence, a beast in the brush, a butchery(肉食店) of small game for the pot. The men wore a sock(短袜) over each knob(圆形把手) of frostbitten toe and a sheet(被单) for a blanket. One sat on a saddle(马鞍), biscuit(饼干) in hand, and endorsed the plan with a single word: "Sodium(钠)," he joked, "keeps us alive." The brash(仓促的) sexuality(性欲) of youth had cooled into a passable(过得去的) patience. The mass media(传媒工具), far away, would later inflate the tale into a flammable, inflammable(不易燃的) myth, but the truth was a crease(折缝) in the map, a pile(堆) of ten(十pron) letters home, and ourselves(我们自己), changed forever. The penetration(穿入) of the wilderness, the brightness(明亮) of a new dawn, the saddle and the twig fire—these made the cancellation(删除) of an old life into a quality(质量) beginning. We said good-bye(再见) to who we were, and began. A Japanese(日本的) doctor joined us later, carrying medicine(内服药) and a small brass pendulum(钟摆) he would swing to calm his nerves; he taught us the prefix(前缀) "anti-" for every septic(腐败的) wound, and warned that an untreated cut could leave nothing but a skeleton(骨骼). No mammal(哺乳动物) in that wild place was safe, he said, so we agreed to endorse(背书) a strict follow-up(后续) routine and check each other daily.

## 50. Intuition Against the Illusion

My **intuition**(直觉) warned me before any **answer**(回答) came. The **punctuation**(标点法) of the email was too perfect, an **illusion**(幻象) of authority wrapped in fine **apparel**(衣服). I **detest**(厌恶) fraud, and this **memorandum**(备忘录) reeked of it. It promised **electricity**(电) contracts in **Germany**(德意志) and **Denmark**(丹麦), a **tonic**(激励的) for any **prospective**(预期的) **income**(收入), with a **proxy**(代理人) who would **collect**(收集) the **overpayment**(多付的款项) and **implement**(工具) a **reform**(改革) of our **taxation**(税制). **Hereof**(在本文件中), it said grandly, we may **begin**(开始) a **noble**(高尚的) **course**(过程).

**Well-known**(有名的) crooks rarely **uncover**(揭开) themselves so plainly. The **majesty**(雄伟) of the letterhead—a **crystal**(水晶) seal, an **oval**(卵形) crest, the **aristocratic**(贵族的) flourish of a **learned**(博学的) hand—could not hide the **harassment**(折磨) beneath. **Out**(出去) of **ignorance**(无知), our junior clerk had nearly answered. I told him to **relax**(松弛), **hesitate**(犹豫), and never let **cohesion**(凝聚力) of grammar persuade him. **Persuasion**(说服) is not proof. A **phobia**(恐怖病) of missing out is what these monsters feed on.

I **fancy**(颜色鲜艳的) myself careful. I made an **enquiry**(询问), took a **transcript**(抄本) of the call, and asked the bank to **rescind**(退还) the transfer. The trail would **expire**(满期) in hours, so I did not dawdle. The **friction**(摩擦力) of doubt is healthy; let it **shrink**(收缩) the fancy schemes to nothing. To **acquaint**(使熟悉) a team with the **manner**(方式) of such **betrayal**(背叛) is the best **disinfectant**(消毒剂). **Observation**(观察) beats trust.

That night a **thunderstorm**(雷雨) rolled in. **Rainfall**(下雨) hammered the **vineyard**(葡萄园) on the **cliff**(悬崖); **hail**(冰雹) drummed the **boot**(靴) of my car. A **fox**(狐狸) darted across the lane and a **macaque**(短尾猿)-like shadow—surely my own nerves—made me **roar**(吼叫) with a nervous laugh. The **negation**(否定) of the scam felt like a **straighten**(把...弄直vi) of a bent spine. I would **foretell**(预告) more attempts, for these spirals of greed never truly **disarm**(解除武装). They **drip**(滴下), they **boost**(增加), they **evaporate**(使蒸发), and return.

The **sparse**(稀少的) facts were these: a **finicky**(过分注意的) **farmer**(农民), a **precarious**(不稳定的) deal, a **triangular**(三角的) web of shell firms in **metallurgy**(冶金学) and **corn**(谷物). **Either**(也pron) we accumulate proof or we lose. **Whoever**(谁) wrote it had a **chalk**(粉笔)-dry heart. I lit a cigarette with a **twig**(细枝) of dry pine, watched the **oscillation**(摆动) of smoke **spiral**(螺旋形的) upward, and felt the **depress**(使沮丧) lift. The **accumulation**(积累) of small vigilance, I decided, is what keeps a finicky world honest. **Lipstick**(唇膏) on a pig is still a pig; a polished lie is still a lie. I shall not be the fool. Good night, and beware. A **Chinese**(中国的) proverb says greed is a **monster**(畸形的动植物), a hungry **beast**(兽) that no **pot**(罐) of gold can fill. Honesty is **indispensable**(必需的); it is the **trend**(倾向) that outlasts every scam. I aired the whole story at a public **airing**(晾干), and even an old **negro**(黑人a) jazz musician at the club nodded in a slow **dance**(舞) of agreement. Vigilance is the **parachute**(降落伞) that saves you; trust in safe **transportation**(运输) of your money, never a stranger's promise, on any **snowy**(雪的) or sunny day.

## 51. A Village at the Crossroads

The **origin**(起源) of our **small**(小的) village can be traced to a **noted**(著名的) **blacksmith**(铁匠) who, in a **forthcoming**(即将出现的) age, chose to **lodge**(临时住宿) beside a busy **intersection**(数) where two **European**(欧洲的) trade routes would **concur**(同地发生). Long before any **ruler**(统治者) tried to **conquer**(征服) the region, a **pious**(虔诚的) **Christian**(基督教的) **minister**(照顾) and a hardy **tradesman**(商人) settled here, and their **amicable**(友好的) **deal**(处理) shaped everything that followed. On **scorching**(灼热的) afternoons the fields **ripen**(使熟) quickly, and a **bold**(大胆的) **squirrel**(松鼠) will dart across the road at exactly five **o'clock**(点钟), as if it must **obey**(服从) some private **logic**(逻辑). **Above**(上述的ad) the intersection stands an old signpost where people of every **race**(赛跑) once paused. In **advance**(前进) of the harvest, the village gathers the **material**(材料) for a festival and arranges a wide **range**(排列) of stalls. Life here is rarely **humdrum**(单调的), though it can seem **casual**(偶然的) to a visitor. A **documentary**(文献的n) **speaker**(说话者) once called the place a **remnant**(残余) of old **idealism**(唯心主义), yet the people are **realistic**(现实的) and **businesslike**(事务式的). They **depend**(取决于) on the **bounty**(慷慨) of the land, deal fairly with every **purchaser**(买主), and never **maltreat**(虐待) a **tenant**(承租人). When the morning **chime**(一套发谐音的钟) rings, dew will **glisten**(闪光) and **quiver**(颤动) on the **lily**(百合) leaves, while the **mangrove**(植) down by the inlet seems to **protrude**(突出) from the **transparent**(透明的) water. My uncle, a retired **sportsman**(爱好运动的人), keeps an **oil**(油) lamp with a cracked **lid**(盖) and a worn **sponge**(海绵) on the **brim**(边缘) of the windowsill. He is a man of **decided**(明确的) opinions and will **anxiously**(焦急地) **circulate**(循环) any forthcoming news. **Bless**(求上帝赐福于) this house, he says, and may God keep **disaster**(灾难), **danger**(危险), and **homicide**(杀人) far from it. He distrusts the **craziness**(疯狂) of the city, the **troublesome**(令人烦恼的) **tactics**(策略) of speculators, and any **lucrative**(有利的) **ploy**(策略) that smells of fraud. **Lest**(惟恐) the family lose its **tranquility**(宁静), he stays **vigilant**(警惕着的). One **plaintive**(悲哀的) evening an **absent**(缺席的) neighbor returned wearing a heavy **overcoat**(外衣), as if for an **adventure**(冒险). He had ridden a **locomotive**(运动的) across half of **Greece**(希腊) and **India**(印度), and he spoke **evenly**(一致地) of the **prevalence**(流行) of poverty he had seen, of an **inmate**(同住者) who was wrongly jailed, and of a **philosophical**(哲学上的) **dramatist**(戏剧家) whose plays could **maim**(使残废) a proud man's pride. He set his **outfit**(用具) down by the **vacant**(空的) chair, smiled, and asked us to **excuse**(原谅) his dusty boots. A **corporation**(市镇自治机关), he said, had tried to **nominate**(提名) him to **terminate**(终止) a contract, but he would not **act**(表演) against his conscience. The words friend and foe are **antonymous**(反义的), he reminded us, and **stupidity**(愚蠢) often hides behind a **barricade**(设路障) of clever speech. As the **bunk**(铺位) creaked and the fire's **flush**(脸红v) faded, we sat together; the talk blessed us all the same, evenly warming the long, mild night.

## 52. The Cooperative in the City

Adolescence(青春) is a momentary(瞬息间的) layer(层) in the long bulk(容量) of a life, yet it can foster(养育) habits that last worldwide(全世界的). My research(研究) into one city(n. 城市) cooperative(合作的) began with a kind(仁慈的) waitress(女侍者) named Vera, a willing bread-earner(挣钱养家的人) who had survived a childhood of strife(争吵) and severe(严厉的) want in a leaning shack(小室) near the inlet(水湾). She spoke of that natal(出生的) place without nonsense(胡说), in coherent(一致的) and completely(十分) calm sentences, though the memory of calamity(灾难) could still make her voice fade(褪色). As a baby(婴儿) she had been carried, the family said, almost from the womb(子宫) into chaos(混乱); communism(共产主义) had collapsed, and the respective(各自的) duties of each adult fell on the least(最小的) likely shoulders. Vera refused to discriminate(区别) against anyone, and she would not coerce(强制) a soul. Her especial(特别的) gift was patience. Behind the cooperative stood a noted gallery(画廊), and across the park(公园) a janitor(看门人) swept the steam(水汽) from a hot recipe(烹饪法) stove(炉子) while a salesman(售货员) polished a trademark(商标) sign. The whole place teemed with life: a wasp(黄蜂) circled a glass of lemonade(柠檬汽水), a doll(玩偶) lay in a closet(小储藏室), and somebody(某人) had left a notebook(笔记本) open on a valued(宝贵的) antique desk. Vera was engaged(占用的) in a worldwide trademark dispute, a heavy liability(责任) she handled with hardy(勇敢的) good humor, for she knew even the wisest are fallible(易错的). She would repeat(重复) her vow(誓约) each morning: do no harm(伤害). The reliability(可靠性) of the small shop depended on her, and her absorption(吸收) in the work was complete. The potential(可能的) of the venture was real, the velocity(速度) of its growth surprising, and a fair evaluation(估价) found its proprietorship(所有权) sound. A cooperative spirit, she liked to say, can inject(注射) hope into the most secular(长期的) and earthly(世俗的) routine. On Sundays a Buddhist(佛教徒) neighbor and a defiant(无礼的) young engineer would roam(漫步) in from the tree(树)-lined street, willingly(乐意地) sharing fried pumpkin(南瓜) and a kind word. The spectator(观众) could see how the city was being regionalized, how conservation(保存) of the old fort(堡垒) and its inlet had become a cause. Yet a penalty(处罚) hung over the project: a momentary lapse in funds could terminate it. Once, snatching a tail(尾巴) of bad news off the wire, Vera felt a flare(熊熊燃烧) of fear, like an ulcer(溃疡) waking. A policeman(警察) came; a manacle(手铐) of red tape threatened to bind the venture. But the engineering(工程学) held, the electronics(电子学) worked, and the appropriate(合适的) papers were signed. Hitherto(到目前为止) the place had merely survived; now, the meeting(会议) agreed, it might truly thrive. Nothing earthly is permanent, Vera admitted, but a habitable(可居住的) corner of kindness is worth any cord(绳) of effort. A local writer(作者), whose chief concern(影响) was to regionalize(使区域化) the old recipes, came to a public hearing(听力); he watched the fields undulate(波动) in the wind, saw boys sprint(疾跑) after a football(足球), and would fry(油煎) pumpkin while a child clutched a doll with deep attachment(连接物), refusing to let anyone snatch(夺) it away.

## 53. The Archaeologist on the Brink

Shortly(立刻) after dawn, the cloudy(多云的) sky promised more bad weather(天气), and the rise(升起) of the sea(海) against the medieval(中世纪的) wall made the whole dig feel accidental(偶然的), even doomed. Our team of archaeology(考古学) students had to recognize(认出) that the project stood on the brink(边缘) of disaster. The persistence(坚持) of one entrant(进入者), a resolute(坚决的) woman who(谁) could memorize(记住) every longitude(经度) and meteorology(气象学) chart off-hand(立即), kept us going. She would not default(拖欠) on her promise, nor revert(回复到) to despair. "Optimism(乐观) is a kind of potion(一服)," she remarked with quiet daring(大胆的), "and stupidity its allergy(反感)." Who could contradict(反驳) her? She arranged the disposal(处理) of the loose pottery(陶器) shards with optimum(最适宜的) care, smelling each for the faint smell(气味) of old glue(胶), and sorting them into a neat tetrad(四个) on a flat cork(软木) board. An owl(猫头鹰) watched from a shadowy(有影的) fig(无花果) tree as the morning light began to emerge(出现). The legendary(传说的) catastrophe(大灾难) that had buried this town was no idyll(田园诗): an explosion(爆炸) of the nearby volcano, accordingly(相应地), had crumpled its octagon(八边形) temple like paper. We could still see the dent(牙) where a falling beam had struck, the eddy(旋转) of ash that froze mid-swirl, and a remnant of a cherry(樱桃)-wood saw(锯子) left by a worker who fled in desperation(绝望). There would be no congratulation(祝贺), no easy deduction(推断), until the correlation(相互关系) between the layers was proven. A speculator(投机商) had once tried to commercialize(使商业化) the site, his fraud(欺骗) a kind of burglary(盗窃) against history; we opposed him at the rendezvous(集合点) point and forced him to default. The increase(增加) in tourists soon brought distraction(分心). One man, full of make-up(气质) and chic(别致的款式) clothes, kept a mug(大茶杯) of alcohol(酒精) at his side and would haggle(争论) over every artifact; his short-weight(短装) scales and I/c(信用证) documents were plainly suspect, and a prohibition(禁止) was quickly issued against him. He(他) aggravated everyone, yet we did not let him disturb the work. By till(直到) and trowel we proceeded, our thinking(思想) sharpened by hardship. Quite(十分) suddenly the persistence paid off: an entrant brushed aside the dust and a carved face seemed to convince(使信服) us, as if to consultation(咨询), that the ancient Jew(犹太人), the dictatorship(独裁) that ruled here, the long ordeal(严酷的考验) of its people, were all real. The enhancement(提高) of our records was immediate. We felt a flame(火焰) of pride. Specialized(专业的) scholars would study the find extensively(广泛地), and any conceivable(可能的) doubt about the town's population(人口) would, at last, be laid to rest. Working outdoors(在户外) at speed(速度), we would not aggravate(使恶化) the fragile site nor crumple(弄皱) a single record; archaeology was our true occupation(占领), and we would oppose(反对) any destructive(破坏的) scenario(想定). With calm poise(平衡) I made one final remark(评语), refusing to implant(灌输) false hope: no handcuff(手拷) of regret(遗憾), no rotten potato(马铃薯) of doubt, would slow us now.

## 54. A Pilot's Choice

The **captain**(首领) of the **airline**(航线) had to **opt**(选择), in a **tight**(紧的) moment, between two airline options, and he could not **omit**(疏忽) a single **specific**(明确的) factor from his calculation. A **gigantic**(巨大的) storm sat across the **transverse**(横切的) path of the **rocket**(火箭)-fast jet, and **aviation**(航空) rules urged caution. He would not **deny**(否认) the danger, nor **despise**(轻视) the **eager**(渴望的) **hopeful**(给人希望的) crew who depended on him; instead he chose to **assert**(维护) command **firmly**(坚定地). "Pick(拾) the **secluded**(隐退的) northern route," he said, and the **prompt**(迅速的) order left no room for **inattention**(疏忽). A **magician**(魔法师) of the cockpit, he kept his **elegance**(优雅) under stress, even when a **tiny**(极小的) warning light made the panel glare. The **producer**(生产者) of a documentary, who sat in the **ward**(病房)-like rear cabin near a **fixed**(固定的) **stool**(凳子), had asked to film him; the **commentary**(注释) would later **emphasize**(强调) how a **reliable**(可靠的) professional behaves when a **mate**(伙伴)'s life is the **case**(箱) at stake. **Apart**(分离) from the danger, the flight was a **classic**(第一流的) of routine. The **associate**(把...联系在一起) captain, a **keen**(锋利的) and **masculine**(男性的) man who despised laziness, made a quick **subtraction**(减法) of fuel against distance and slid a **slide**(滑) rule across the desk. A sudden **urge**(催促) to act seized him, so he urged the trainee to memorize the figures, then to **fathom**(领会) the deeper logic behind them. "Wherein(在何处) lies our safety?" he asked, like a **monarch**(帝王) posing a riddle. "In the **option**(选择) we **forgive**(原谅) ourselves for not taking, if it would maim the plane." A **dozen**(一打) lights illuminated the dark. The **phonetic**(语音的) alphabet crackled over the radio; a **printout**(计) of the new **decree**(法令) from control spat from the **tube**(管) of the **tape-recorder**(录音机) beside the keyboard. The pilot did not **cough**(咳嗽), did not **nap**(小睡), did not let his mind **haunt**(常去) old fears. He situated the aircraft above the worst of it, thickened his focus, and let the captain's voice **murmur**(低沉连续的声音) its calm. A **foe**(敌人) of panic, he treated fear as a **tonne**(公吨) of dead weight to be cut loose. When at last the runway lights rose to greet them, a single tear seemed to **heal**(治愈) an old wound. The **translation**(翻译) of all that training into one safe landing was, the producer admitted, no mere **joke**(笑话); it was the **forefront**(最前部) of a noble **profession**(职业). He would not **plagiarize**(剽窃) another man's courage. He had his own, and it was specific, eager, and entirely his. His **uncle**(伯父), **himself**(他自己) a **highly**(高度地) trained **fighter**(斗争者) and once an **adversary**(敌手) of careless flight, would **speak**(说话) of **education**(教育) as the one thing no **mischance**(不幸) could **destroy**(破坏). He kept a **fitting**(适合的) **portfolio**(部长职务), a **rectangle**(矩形) of worn leather, and would **oversee**(俯瞰) every detail **but**(但是) never **disturb**(打扰) the crew. **She**(她), a **stationer**(文具商)'s daughter who ran a small **bookstall**(书报摊), would **situate**(位于) herself near the **dwelling**(住宅) and **illuminate**(照亮) the cabin with a lamp; the smell of **benzene**(化) could **thicken**(使变厚) the air and bring a wave of **nausea**(恶心) that made a man **groan**(呻吟), and a **rat**(鼠) once gnawed a **cartridge**(弹药筒) **wrapper**(包装纸) to shreds. He urged caution, called any **deletion**(删除) from the checklist **unfit**(不合适的) and reckless, and would **stick**(棍) to procedure.

## 55. Restoring the Old Quarter

To **announce**(正式宣布) the festival, the **headmaster**(校长) of the village school stepped to the **microphone**(话筒) under a **mild**(温和的) evening **sky**(天空). He meant to **inaugurate**(为...举行就职典礼) a long **pilgrimage**(朝圣) of work and to **fast**(快的)-track the repair. This was only the **prologue**(序言): the old **slum**(陋巷) quarter, **unlike**(不同的) anything **marketable**(有销路的), would **undergo**(经历) a complete renewal. A **surveyor**(调查人) had filed a **factual**(事实的) report, and his **pertinent**(贴切的) notes, written in a neat **indent**(缩行), listed every **breakage**(裂口), every **hollow**(空的) beam, every **plug**(塞子) torn from the wall. The **aggregate**(共计) cost made the treasurer **sigh**(叹气), but civic **brotherhood**(兄弟情谊) **compels**(强迫) generosity, and the **overall**(包括一切的) mood was **placid**(平静的) rather than **hysterical**(歇斯底里的). The headmaster, **fluent**(说话流利的) in the town's history, would not **abruptly**(突然地) abandon a single **delinquent**(拖欠的) debt; the **cause**(原因) was too dear. A **workman**(工人) in a **woollen**(羊毛制的) cap and worn **sneakers**(旅游鞋) arrived by **taxi**(出租汽车), his tool **belt**(带) heavy with each **vital**(生命的) **instrument**(工具). He would **rake**(耙子) the **swamp**(沼泽地) behind the houses, **batter**(连续猛击) down the rotten fence, and reset the **ornamental**(装饰的) **engraving**(雕刻) that once marked a **feudal**(封建的) estate. "We must not **delay**(耽搁)," he said **heartily**(精神饱满的), taking a **mouthful**(满口) of **almond**(杏仁) cake and a sip of fresh **juice**(汁). "A **wasteful**(浪费的) **half**(半)-measure would only **threaten**(恐吓) the street." An old woman would **knit**(编织) woollen scarves while young men found **backing**(倒退) for the project, and a curious dog would **sniff**(嗅...味道) at the wet paint. The **revelation**(显示), when it came, was **credible**(可信的): beneath the **colorless**(无色的) plaster lay a **fat**(多脂肪的) seam of old tile, an **article**(物品) of real beauty. People came to **participate**(参与); the lane began to **teem**(大量出现). Children would **squeal**(长声尖叫) and a cart would **clatter**(得得声) past, while a **barber**(理发员) set up near the **exit**(出口) and a **sandy**(沙的)-haired girl planted a single **sunflower**(葵花). **Approximately**(近似地) a **degree**(程度) of order returned each day. **Censorship**(审查) had once erased the **corruption**(腐败) of the old rulers, but the quarter now rose to a new **pinnacle**(小尖塔). The change felt almost **instantaneous**(瞬间的). No **invoice**(开发票) could measure it. A passing **warship**(军舰) sounded a **signal**(信号), as if to **herald**(传令官) the rebirth. The **logistics**(后勤学) were **intricate**(复杂的), the **figurative**(比喻的) weight enormous, yet the people were **bound**(跳跃前进) to finish. That night a tired **performer**(执行者) strummed on a **cosy**(舒适的) **sofa**(长沙发), **sharply**(锐利地) aware that the **clam**(蛤)-shut secret was gone. A couple just back from their **honeymoon**(蜜月) joined in. The mayor, **overjoy**(使大喜) in his eyes, offered the lowest **bid**(出价) and signed. The schedule had **probably**(或许) slipped a little, and no one wished to be **behindhand**(落后), but the renewal was **very**(很) real, and to **reflect**(反射) on it was to feel, for one mild instant, at home.

## 56. The Auction at the Old Mall

On a **black**(黑的) winter morning the **auction**(拍卖) began, and a **tedious**(沉闷的) **apprehension**(理解) hung in the air like smoke from a **chimney**(烟囱). The **challenge**(挑战) for every **gambler**(赌徒) in the room was plain: **define**(给...下定义) a fair price, **yet**(还) not let **petty**(小的) greed **perpetuate**(使永存) a foolish bid. A **pioneer**(先驱) of the **trade**(贸易), a **candid**(坦白的) **physician**(医生) turned dealer, stepped to the **fore**(在前面). "I will not **cheat**(欺骗)," he said with **emphatic**(强调的), almost **macabre**(恐怖的) calm. "Nor will I **criticize**(批评) a rival, for that would only **entail**(使必需) **disgrace**(失宠)." The **mall**(购物商场) was old; its **durable**(耐用的) beams had begun to crack, and the **maintenance**(维修) bills threatened to **abolish**(废除) any profit. **Stagnation**(停滞), not **malignant**(恶性的) scheming, was the true foe. A **baroness**(男爵夫人) in a silk **blouse**(女衬衣) made a **declaration**(宣言) that her **ability**(能力) to pay was beyond question, and her **allied**(联合的) friends, **fortunate**(幸运的) in trade, embraced the idea with no opposition. The **assumption**(假定) was that the **percentage**(百分数) of buyers would **remain**(剩下) high. To **proceed**(进行), the auctioneer rang a small bell that seemed to **jingle**(丁当响) and chime at once; the durable **gauge**(标准尺寸) of a sale, he liked to say, is whether the crowd will **endure**(忍受) to the last lot. A **pungent**(刺激性的) aroma of **bitter**(有苦味的) **ale**(淡啤酒) and **pen**(钢笔) ink drifted from the back, where a **laborer**(劳工) mopped the floor. "This is no joke, yet I feel no **anxious**(焦虑的) dread," murmured a fore-thinking man, candid in his **estimation**(估算). He would not **dwell**(居住) on **sarcasm**(讽刺) or **metaphor**(修辞); he would simply bid. The **outcome**(结果) of the **bidding**(投标) would **transform**(改变) the whole street. A **rational**(有推理能力的) mind, not **extravagance**(奢侈), must rule. "We are on the **verge**(边缘) of something," said the physician, rapping a **screw**(螺丝) against the **kettle**(水壶) for quiet. The **middle**(中间) rows, fortunate and alert, leaned in. **Civic**(市的) pride did not **interfere**(干涉) with commerce here; rather, the two were **coincident**(一致的). A petty quarrel over a candid remark nearly flared, but the dealer's even **temper**(脾气), his refusal to **disdain**(蔑视) anyone, kept the peace. He would not **cling**(抱紧) to a single **set**(一套) of china, nor let a sharp tongue maim the mood. The **cabbage**(洋白菜)-seller next door, a tradesman of long **history**(历史), watched through the **express**(表达) glass. When the final hammer fell, the **store**(商店) changed hands. The **reaction**(反应) was loud; people clapped, the chimney smoked on, and the long, durable day proceeded to its quiet, fortunate end. Yet, even then, the **dumb**(哑的) relief in the room said more than any speech. As long as honest trade could remain, the old mall would not be cheated of its future. To **narrate**(叙述) the day's lesson in plain **Latin**(拉丁的) and English alike, under no real **stress**(压力), the auctioneer stressed each **step**(步) with almost **adverbial**(副词的), **extremely**(极端) deliberate care. He refused to **undercharge**(索价低于常价) or to write a bad **cheque**(支票), for the **toll**(通行税) of honest trade was patience, and any **delinquency**(过失) would only **embrace**(拥抱) ruin. The **internationalization**(国际化) of the market did not frighten him; a **furious**(狂怒的) bidder, full of nervous **cleverness**(聪明), might **gnaw**(啃) his pen, but as **undersigned**(在下面签名的) witness he would calmly **feed**(喂养) the ledger, **mop**(墩布) his brow, and explain how an **enzyme**(生化) or an **electron**(电子) means nothing to a man who cannot **pollinate**(对) trust into a deal.

## 57. The Sociologist's Journal

Really(确实), the wonderful(惊人的) schedule(时间表) of a working sociologist(社会学家) is less(更少的) glamorous than a thriller(惊险小说) would suggest. Each morning I open my journal(定期刊物) and easily(容易地) outline(提纲) the day's tasks; the work is solely(单独地) mine, and personally(亲自) I find that clearly(明白地) comforting. My optional(可以任选的) reading includes a dense treatise(论文) and a long bibliography(书目), for I aspire to lengthen(使延长vi) my understanding of how an ethnic(人种的) community keeps its stability(稳定). Something(某事) about the aroma(芳香) of old paper, like a faint aerosol(浮质) of dust, makes me eager to study. I diagnose(诊断) social trends the way a physician studies a virus(病毒) or a staphylococcus(微生物) under glass; the validity(有效) of any claim depends on data, not on a premature(早熟的) guess. There is real ambiguity(模棱两可) in human attitude(态度), and a homogenous(同质的) sample can hide more than it shows. Last week I had to convene(召集) a small symposium and arbitrate(仲裁) a dispute; the regime(政体) of polite debate kept tempers from making the room escalate(逐步升高) into chaos. One aristocrat(贵族), an industrious(勤劳的) millionaire(百万富翁) who had emigrated young, spoke with modesty(谦逊) about his contribution(贡献) to industrial(工业的) reform. His attitude was advantageous(有利的) to all. A princess(公主) of an old ethnic line told a romance(传奇) worthy of a melodious(音调优美的) ballad, and her aural memory was phenomenal(显著的). We exchanged views; nor(也不) did anyone repudiate(拒绝接收) the others. I keep a keyboard(键盘vt) and a printer(印刷工) ready, and my repertoire(节目) of methods is wide. When the aggressive(侵略的) questions came, I did not pant(气喘) or peep(偷看) nervously; I answered with control(控制). The pension(养老金) reformers wanted to escalate spending; the treasurer(司库) urged restraint. I.e.(那就是), the demand(要求) was clear but the strength(力) of the budget was not. A spatial(空间的) map of the city, looped with red string, showed where dependence(依靠) on aid was high. We schedule a follow-up, and the equation(等式) of needs and means stays unsolved. A crab(螃蟹)-shaped diagram, drawn off-hand, made the crew(全体船员) laugh. Toil(辛劳工作) though it is, the pursuance(追求) of truth is nice(美好的) work; the contribution feels permanent. By noon a cloud(云) crossed the sun, and the loop(环状物) of talk closed. I sail(帆) home, eager for supper, my reflection(映像) in the train window calm. A premature conclusion would endanger(危及) the whole study, so I write only what I can defend. The tragedy(悲剧) of bad research is that it looks tame(驯服了的) until it engulfs a policy. So I sing(唱) no false praise; I record, I reflect, and tomorrow I begin again. I would not concoct(调制) data, nor exchange(交换) truth for a neat story; that presumption(假定) would be unthinkable(不能想象的). A young trainer(教练), who hoped to emigrate(移居国外), brought a packet(小包裹) of mustard(芥子) seeds and a wreath(花环) of dried herbs as a gift. We did not bump(撞击) heads over the adverb(副词a) in a sentence or the hormone(荷尔蒙) in a sample. A sudden crack(裂缝) of thunder seemed to engulf(吞没) the room; one nervous student had almost a seizure(强占) of doubt, but I urged him to squash(压碎n) his fear, to treble(三倍的) his effort, and to dig in his heel(脚后跟). No one would hijack(劫持) the seminar with profuse(极其丰富的) complaint.

## 58. Night Shift at the Planetarium

At **zero**(零) hour the **steward**(乘务员) of the **planetarium**(行星仪), a **meek**(温顺的) and **sane**(健全的) man named Otto, climbed the **staircase**(楼梯) to begin the night **watch**(观看). **My**(我的) job was to **review**(回顾) the dome's optics before the morning crowd, and **beforehand**(预先) I had to **evaluate**(估...的价) every wire, **plus**(加) the spare **cassette**(磁带盒) and the **loudspeaker**(扬声器). The **theme**(题目) of the new show was **mankind**(人类)'s long **pursuit**(追赶) of the stars, a **typical**(典型的) **narration**(叙述) that would **build**(建造) slowly toward awe. Otto, a **bilingual**(能说两种语言的) **preacher**(鼓吹者)'s son who had once aspired to **study**(学习) **physics**(物理), liked to **deem**(认为) the cosmos a kind of **church**(教堂). "**Seriously**(严肃地)," he said, his face beginning to **glow**(发出光和热), "to **occupy**(占) your mind with the **sun**(太阳) and the **volcano**(火山) of a distant star is the **sole**(单独的) cure for **despair**(绝望)." He would not **subscribe**(捐款) to **fright**(恐怖); **darkness**(黑暗), to him, was merely the **margin**(空白) where light begins. We worked **systematically**(系统地). A **glare**(眩目地照射) from a loose lamp made me **alert**(机警的), and I marked it on the margin of my notebook with a quick **xerox**(用静电复印) of the old wiring plan. Otto fetched **oatmeal**(麦片) and **spice**(香料) tea from the **bakery**(面包店) downstairs, and we shared a **bare**(赤裸的) supper near the **playground**(运动场) window. He spoke of his **grandmother**(祖母), who in August would **leap**(扑向) from her chair to greet the first cool wind, and of a **wounded**(受伤的n) **patrol**(巡逻) soldier he had once nursed, a **follower**(契据的附面) of an old **prophet**(预言家) whose **commandment**(称赞) was simple mercy. "**Anyway**(不管怎么说)," he said, "**opinion**(意见) divides mankind, but the sky unites it." There was no **compromise**(妥协) in his faith, no **opposition**(敌对) he could not meet with a quiet **quash**(取消) of doubt. A **pistol**(手枪) hung, disarmed, in a glass case by the **pharmacy**(药房) sign downstairs, a relic of a darker decade when an **ally**(同盟者) and a foe had patrolled these streets and the **slaughter**(屠宰) of **feudalism**(封建主义)'s last war had filled the wards. Otto deemed such firearms an **impossibility**(不可能性) for a planetarium; he had argued the point with **rigor**(严格) and won. Now a **gymnast**(体操运动员) practiced on the lawn at dawn, a postman cycled past, and the only siren was the soft hum of the projector. By **thirty**(三十) minutes past dawn the optics were clear. Otto signed the log with my pen, took his pension card from his coat, and smiled. "**Permanently**(永久地)," he said, "this is the best post a man could ask." Outside, the **radiation**(放射) of the rising sun lit the dome. I cashed no praise from him; his quiet **cooperation**(合作) was payment enough. The **container**(容器) of old slides went back on the shelf, and the **lenient**(宽大的), **ego**(自我)-free man went home to **write**(写) his diary by lamplight. **Oh**(嗨), how Otto loved a good **symposium**(讨论会)! An **expert**(专家) on old instruments, he would **aspire**(热望) to teach any **user**(用户) who came to the planetarium's **guesthouse**(宾馆). He wore a soft **flannel**(法兰绒) coat against the **rheumatism**(风湿病) in his knee, and he played **gaily**(华丽地), like a boy at **basketball**(篮球). The **consumption**(消费) of power, he noted, was barely an **ampere**(安培); the **computer**(计算机) logged each reading, and an old **telex**(用户电报) still clattered in the office. 'No army could **invade**(侵略) this peace,' he said, dressed for his **hundredth**(第一面) night shift. The **palatable**(美味的) supper, the **cash**(现金) in the till, the strong **connection**(联系) between teacher and star — he would not **dispose**(处理) of any of it.

## 59. The Successor at Willow Farm

In **recent**(新近的) years Willow Farm had fallen into a **depressed**(情绪低落的) **condition**(条件), and I returned as its reluctant **successor**(接替的人或事物) after the **expiration**(期满) of my grandfather's long lease. The **premises**(建筑物) were vast, half a **panoramic**(全景的) valley reaching to the **horizon**(地平线), where at **noon**(中午) a **metallic**(金属的n) **blaze**(火焰) of sun lit the old grain **dome**(圆屋顶). I had once aspired to **resign**(辞职) from farming altogether; a **patriotic**(爱国的) uncle scoffed at that **preference**(偏爱), reminding me that a **teenager**(十几岁的青少年) who flees the soil is led **astray**(遗失). So I stayed. The **aforesaid**(上述的) grandfather, in his last **term**(期) of **mourning**(哀痛) for my grandmother, had kept a **legible**(清晰的) diary whose every line a **translator**(译音) could read. He wrote with **courtesy**(礼貌) and never a **rude**(粗鲁的) word; he would **greet**(致敬) each **sheep**(羊) by name and **behave**(举动) toward every **diver**(潜水员) who came to clean the well with a **hospitable**(好客的) patience. He scorned **laziness**(懒惰), yet showed no **scorn**(轻蔑) for honest **exhaustion**(用尽). One **ought**(应该) to **repay**(偿还) the land, he liked to **dictate**(听写), or be banished from it. I was **certain**(某) the work would be **complicated**(结构复杂的). A recent **drought**(干旱) had defiled the lower field; the **inorganic**(无生物的) salts had risen in a slow **flux**(流) to the surface, leaving an **infinitesimal**(无穷小的) metallic crust. With meticulous care I would **drill**(钻) new wells, **fetch**(取) water uphill by **traction**(牵引), and **grant**(同意给予) the bushes time to recover. I kept a **duplicate**(完全一样的) of every **sales**(销售adj) record on a **board**(长木板), legible and exact, lest some **inconsistency**(不一致) or **inaccurate**(不精密的) figure send the accounts astray. By **August**(八月) the farm began to **sustain**(支撑) itself. We canned **pickle**(腌制食品) and **soy**(酱油), and a **tentative**(试验性的) **concert**(音乐会) of birds returned to the **bush**(灌木) at dawn, an **aural**(听觉的) **accompaniment**(伴侣) to the morning **service**(服务) of chores. I felt a **cramp**(抽筋) in my **breast**(胸膛), not **trauma**(医), but the **educational**(教育的) ache of real labor. My **flexibility**(柔韧) improved; my **foot**(脚) found firm traction on the muddy slope. A **crook**(钩子) of willow served as my **cradle**(摇篮) for the lambs. I was **able**(有做某事) to **discharge**(卸货) the old debts after a good harvest, and an **extension**(延长) of credit, secured against the aforesaid premises, gave me a financial **cushion**(垫子). Each dawn I tied a **mask**(面具) against the dust and watched the **downward**(向下的ad) slope of the field catch the first light. There was no **firearm**(火器) on the premises and no **siren**(警报声) in the valley, only the **plural**(复数的n) hum of bees. I learned to **discern**(看出) the **spot**(斑点) where **deviation**(背离) from routine would cost a harvest, and I refused to let any rude visitor **defile**(染污) the work. An **opal**(蛋白石) of dew sat on each leaf at dawn. **Halfway**(半途) through the season, **rich**(富的) with a quiet pride, I no longer felt **regretful**(遗憾的). The **punishment**(罚) of doubt was lifted. This land, I reiterated to myself, was **instrumental**(仪器的) to **whom**(谁) I had become; and I, its grateful successor, would never again behave as one led astray. I bit into a ripe plum at noon and called it good. I would **stay**(逗留) through every storm, **meticulously**(胆小地) checking each fence; a single **bite**(咬) of doubt I would **banish**(流放) at once. Let the cynics **scoff**(嘲笑) — I **reiterate**(重申) that this land made me.

## 60. The Coastal Fortress and the Coral Reef

By **December**(十二月) the old **coastal**(沿海的) **fortress**(堡垒) had lost much of its **popularity**(通俗性), yet a **select**(选择) group of scholars still made the journey **across**(横过) the bay **to**(到) study it. I went too, immersing myself in its history. The **chief**(领袖) **counselor**(顾问) of the **municipal**(市的) heritage board, a **notable**(值得注意的) **scholar**(学者) of **slight**(轻微的) build and **stern**(严厉的) manner, met our **train**(列车) at the station and led us **aside**(在旁边) to a **quiet**(安静的) **parlor**(客厅). Over **supper**(晚餐) of **pork**(猪肉) and **vinegar**(醋) he offered an honest **appraisal**(评价) of the site. "Tourism here has begun to **dwindle**(缩小)," he said **aloud**(出声地), with a **sluggish**(行动迟缓的), almost **sleepy**(想睡的) regret. "Our **earnings**(工资) shrink each year, though the **asset**(资产) is **splendid**(壮丽的)." He was **reluctant**(不愿的) to let the place **forever**(永远) fade. To revive it, he had organized a **brainstorm**(灵机一动) with local makers and merchants, hoping some **incentive**(刺激) would draw **people**(人们) back. The fortress sat on an **acre**(英亩) of high ground, its chambers carved with the **regular**(有规律的) patience of long-dead masons. From the topmost **chamber**(房间) a panoramic view opened to the horizon; at **twilight**(曙光) the **sunlight**(日光) struck the sea with **optical**(光的) splendor, and far below, an **Arabian**(阿拉伯的)-style dome marked an old chapel of **Christ**(基督). A **neat**(整洁的) **shelf**(架子) of rock dropped to the coastal shallows, where a living **coral**(珊瑚) reef teemed with organisms. With **ventilation**(通风) shafts cut through the thick walls, the fortress had once been a true asset of defense; now its deep **tank**(罐) still held rainwater, and a **strand**(股) of old rope, knotted at intervals, hung from the wall like a relic. "People once feared this was a **fake**(假货) ruin," the counselor said, "a clever **maker**(制造者)'s forgery sold to gullible tourists. But the **index**(索引) of every stone, cross-checked against the December archives, proves it genuine." He spoke with no **haste**(匆忙). A **leopard**(豹), he joked, had more patience than a committee, and a **feather**(羽毛) weighed more than the average official's promise. We must **ensure**(确保), he said, that no **outlaw**(被剥夺公民权者) or speculator be allowed to strip the reef or fence the land. He had been a diver in his youth; he could still discern, from the **take-off**(起飞) of a startled fish, exactly where the **strap**(带) of a tourist's camera had snapped and sunk. **Morality**(道德) and good **seniority**(资历), he believed, were the true **means**(方法) of preservation. As the **airplane**(飞机) of a distant patrol droned overhead and a faint siren sounded from a **clinic**(诊所) in the town, he reminded us that even a regular season of decline need not mean **degradation**(降级). **Acidity**(酸度) in the water, a **transformer**(变压器) humming on the cliff, a **sixty**(六十)-year-old map curling at the edge: each was part of a fragile whole. He asked us to **mind**(精神) the place, to **respond**(回答) to its quiet call, and to feel the **deeply**(深深的) rooted, **inveterate**(根深的) love a **Brazilian**(巴西的) sailor once carved into the stern of a wrecked ship near here. The **shipwreck**(船舶失事), he added, lay just past the **navel**(脐) of the bay, its **animation**(生气) long stilled. I left at noon, my **curriculum vitae**(履历) of memories richer by one fortress, certain the **unjust**(非正义的) neglect of such a place was a thing we ought, with **auxiliary**(辅助的) effort, to end. The **postman**(邮递员) waved as our train pulled away. With **thanks**(感谢) to the old counselor, we would **share**(分配) his vision. He spoke **about**(在周围) the fortress as an **organism**(生物), not **merely**(仅仅) a ruin, and his **aptitude**(才智) for history was plain. A **lark**(云雀) sang from a low **bough**(树枝); the morning had the air of a **theatre**(戏院) before the curtain. To **immerse**(沉浸) a **school**(学校) of young students in such a place, he said, takes real **exertion**(尽力), yet it is no rare **occurrence**(发生) in a region of such depth. He tied a quick **knot**(绳结) in the rope and smiled, free of any **depression**(消沉).

## 61. The Chemistry Teacher's Odyssey

Frankly(坦率地), my previous(先前的) chemistry teacher seemed insane(疯狂的). On a quick(快的) Wednesday(星期三) morning he would burst into the classroom(教室) wearing baggy(袋状的) trousers(裤子), his spirit(精神) bright, ready to give(弹性) a lesson that felt like an exciting(令人兴奋的) odyssey(长期的冒险旅行). He had to acquire(获得) his teaching licence(执照) only after a perennial(四季不断的) struggle, yet he taught with precision(精确). He explained that hydrogen(氢气), the predominant(主要的) element in the universe, could fuel(燃料vt) stars effectively(有效地), and that ammonia(氨), lethal(致命的) in high concentration, was harmless(无害的) when diluted in a watery(水的) solution.

He loved to refute(反驳) lazy thinking. 'Memorize the actual(实际的) data, not a nominal(名义上的) approximation(近似值),' he said resolutely(坚决地), tapping the window pane(窗格玻璃) with a spoon(匙). He told us, with no contemptuous(轻视的) tone, that atomic(原子的) mechanics(力学) was not insane magic but careful note-taking(笔记). He warned that an impetuous(冲动的) experiment could deform(损坏...的形状) the apparatus or, moreover(加之), pour(灌) toxic sediment(沉淀物) into the school sewer(下水道).

His backstory was an odyssey worthy of an immortal(不朽的) soul(灵魂). Before teaching, he had been a pilot(飞行员), then briefly an infantry(步兵) officer who resolutely refused a fascist(法西斯分子) order and was detained for it. He realized then that real courage was harmless to others and protective(保护的) of the weak. That single sentence(句子) shaped his perennial longing(渴望) to teach.

On weekends he ran a small farmhouse(农舍) beside a paddock(小牧场), where migratory(迁移的) birds and a slow tortoise(龟) shared the foliage(叶子). He grew celery(芹菜), kneaded dough(面团) for bread, and fed meat(肉类) scraps to his dog. He liked to inscribe(记下) a clever line of poetry on each loaf. His kidney(肾) trouble made him perspire(出汗), but he never complained of agony(极度痛苦).

The local pharmaceutical(药物) boom(发出隆隆声) had once tried to lure(引诱) him toward profit, yet he felt that knowledge, universally(普遍地) shared, mattered more than ownership(所有权) of a patent. He believed every child held vast potentiality(潜在性). 'Don't be suspicious(可疑的) of curiosity,' he urged, lighting a torch(手电筒) of inspiration that would brighten(使发光) any dull mind. He taught us sportsmanship(体育精神) in sport(运动运动会vi), the precision of seismic(地震) measurement, the geometry of a three-dimensional(尺寸的) model, and even how detergent(清洁剂) cleans a watery confluence(汇合) of grease.

When a nominal voter(投票人) complained, the principal had to restock(重新进货) his patience and detain(耽搁) his temper. In our province(省), people would dub(电影) him eccentric, but he would persist(坚持). Each spring he watched buds burgeon(嫩芽) in the paddock and feel(触) the quiet joy of growth, and at dusk he would shut(关) the heavy door, content. The ceremony(典礼) at year's end was popular(流行的): seven(七) students, prior(较早的) doubters, stood up. We came to reasonably(合理地) realize(认识到) that a teacher many called a maniac(发狂的) had given us, with violent(猛烈的) enthusiasm, the foundation(基础) of our lives.

## 62. The Village Journalist at Easter

As a **journalist**(新闻工作者), I never let **any**(什么) deadline **constrain**(强迫) my curiosity, so one **dreary**(沉闷的) **Easter**(复活节) I set out to a remote **frontier**(国界) village to write more than an **incomplete**(不完全的) **novelette**(中篇小说) about rural life. Frankly, I was an **outsider**(局外人), a city **walker**(步行者) among farmers, but the people did not treat me with **stiff**(坚硬的) suspicion.

My host, a **faithful**(守信的) **Englishman**(英国男子) who had studied **geography**(地理), served a **beautiful**(美的) **breakfast**(早餐v) of **bacon**(咸肉) and eggs. He would not **barter**(货物交换) or(或) **override**(制服) my plans; instead he would **suggest**(建议) a gentle route along a **steep**(陡峭的) **ridge**(脊). 'Take(拿取) your time, do(做) **everything**(每件事) **quickly**(快) only when you must,' he said, and I had to agree his **propriety**(适当) was charming. He kept a tidy **database**(计) of every **productive**(能生产的) harvest, written by hand on a **slate**(板岩).

We walked past a quiet **pond**(池塘) where a **hedgehog**(刺猬) rustled through the reeds, and an army of ants marched in **accord**(相一致) across a stone. A single **reed**(芦苇) bent in the wind, and one stray **ant**(蚁) climbed the slate **counter**(柜台) by the door. The damp air made my **asthma**(医) flare, so I had to **exert**(发挥) myself to keep pace. A nervous **child**(小孩) would **fidget**(坐立不安) and **growl**(嗥叫) playfully near a **cage**(鸟笼) that, **presently**(一会儿), held nothing but a **battery**(电池)-powered toy. With a sudden **burst**(爆裂) of energy he would **satisfy**(满意) his urge to run. I **bet**(打赌) the boy had once tried to **construct**(建设) an **interplanetary**(行星间的) rocket from a soup can and a **muffler**(围巾), and his only **justification**(辩护) was a child's wild dream.

The local **greengrocer**(蔬菜商), who liked to **engrave**(刻上) his name on each crate, explained the **characteristic**(特有的) **odour**(气味) of the marsh, where **biodegradable**(生物所能分解的) leaves decay. **Secondly**(第二), he warned that the old bridge was **fragile**(易碎的), its timber left in **abeyance**(缓办) for repair. A **burglar**(盗贼) had once tried to **chip**(片屑) away its lock, a **mistake**(错误) that earned him the village's contempt.

There was a **similarity**(类似) between this **hillside**(山腰) hamlet and a **stronghold**(堡垒) of an earlier age, though its **shortcoming**(短处) was poor roads. To **uphold**(支持) tradition, the people would not **corrupt**(腐败的) the simple life with **gloom**(黑暗) or greed. An **average**(平均) family here measured wealth not per **capita**(人) but by the warmth of **matrimony**(结婚) and the **heave**(用力举起) of honest labor. They could **put**(放) a worn **lathe**(车床vt) to work, repair a **bumper**(缓冲器), or fix any household **appliance**(用具).

In the cool air I could feel my **respiration**(呼吸) steady. I tried to **maximize**(增加到最大程度) my notes, to **abbreviate**(缩写) nothing of value, with great **emphasis**(强调) on the small **nicety**(美好) of daily kindness. The trust I would **accrue**(产生) here, I decided to **designate**(把...定名为) as the real reward of the trip. A **beginner**(初学者) photographer would have struggled, but I, no longer **shy**(怕羞的), captured the morning **condensation**(凝聚) on a windowpane and the **tip**(尖端) of dawn on a **different**(差异的), distant peak. By the time I returned, I felt satisfied: an **atom**(原子) of truth, designated as my finest story, had been found. My mild asthma did not flare, and I did not need to exert myself to satisfy the editor; at the kitchen counter I watched a single ant cross the wood while a sudden burst of laughter filled the room. Even the **experiment**(实验) of leaving the comfortable **suite**(套间) behind, with its faint chemical odour, had been worth the **noise**(喧闹声) of the road.

## 63. The Detective and the Widow's Manor

The case began, as so many do **now**(现在), with a **leak**(漏洞) of **obscene**(淫秽的) rumors. A **respectable**(可敬的) **merchant**(商人) had died, leaving behind a **grave**(严重的) estate and a sorrowful **widow**(寡妇) who would **frown**(皱眉) at any mention of his name. As the **author**(作者) of this account, a private **detective**(侦探) by trade, I **should**(应该) **pinpoint**(精确) the truth and not **evade**(规避) the harder questions.

I took an **inland**(内地的) **detour**(绕道) to the old manor, which sat at the **entrance**(入口) of a quiet **valley**(谷) where wildflowers seemed to **abound**(多). The house was a **maiden**(少女) fortress of stone, ringed by a wooden **fence**(篱笆), with a **crimson**(深红色) door that shimmered at dusk. A statue stood on a marble **pedestal**(基架) in the garden, an **eccentricity**(怪僻) of a **forefather**(祖先) who had once served in the **kingdom**(王国)'s **army**(军队) and even spoken before **congress**(代表会议).

Inside, the widow sat folding **tissue**(生理组织) paper, her movements **ephemeral**(朝生暮死的) and nervous. She did not **consider**(考虑) me an enemy. 'Whatever(无论什么a) you find, I will not **defy**(违抗) the law,' she said, lighting a **cigarette**(香烟) though she knew **smoking**(抽烟) troubled her **fitness**(适当). I declined her offer; I **owe**(欠债) my health to clean lungs. On the table lay a **binding**(装订) **contract**(合同) and an unpaid **grocery**(食品杂货店) bill that hinted at looming **bankruptcy**(破产).

The local **inspector**(检查员), a man of great **proficiency**(熟练), had filed a hasty **diagnosis**(诊断): the merchant's death was natural. But the **probability**(可能性) of coincidence felt thin. I would not **sympathize**(同情) with laziness. With careful **effort**(努力) I examined the **remainder**(剩余物) of the documents, and a **buzzword**(强意词) in the **new**(新的) ledger caught my eye: 'hotelling(旅馆业),' a fashionable scheme that had drawn the family into **discord**(不一致) and debt.

In the cellar I found a **trench**(沟) dug near the foundation, as if for a **demolition**(拆除), and traces of an **alkali**(化) **secretion**(分泌) staining the **earth**(地球). A **beautician**(美容师)'s vial, a **burnt**(烧焦的) match, a fishing hook meant for **carp**(鲤鱼) — each clue pulled me into a **vortex**(旋涡) of suspicion. The maid, on **probation**(试用) for a minor theft, had been **passionate**(多情的) but loyal; her **vulnerability**(易损性) made her an easy scapegoat. I refused to **denounce**(谴责) her without proof.

By the **writing**(写) of my final report, the **manifest**(明白的) truth emerged: a cousin, facing **imprisonment**(监禁) for fraud, had returned from the **Occident**(西方) to seize the inheritance. He had been **lewd**(淫荡的) in life and ruthless in greed, no better than a poacher who would **cap**(便帽) a man's days for **wealth**(财富). Yet justice, **sweet**(甜的) and slow, found him. I **congratulate**(祝贺) no one for such grim work, but at the **fulfillment**(完成) of the case I felt, for one **quarter**(四分之一) of an hour, almost as light as a child at a **skating**(滑冰) rink, or a sailor who believes a **mermaid**(美人鱼) truly does **exist**(存在) beneath the waves. I set down my **arms**(武器), my **hoe**(锄地) of inquiry, and a **choir**(唱诗班) of relief sang in my tired mind.

From the **beginning**(开始) I had sensed a **psychological**(心理的) pattern: greed tends to recur with alarming **frequency**(频率), an **epidemic**(流行性的) of the soul that no **restorative**(有助于复元的) tonic can cure. The merchant's **offspring**(子孙后代) would now **reside**(居住) elsewhere, and I hoped the lesson would **reinforce**(加强) their better instincts. As I stood to leave, I let my hand **brush**(刷) the cold stone wall and watched the lake **shimmer**(微光) one last time. The **generous**(慷慨的) widow pressed a folded note of thanks into my palm; I did not unfold it, but I would not **fold**(折叠) under guilt either, for I had done my duty and would **stand**(站立) by every word.

## 64. Backstage Before the Revolution Play

The **theory**(理论) behind a great **rehearsal**(排练) is simple, yet the actual work is **messy**(肮脏的). On a cold **Paris**(巴黎) **evening**(傍晚) just before **Christmas**(n . 圣诞节), the **entire**(完全的) **personnel**(职员) of our small theater gathered to **remove**(移动) the dust from an old **framework**(构架) of a stage set. We had a **war**(战争) drama to perform, set during a **revolution**(革命), and the script demanded precision.

The **senior**(年长的) director, a **rigid**(僵硬的) man with sharp **insight**(洞悉), refused to **overestimate**(过高估计) our readiness. 'Hopefully(可以指望),' he said, 'we will not have to **cancel**(删去).'

His **objective**(哲) was clear: a flawless **collection**(收藏) of scenes. He would not **pardon**(原谅) a single dropped **word**(词). When a junior actor began to **brag**(吹嘘) about his talent, the director gave him an **ironic**(说反话的), almost contemptuous glance, and the young man's confidence began to **droop**(下垂).

Backstage smelled of **rubber**(橡皮), fresh **grain**(谷物) stored in the corner, and the faint **moisture**(潮湿) of a leaking **pole**(极) near the **cabin**(船舱) door. A **pet**(爱畜) **sparrow**(麻雀), **familiar**(熟悉的) to us all, hopped along a **thread**(线) of light. Someone had to **stir**(搅拌) the glue and fix the **rickety**(医) props, which were **imperfect**(不完善的) and **somewhat**(有点儿) **unsatisfactory**(不能令人满意的). We had to **accumulate**(积累) patience; the holdup over a missing **jewel**(宝石) nearly drove us insane with a **tumult**(骚动) of complaints.

My own **specialty**(特性) was **insulation**(隔离) and lighting — the **analogue**(类似物) dials, the **radar**(雷达)-like dimmer, the **booth**(有篷的售货摊) where I sat. I felt **dizzy**(眩晕的) from the long hours, my eyes ready to **upset**(使...心烦意乱) into sleep. The **chorus**(合唱) rehearsed in the **northern**(北方的) wing while a **fatuous**(愚昧的) critic from a **marine**(海的) journal made a fatuous, **insipid**(没有味道的) remark and tried to **disclaim**(放弃) any earlier praise. I did not **grieve**(悲痛); I simply marked his **mannerism**(特殊习惯) in my notes and moved on.

There was always **intrigue**(阴谋) among the cast. The **housekeeper**(看门人) alleged that the lead actress, who played a **commander**(司令官), had been detained at a **hold-up**(停顿) on the **highway**(公路). A **jury**(陪审团) of gossips formed at once. In **compliance**(遵守) with the rules, I crossed to her dressing room to check. She was fine, only fatigued, and grumbled about a **sporadic**(零星的) — sporadic — headache and the **dirty**(弄脏的) mirror. (Even now I correct my own spelling.) Her **subliminal**(下意识的) fear of failure was, frankly, the only real **desolation**(荒凉) in the room.

When at last the curtain rose, all our **relaxation**(放松) vanished. The **execution**(实行) was nearly perfect. Not one **litre**(公升) of effort was wasted. The audience, **twentieth**(第二十)-century skeptics though they were, sat in **opportune**(及时的) silence. No **ghost**(鬼魂) of doubt remained. A **robbery**(抢劫) of nerves had given way to triumph, and even the ghost of stage fright, that old **junk**(垃圾) of the mind, melted like a pet in sunlight. We had subordinated our pride to the play, and the **dream**(梦) we shared made every senior and beginner among us feel entire.

Afterward, over a quiet **vacation**(假期), I would **unfold**(展开) the whole **organizational**(组织的) story. The play depicted a peasant **lieutenant**(陆军中尉) who raised a **sickle**(镰刀) as a banner and refused to be a **subordinate**(下级的) to tyranny. Some critics would **allege**(宣称) that the script romanticized war; that was, I admit, a fair **correction**(改正) to make. We were no **boss**(老板)-driven machine; **thrift**(节约) in budget had brought the set to a near **standstill**(停顿) more than once. One actor battled **alcoholism**(嗜酒者) and would **cross**(十字) himself before each scene, his face pale beneath the red **pigment**(颜料) of his makeup. Yet it was **TRUE**(真实) art. We even avoided the **demurrage**(滞期费) charge on our rented props by returning them early. When the final **pop**(流行的n) of the closing firework faded, I knew the correction of every flaw had been worth it.

## 65. A Letter on Coastal Forestry and Family

My dear **grandson**(孙子), I **maintain**(维持) that you should **plan**(计划) to visit before **late**(迟的) autumn. The **prospect**(景色) of showing you our **peninsula**(半岛) is too **obvious**(明显的) a joy to give up. Let me, in my **curly**(卷曲的) handwriting, paint the **home**(回家) you have not seen.

From the **bottom**(底) of the hill you **ascend**(渐渐上升) a **roundabout**(迂回的) path **until**(直到...为止), at **midday**(正午), the **sixth**(第六) bend reveals the sea. Our **neighboring**(邻近的) **forestry**(林业) station sits **upon**(在...上) a ridge, and beyond it the bottomland is so **vulnerable**(易受伤的) to flooding that engineers had to **dredge**(挖泥机) the channel and **run**(奔) a **parallel**(平行的) canal. I once worked as an **engineer**(工程师) there, before I became a humble **client**(顾客) of the local **government**(政府) and a **beneficiary**(受益者) of its pension.

The people here are **persistent**(持久稳固的) and full of **perseverance**(坚持). They **educate**(教育) their children **well**(好); **comprehension**(理解) and good **orientation**(方向) toward work are valued more than wealth. **Furthermore**(而且), they keep a quiet **conformity**(遵照), though no one is **truant**(逃避者) from honest labor. I will not **misrepresent**(误传) them: a few are **jealous**(妒忌的), a few **mediocre**(普普通通的), and one **bizarre**(奇异的) old miser even tried to **defraud**(欺骗) his own **affiliate**(使隶属于) over a tiny **inventory**(详细目录) of **borrowings**(借款). The **malpractice**(玩忽职守) was obvious, and the **announcement**(通知) of his guilt brought a **sensational**(轰动的), almost **dramatic**(引人注目的) stir. Frankly it was a **grim**(严酷的), **sultry**(闷热的) scandal, and **absolutely**(完全地) no one will **entitle**(给题名) him to forgiveness.

I must not **detract**(降低) from the beauty, though. At dawn a **husky**(谷的) fisherman taps on my pane to sell **rice**(稻) and fresh fish on a **dish**(碟子). A **caterpillar**(毛虫) inches across the **hearth**(壁炉地面); a curly **napkin**(餐巾) of mist wraps the bay. I **electrify**(充电) the lamp, fold a **charter**(宪章) map, and feel the **fibre**(纤维) of contentment. The **childish**(孩子的) part of me still longs to chase the **migration**(迁移) of birds, to watch them **recur**(一再发生) each season and **congregate**(聚集) over the **pit**(坑) where the old **grease**(动物脂肪) pump rusts.

There is a **fault**(缺点) in my health, I confess. A persistent **pathos**(痛苦) has settled in my chest, and the **bilateral**(有两面的) ache will not **fulfil**(完成) any promise of recovery. The fault is not grim enough to grieve over. I refuse a **stereotype**(印) of the lonely old **philosopher**(哲学家); I am no **gullible**(易受骗的) fool. A **volt**(伏特) of energy still runs through me when I **contact**(接触) old friends by **airmail**(航空邮件) or **tape**(带), or when the **liaison**(联络) officer from the conservatory sends an **inadequate**(不充足的) but kind note.

Yesterday's **newspaper**(报纸) carried an **enlargement**(扩大) of an old photograph, its **color**(颜色) faded, showing a **band**(条) of fishermen near the **prison**(监狱) wall by the harbor's **opening**(口). The sight did **overwhelm**(使受不了) me; **afterward**(后来) I sat in silence for a **feminine**(女性的), gentle hour, not worth a single **penny**(便士) of complaint, until the urge to **command**(命令) my own grief returned. Do not let **dissimilar**(不同的) opinions detract you, nor let any **bourgeois**(资产阶级的) pride beneath your years **protract**(延长) your decision. Some call the journey roundabout; I call it worthy. Come, and we will misrepresent nothing, only sit by the hearth and talk well into the sultry, grease-scented night. Your loving grandfather.

## 66. From a Mule Path to the Stars

Whence(来处) comes the human urge to explore? Every explorer(勘探者), from the rural(农村的) shepherd who once drove a stubborn mule(骡子) along a stormy(有暴风雨的) mountain passage(通过) to the modern astronaut(太空人), shares one robust(强健的) mentality(智力): the longing to escape(逃跑) the known zone(地区) and touch(触) the unknown. I propose(提议) we test(试验) this idea by following a simple(简单的), dramatic story.

A notorious(臭名昭著的) miser(守财奴) of a village, a superstitious(迷信的) man accustomed to counting every penny, once mocked a young boy who read journalism(新闻体) by candlelight and kept a glossary(词汇表) of difficult words. The boy was no ordinary child. Often(常常) he would lean(倾斜) over an editorial(社论) about France(法国), about a centennial(百年纪念) celebration of flight, and dream. His parents had to wean(使断奶) him from idle play, but his intelligence(智力) was remarkable(不平常的), his oral(口头的) fluency(流利) elegant(雅致的) beyond his years.

At boarding school(寄宿学校) the boy learned the formulation(明确的表达) of nutrition(营养), the chemistry of nitrogen(氮) and aluminum(美), and how a polymer(聚合物) could be shaped into a functional(功能的) prototype(原型). He studied the concentric(同中心的) rings of a thermal(热的) engine and the way a single ray(光线) of light behaves. A reasonable(明智的) teacher helped codify(编码) his scattered notes. He would not discard(抛弃) a half-formed idea; instead he would repair(修理) it, refine it, and excite(刺激) his audience(听众) with the result.

Years later, after a painful layoff(临时解雇) from a pricing(定价) office where a cruel deed(行为) and a corporate prosecution(起诉) had soured the mood, he turned to research. Financing(金融业) was thin. He sent a hopeful telefax(传真), then waited a single minute(分钟) that felt like a misery(痛苦). The outlay(费用) was huge, the malady(病) of doubt real, and a slow(慢的) microbe(微生物) of fear gnawed at him. Yet his perseverance did not fail.

He joined a federation(联邦) of scientists at a conservatory(温室) of technology, where, in observance(遵守) of strict safety, they would chop(砍) and weld metal, fend(保护) off every illogical(不合逻辑的) objection, and cultivate new design. They printed a bold slogan(标语) above the door and held a ballot(选举票) to name their first rocket. The cultivation(耕作) of patience was undue(过分的) but necessary. A languid(疲倦的) afternoon could turn into a stormy night of work.

At the centennial gala, before a vast audience, he stood beneath a banner near a mock throne(御座) built for the ceremony. The newspaper called the launch an exquisite(优美的) triumph; the prize(奖赏) was his. He had once gutted a tuna(金枪鱼) for supper and watched a rooster(公鸡) crow at dawn on a rural farm; now he would help(帮助) send a craft beyond the reach of any mortal(必有一死的) limb(肢). The insertion(插入) of his small spacecraft into orbit deafened the crowd with cheers. Before that day he had to accustom(使习惯) himself to long nights at a coastal camp(野营), riding a battered moped(机动脚踏两用车) past the docks where nautical(船员的) charts and a rusty razor(剃刀) lay forgotten. No external(外面的) pressure, no salutation(致敬) of doubt, could deafen(使聋) the steady tenor(限期) of his resolve. He felt no guilt(罪过) for the effort it took to generate(使产生) one new idea, and he was as gentle as a gorilla(大猩猩) guarding its young. Whence the urge? From the simple, restless heart that refuses to agree(答应) that the sky is a ceiling. To preserve(保护) that fire, we must educate every dreamer well.

## 67. The Statistical Clown and the Circus Lobby

When(何时) the circus(马戏表演) came to our town, it brought more than a lion(狮子) and an acrobat(特技演员). It brought a statistical(统计的) puzzle that would test my knowledge(知识). I am a linguist(语言学者) by training(训练), but my favour(亲切) leans toward any topic(话题) that lets me speculate(推测) freely, and I welcome(欢迎) the chance to trace(痕迹) a strange story to its end.

The lead clown(小丑), a lively(活泼的) and talented(有才能的) man, had once been a powerful(强大的) seaman(海员) before a sinful(有罪的) gambling habit destined him for ruin. He would divert(使转向) his remorse(懊悔) into performance, and the audience adored him. Practical(实行的) and plentiful(富裕的) in jokes, he could make even the most ashamed(羞愧的) child laugh until the noise seemed to elevate(提升...的职位) the whole tent. Yet behind his painted smile lurked a remorse no birthday(生日) could heal.

There was an embargo(禁止贸易), of sorts, on his past. He would not speak of the gaol(监狱) where he had served time, nor the daze(耀眼) of those(那些) forbidden(禁止的) years. A scornful(蔑视的) rival accused him under a flimsy pretext(借口), hoping to subsidize(资助) his own act by ruining another's fate(命运). The complication(复杂化) grew dense(浓密的). People in the lobby(门廊) would lean in and remind(提醒) one another of old rumors, untold(未说过的) and incredible(不可相信的), whereby(凭什么) a man's reputation could burn(燃烧) to ash.

I decided to salvage(抢救财货) the truth. From the basement(底层) of the town hall, a damp room that smelled of iron(铁) and old timber(木材), I dug out records. The mode(方法) of the old prosecution was clear: a fountain(泉水) of false statements, a resonant(引起共鸣的) lie repeated until it seemed true. The man was no devil. As a youth he had studied horticulture(园艺) and the distillation(蒸馏) of fragrant oils; he knew geology(地质学), kept bees, and could denominate(为命名) every(每一个的) plant by its Latin name. He had simply erred once and paid dearly.

The circus, meanwhile, had to unite(联合) its scattered tribe(种族) of performers. A pygmy(侏格米人) juggler, a refugee(避难者) acrobat, and a donkey(驴子) trainer from a distant bay(海湾) all relied on the show. Their global tour — they liked to globalize(使全球化) their art — would collapse if the lobby gossip continued. The manager, a man of significant(有意义的) patience, tried to pacify the crowd. He had a disciplinary(纪律的) meeting, a resonant statement(声明), and a single goal: to rid(使摆脱) the troupe of slander.

Before the final act, I climbed to a small observatory(天文台) above the market(集市) square to clear my head, mailing a note in a manila(马尼拉) envelope addressed c/o(请转交) the town clerk. To err(犯错误) is human, I reminded myself, and no minor slip should destine(命定) a kind man to disgrace or sow(播种) eternal evil(邪恶的) in our hearts. I would offer no concession(让步) to cruelty. The records department(部) had nearly let his file scorch(烧焦) in a fire; a careless lamp had blackened the floor(地板) and the timber beam above. A man might gorge(咽喉) on rumor as on poison, yet rumor is no cyanide(化) if the truth gives us(我们) protection(保护). After a graceful ballet(芭蕾舞) by two dancers in the ring, I rose, wiped the sweat(汗水) from my brow, and chose to tie(领带) my findings into a neat bundle for safekeeping.

At last the elastic(弹性的) truth snapped back into shape. The clown's resonant laugh returned. I felt a youthful(年轻的) joy as I beat(敲打) my way through the curtain to congratulate him. Those who had doubted him now sat ashamed. Christianity(基督教) teaches mercy, and even the scornful rival, packing(装箱) his bags by the willow tree near the bay, seemed to bind(捆) his pride and ask forgiveness. The supporter(支持者) of truth had won; the favour of the crowd, once divided, was whole again. I left a tip on the pillow(枕头) of my hotel and walked out, blind(盲的) no longer to the power of a single honest record.

## 68. The Apprentice at the Shipbuilding Yard

On the wind-swept **terrace**(斜坡地) above the **shipbuilding**(造船) yard, **our**(我们的) **orphan**(孤儿) **apprentice**(学徒) stood each **autumn**(秋) morning, watching the **cutter**(用于切割的器械) slide into the bay. His **mercurial**(墨丘利神的) moods could turn from joy to **revolt**(反抗) in a minute, yet our **council**(政务会) of foremen agreed his **motivation**(动机) was **superb**(壮丽的). We did not **fabricate**(捏造) praise; **honesty**(诚实) was the **threshold**(门槛) of our trade.

I will **describe**(描述) him plainly. He was a thin **twin**(双的) of his late brother, with the **instinctive**(本能的) grace of a **saint**(圣人) and the stubbornness of a mule. His **salary**(薪金) was small, barely enough to **keep**(保持) him from a **vain**(徒劳的), empty **den**(窝) of a room, but he never complained. To **enrich**(使丰富) his skill he would keep a **questionnaire**(问题单) of every flaw he found, and **normally**(通常) he would **transfer**(转移) each note into **triplicate**(一式三份) for the **keeper**(看护人) of records.

The **essence**(本质) of shipbuilding is patience. One must **withhold**(拒绝给某事物) judgment until the **malleable**(有延展性的) steel cools, must **avoid**(避免) the **morbid**(病的) haste that ruins a hull. A **viscous**(粘滞的) **varnish**(清漆), a **percussion**(打击乐器) of hammers, the **gallop**(奔驰) of rivet guns — all of it combined into a strange music. We taught him to **consolidate**(巩固) his strength, to **pacify**(使平静) his temper, and to **anchor**(锚) each plate with precision. **Nowadays**(现今) a robust **antenna**(天线) and a radar replace the old methods, but the **philosophy**(哲学) of the craft does not change.

He had a weakness, I confess: an **allergic**(过敏的) reaction to the **topsoil**(上层土) dust near the **willow**(柳树) grove, which made him cough **through**(穿过) the whole **length**(长) of a shift. Yet he would not let it **supersede**(代替) his duty. When a **precedent**(先例) of carelessness threatened to **crush**(压碎) morale, he would **retort**(反驳) with a sharp, lucid argument and uphold the rules. His **literacy**(识字) was high; he read philosophy and even a **thesis**(论文) on the **depletion**(损耗) of marine resources, and he could **authorize**(授权) a repair order without a single error.

One **shock**(震惊) came when a **driver**(驾驶员) smuggled **cocaine**(古柯碱) in a **heap**(堆) of timber. The **furor**(激怒) was immense. Some wanted to **whitewash**(粉刷) the scandal to protect the **payroll**(薪水册); others, in the name of **justice**(公正), demanded a full **perusal**(细读) of the books. Our apprentice, **resistant**(抵抗的) to bribery, refused to avoid the truth. 'Otherwise(另样),' he said, 'our **fame**(名声) is worthless.' He was no coward.

For his **benefit**(利益) and ours, the council promoted him. At the **end**(末端) of his apprenticeship we held a small ceremony on the terrace. A **waving**(波浪状的) banner, a **tape-recording**(录音) of an old sailor's song, the distant gallop of celebration — it felt like the launch of a **space shuttle**(航天飞机) or a **spacecraft**(宇宙飞船), **minus**(负的) the smoke. **Sincerely**(真诚地), I have rarely felt such pride. The boy who began with nothing had earned his place, and the **expression**(表达) on his face, free of **disgustful**(令人生厌的) pretense, was the truest reward of all.

Later that evening, in his plain **pyjamas**(睡裤), he shared a simple meal with us: grilled **eel**(鳗鱼), a ripe **banana**(香蕉), and a **covering**(包括的) of warm broth that cleared the **airway**(航线) after a dusty day. He showed no **bad**(坏的) temper and asked for no **mercy**(怜悯), only the **favor**(好感) of being allowed to **combine**(联合) his two great loves, the sea and honest work. A **gay**(快乐的), easy laugh was a rare **trait**(显著的特点) in one so young, yet he had it. The yard, to him, was an **oasis**(绿洲), and that night, sitting near the **rear**(后部) of the hall, he confessed that every **fabrication**(制作) of doubt about his future had finally dissolved. Patience, he said, was the one **element**(元素) that made all the rest possible.

## 69. The Accountant's Quiet Investigation

The **method**(方法) was simple, the **witness**(目击者) reliable, yet the **investigation**(调查) refused to end. As the firm's **accountant**(会计人员), I had to **administer**(掌管) the audit of **accrued**(增值的) interest dating back to a contract signed in 200 **B.C.**(公元前) — well, not literally, though it felt **that**(那) old. My **responsibility**(责任) was to **mitigate**(减轻) any **error**(错误) before the **arbitration**(仲裁) began.

On a **normal**(正常的) **June**(六月) morning I opened the **cupboard**(碗橱) where the **casting**(铸件) ledgers were kept. The records, **groundless**(无根据的) rumor aside, showed nothing **wrong**(错的ad). But a single **bell**(钟) of doubt rang in my mind. **Occasionally**(偶然) a **sovereign**(主权的) client will **flaunt**(招展) his wealth and **provoke**(激怒) suspicion, and this **maritime**(海上的) shipping magnate, a **prolific**(多产的) **republican**(共和的) donor with a **din**(喧嚣) of opinions, was no exception. His **production**(生产) figures looked too clean.

I am **proficient**(熟练的) enough with numbers to know when a sum is wrong. **Under**(在...下面在...以下) the **explanatory**(说明的) notes for the **fifth**(第五) quarter, the **supplement**(补遗) to the **revision**(修改) did not add up. Was someone trying to defraud the **partake**(分担) of profits? I would not **coax**(哄) the data; I let it speak. The **arithmetic**(算术), after some **hesitation**(犹豫), revealed a missing **allotment**(分配) — a **refund**(归还) that had never reached the **cattle**(牛) ranchers in **Sweden**(瑞典).

My supervisor, an **admirable**(可钦佩的) man of great **ingenuity**(机灵), was **acquainted**(熟悉的) with the family. He had a **foible**(弱点) for **melancholy**(忧郁) **silence**(寂静) and a **courteous**(有礼貌的) manner, but he was no fool. ' **Demolish**(拆毁) the false entries,' he said, 'and rebuild from the source.' His **assurance**(保证) gave me confidence. We would not **block**(大块木料) the truth, nor whitewash a wrong.

The **scientist**(科学家) we hired to verify the casting alloys confirmed that **infertile**(不肥沃的) soil samples had been used to **corrode**(腐蚀) the evidence — a bizarre detail. Meanwhile, the **overwrought**(过度紧张的) office grew tense. One clerk, **hoarse**(嘶哑的) from arguing, scratched at his **eyebrow**(眉毛) and muttered about the **sophistication**(世故) of the fraud. Another, **fond**(喜爱的) of drama, threatened to **stop**(停止) work entirely.

By **Sunday**(星期日) I had worked **overnight**(通宵的) more than once, surviving on **cigar**(雪茄烟) smoke and weak tea served by a forgetful **milkman**(送奶人)'s leftover delivery. My eyes ached; I could barely **succeed**(成功) in reading the **spectacle**(眼镜) of figures before me. Yet **greed**(贪心) had made the criminals careless. An **ignorant**(无知的) assistant had left a **stapler**(钉书机) clipped to a page that proved the **valuation**(估价) was a lie.

The **arrival**(到达) of the auditors sealed the case. The **pier**(码头)-side warehouse, the **turkey**(火鸡)-farm subsidiary, the **suburbia**(郊区) office — every block of the empire was **scrupulous**(小心谨慎的) in appearance and rotten beneath. We would not be eligible for praise; we simply did our duty. The **occupational**(职业的) pride of an honest accountant is a quiet thing. **Anybody**(任何人) can chase fame, but to **contribute**(贡献) to justice, to refuse the **innovation**(改革) of clever lies, to **muse**(沉思) on the **circumference**(圆周) of a man's character and find it sound — that is the real revision worth making. The pope of finance had fallen, and the **virile**(男性的) machinery of law, courteous yet firm, took over.

In the end, the **rule**(统治) I followed was **virtually**(实际上) a **script**(手迹) I knew by heart: trust the numbers, take nothing as **acceptable**(可接受的) until checked twice. A foreign **guest**(客人) at the hearing spoke with a heavy **accent**(口音) about the old days of **colonialism**(殖民主义), when ledgers were salted with bribes; I made a quick **scratch**(抓痕) in my margin to note it. Under close **supervision**(监督), even the magnate's lawyer had to **audition**(听) his excuses before a skeptical panel, and not one of them held. The **salt**(盐) of honest doubt had preserved the truth.

## 70. The Honest Sailor and the Drowning Coast

An **honest**(诚实的) **sailor**(水手) named Milo took **payment**(支付) in **milk**(牛奶) and bread when coin was scarce, and he never grew **tired**(疲劳的) of the sea. The **void**(真空) of the open water did not frighten him, though pirates once tried to **decorate**(装饰) their flag with his blood. Sailing **northward**(向北) past an old **monastery**(修道院), he watched the tide **inundate**(淹没) the lowlands while a lone **hunter**(猎人) waded after game.

Milo was every captain's favorite **customer**(顾客) at the harbor market, where merchants treated him **kindly**(仁慈地). He kept a modest **wardrobe**(衣柜) in a cabin, his **countless**(无数的) shirts folded with one bruised **elbow**(肘) resting on the rail as he liked to **compose**(组成) songs. The town would **celebrate**(庆祝) his return, though some, in **disgust**(厌恶), recalled the **formation**(形成) of his temper after long voyages. An **overload**(使超载) of work could break a weaker man.

Near the **lavatory**(厕所) of the old inn, **leftover**(剩余物) stew waited. A **revolutionary**(革命的) mood gripped the **reality**(现实) of the docks that season: **tension**(紧张局势) ran high. A traveling **carnivore**(食肉动物)-keeper let his beasts **peck**(啄) and prowl, and Milo's **conviction**(深信) held firm. A bad **joint**(接合处) in the pier made him **dread**(畏惧) the next storm, yet it was **expedient**(有用的) to stay. Conditions were **conducive**(有益于...的) to disaster. Sailors stored **dynamite**(炸药) to **proclaim**(宣告) the festival, and a great **tanker**(油船), **owing**(欠的) money to half the coast, threatened to **beset**(困扰) the bay.

To **synchronize**(同步) the rescue boats was hard, for **weakness**(虚弱) in the crew was **important**(重要的) to hide. Had he **ever**(曾经) soared so close to ruin? When the flood came to **submerge**(放于水下) the lower streets, the **event**(事件) swept **them**(他们) all. Milo led them to higher ground; the **waterfront**(水边) could not **hamper**(阻碍) him. The **facility**(设备) for calm under pressure is rare. Men **die**(死) when they panic, and **pollution**(污染) from the spilled **tomato**(西红柿) cannery only worsened the **inverse**(相反的) logic of the chaos.

**Registration**(登记) of the missing took a week. On his **way**(道路) home, **confident**(确信的) again, Milo passed a **radish**(小萝卜) field where the salt had begun to **tarnish**(失去光泽) the soil. He would not **obsess**(迷住) over loss. **Culture**(文化), he believed, is the **whole**(全部) of how people **utter**(说) their grief, **whereas**(鉴于) a **rascal**(流氓) hides it. A **peculiarity**(特性) of his **communal**(公共的) village was that no one stayed **helpless**(无助的) long; one **contingency**(事故) met **another**(另一个).

A single **spark**(火花) in a **narrow**(狭窄的) alley nearly undid the recovery, but they managed to **pack**(捆扎) and **level**(水平) the debris, **pin**(大头针) by pin. **Commerce**(商业) returned. The harbor began to **attract**(引起的注意) trade again. **Amid**(在...当中) the **lotus**(植) ponds, in a **lucid**(明晰的) evening, the **navy**(海军) raised a flag for those lost to the **extinct**(灭绝的) old ways. Each **denomination**(命名) of grief found its **symbol**(符号). A single **pirate**(海盗), more **conspicuous**(明显的) than any **disturbance**(动乱) the storm had caused, tried to **force**(力量) the survivors to give **consent**(同意) to a looting scheme, but Milo, **adept**(熟练的) at reading wicked men, refused. Only those of proven honesty were **eligible**(符合条件的) to share the salvage. Watching the gulls **soar**(剧增) above the calm water, he felt at peace. Milo, ever **communicative**(毫无隐讳交谈的), helped design the new **packaging**(包装) for the rescued goods, and chose to **innovate**(革新) the warning system so no town would again be caught **upside**(上面) down by the sea.

## 71. Fieldwork on a Distant Isle

Lately(最近) I have come to ponder(深思) the strange Thursday(星期四) when our small troupe(剧团) of researchers first reached the distant(远的) isle(小岛). As the narrator(叙述者) of this account, I must summarize(概括) honestly, for(为了) memory tends to distort(扭曲) even the most rigorous(严格的) notes. I still recall it vividly(生动地). We had crossed a colonial(殖民地的) canal(运河) by an old conveyance(运送), a rattling car(汽车) whose engine seemed likely(很可能的) to dissolve(使液化) into rust at any moment. Thunder(雷) rolled overhead, and a lone hawk(鹰) did hover(盘旋) above the dusty(沾满灰尘的) shore in a wide arc(弧). Our leader, a prudent(谨慎的) guy(家伙) trained in both anthropology(人类学) and linguistics(语言学), was insistent(坚持的) that we identify(认出) every plant, e.g.(例如) the modest petunia(植) along the path's fringe(边缘). He could be arrogantly(傲慢地) certain, yet his enthusiasm was spontaneous(自发的) and resilient(弹回的). When a sudden squirt(喷出) of rain hit us, he refused to reject(拒绝) the day's timetable(时间表). One Italian(意大利的) colleague, cheerful and clever, spent evenings teaching grammar; he loved to explain how an infinitive(不定式的) could carry a whole intention. He would ask a question(问题), wait, then answer it himself. When ink would spill(溢出) across his notes he only shrugged, and he joked that the island deserved its own zipcode(邮政编码), so far did it feel from any map. The island's welfare(幸福) depended on a single mine, and the unemployment(失业) that followed its closure had bred deep dissatisfaction(不满) and quiet indignation(愤怒). One old miner(矿工), leaning on a crutch(拐杖), told us how the company would expel(开除) anyone who criticized its conduct(行为), treating each complaint as a misdeed(罪行) and imposing a forfeit(丧失的东西) on the careless. Such an irrevocable(不可撤消的) policy, he said with a shrill(尖声的) voice, was a curse(咒骂). We were not loath(不情愿的) to listen. We had come to study how a community reaches maturity(成熟), how it might neutralize(压制) despair. People here did not crave(渴望) luxury; they were desperate(绝望的) only for fairness. They would pray(请求), join(参加) hands, and crawl(爬行) forward through every obstruction(妨碍). Sometimes(不时), when the bustle(匆匆忙忙) of the market faded, you could feel a slow transformation(变化) that no redundancy(冗余) of hardship could erase. I summarized our findings in extensive(广大的) correspondence(通信) sent home. We measured a cube(立方体) of ore, weighed flour(面粉) and other foodstuff(食品), counted each casualty(伤亡人员) of the last flood, and noted the allocation(分配) of supplies. A supersonic(超音速的) jet once roared past, a fatty(脂肪的) streak against the sky. We tipped the rubbish into a tin(罐头) dustbin(簸箕), and an associative(联想的) memory of home would confuse(使困惑) me with longing. Yet I learned to enjoy(享受...的乐趣) the continuance(连续) of simple work, scalpel(解剖刀)-sharp in its clarity. Wherever(无论在哪里) I travel now, I keep that national(民族的) island in my heart, victorious(胜利的) in its own enduring way, and an annex(附录) of peanut(花生) shells still sits in my notebook. The Bible(圣经) on the shelf and the increment(增值) of each small lesson taught me that hope, however technological(技术的) the world becomes, is the most resilient foodstuff of the soul.

## 72. A Booming Campus Term

On a bright **Tuesday**(星期二) the new **manager**(经理) of our college trading club arrived to **enroll**(招收) fresh members and **refine**(精炼) our plans for the term. He was an **enthusiastic**(热心的), **imposing**(使人难忘的) man, a **forerunner**(先驱) of a more modern style, eager to **abrogate**(取消) the old **bureaucratic**(官僚主义的) rules that had made the club feel **stale**(食品不新鲜的). **Throughout**(遍及) the first **fortnight**(两星期) he asked us to **grasp**(抓住) a single **motif**(主题): **unity**(团结). Every **unit**(单位) of the group, he said **expressly**(明确表示的), should feel **alive**(活着的) and **free**(自由的), not **overextend**(使承担过多的义务) itself, and the **willingness**(乐意) of each member would be **proportional**(比例的) to the **glory**(光荣) we shared. He made an **attractive**(吸引人的) **offer**(提出) to **scan**(浏览) our messy ledgers, and his **judgement**(意见) was **timely**(及时的). We had fallen into **arrear**(欠款); an **unfair**(不公平的) **contracted**(合同所规定的) debt sat unpaid, and the **bursar**(会计), a quiet **insider**(知情者), was **uneasy**(不自在的) about the **instable**(不稳定的) books. The manager would **affirm**(断定) a plan, then **toss**(扔) the **latter**(后者的) half aside if the numbers began to **fluctuate**(涨落). He took a **commission**(委员会) only on real **promotion**(促进) of the club, never on **infringement**(侵权) of trust, and his **greeting**(问候) each morning lifted our **impatience**(不耐烦) into hope.

The club itself was a **noisy**(吵闹的) place. A **buzz**(嗡嗡叫) of chatter rose as a **coed**(男女合校大学中的) **panel**(镶板) debated **which**(哪个) projects to **publish**(出版) first. One **trader**(商人) wanted to sell **coal**(煤) and **brandy**(白兰地酒); a **counterpart**(对应的物或人) argued for a **donation**(捐献) drive instead. "A **buck**(<美口>) is a buck," laughed an **Asian**(亚洲的) student over a **hat**(帽子) full of coins, while another, wearing an **eyeglass**(眼镜) on a cord, chewed **gum**(树胶) and scanned a **fictional**(虚构的) business case. We studied the **utility**(有用) of every idea, from **transshipment**(转运) routes to the **navigation**(航海) of customs forms, and one ambitious member even proposed an **aeroplane**(飞机) charter, which made the rest of us **tease**(取笑) him for dreaming so big.

Our faculty **guardian**(保护人), a calm **exponent**(解释者) of careful thinking, warned against **alienation**(异化). He taught a little of everything: **phonetics**(语音学) in the morning, then **zoology**(动物学), **astrology**(占星术) as a joke, even a dash of **plane**(飞机) geometry where an **axial**(轴的) line cut a circle. He would **wring**(拧) his hands and **pledge**(保证) that knowledge, like a **fairy**(幻想中的) tale, must be **instructive**(指示的) yet fun. After class we would **stroll**(漫步) to the river, **paddle**(短桨) a small boat past a **plank**(厚木板) dock, and **bathe**(浸到水中) in the warm light; some played **soccer**(足球) while others ate **cereal**(谷类粮食) or **dessert**(正餐后的水果或甜). He kept a fire **extinguisher**(熄灭者) near the coal stove and a plank shelf of **Arabic**(阿拉伯的) and English books in the **vicinity**(邻近) of his desk. He spoke of the **militia**(民兵) of the mind, of how a single **molecule**(分子) of doubt can **decay**(腐烂) a whole argument, and of the **abrasion**(磨损) that careless words leave on a friendship. When my **stomach**(胃) growled during a long meeting, he simply smiled, for he knew the **booming**(兴旺的) energy of youth needs both food and rest.

### 73. The Eccentric Inventor of Pinewood

Everyone in our **old**(年老的) village had a **nickname**(绰号) for the **eccentric**(古怪) who lived at the edge of the **forest**(森林), near a leaking **dam**(水坝) built of **leather**(皮革) straps and **pine**(消瘦) logs. As a **boy**(男孩子) I would **wade**(趟) through the stream, **relish**(美味) the cold **ice**(冰) on its banks, and **quietly**(安静地) watch him **manage**(经营) his cluttered **laboratory**(实验室). He was **outspoken**(坦率直言的) to the point of **ridicule**(嘲弄), yet **childlike**(孩子似的) in his wonder, and he wore a long **robe**(长袍) stained with chemicals. "Their(他们的) **dogma**(教条)," he told my **dad**(爸爸) with **reverent**(尊敬的) **sincerity**(真诚), "is **contrary**(相反的) to real curiosity." He kept a chipped **jug**(大壶), an old **exercise-book**(练习簿) full of plots and diagrams, and a **notch**(槽口) carved into the wall for every idea he could **recall**(召回). **Recently**(最近) he had been studying **cellulose**(纤维素), hoping to **redeem**(买回) a **perishable**(容易腐烂的) crop and **convey**(运送) its starch into something that would not decay. His **prodigious**(巨大的) mind could **heighten**(加高) a small spark into a **controversial**(引起争论的) theory; **therefore**(因此) people both admired and feared him. One afternoon a **conflict**(战斗) broke out. A **pharmacist**(药师) from town arrived to **unload**(卸货) a cart and, with **insignificant**(无意义的) patience, began to **molest**(骚乱) the inventor with questions, as if to **mystify**(迷惑) and **falsify**(伪造) his work. The visitor's **literal**(文字的) reading of a single **definition**(定义) seemed **deficient**(缺乏的), and his **condemnation**(谴责) would only **exacerbate**(恶化) the old man's mood. "On **behalf**(利益) of science," the inventor said, refusing to **refrain**(抑制), "I must **acknowledge**(承认) the **onset**(进攻) of doubt, but I will not let it **muddle**(混合) the truth." He explained that an **infant**(婴儿) idea needs a **lull**(暂停), not a storm; that one **bushel**(蒲式耳) of evidence, **averagely**(平均) measured, outweighs loud opinion. He pulled the **brake**(刹车) on his temper, checked the **voltage**(电压) of an old battery, and felt a **thrill**(激动) as a **colorful**(色彩丰富的) **petal**(花瓣) of light bloomed from the wire. A **creature**(人) stirred in the rafters. **Unfortunately**(不幸地), the visitor only saw a **harmful**(有害的) eccentric, an **exploit**(英雄行为) of vanity, and he left in a huff, giggling like a fool. **Eventually**(终于) the **renewal**(更新) of seasons softened the quarrel. The inventor, no **solicitor**(律师) of fame, spoke of a **labor-intensive**(劳动密集型的) future where even the **GNP**(国民总收入) of a tiny republic might rise on clever, **democratic**(民主的) invention. He did not **yearn**(想念) for a **cataract**(大瀑布) of applause; **acceptance**(接受) from a few honest minds, he said, was enough. As **background**(背景) music a distant bell rang in the village **hall**(礼堂). I came to understand that his strange, **physically**(物质上) demanding life was its own quiet exploit, a **precipitate**(沉淀物) of pure thought, and that he, the rightful **owner**(物主) of his dreams, was no **cancer**(癌) on our **tradition**(传统) but a gentle **distortion**(弄歪) of it, a man who would rather **spend**(花费) his days in truth than in comfortable lies.

Years later I would **giggle**(咯咯地笑) at the memory of his workshop, a place stuffed with curious **stuff**(原料). There was a **hole**(洞) in the roof, a trapdoor to an **underground**(地铁a) cellar, and shelves crowded like a cluttered **boutique**(专卖流行衣服的小) of inventions. He could **articulate**(有关节的) the wildest **plot**(小块土地) of an experiment as calmly as an **interpreter**(译员) rendering a foreign speech, and he would **rip**(撕裂) a flawed page from his notebook without a second thought. To this day I cannot articulate how much that strange, generous mind shaped me.

## 74. The Comedian Who Repaired Old Cars

Whose(谁的) idea was it to put a comedian(喜剧演员) in charge of a dilapidated(毁坏的) repair garage? The reason(原因), I think(想), was that laughter can revive(苏醒) almost anything. Our front(前面的) office was a shabby(破旧的) room with a single teacup(茶杯), a dusty bookstore(书店) catalogue, and a transistor(晶体管) radio that would flicker(闪烁) between(在...之间) channels. The owner, a blonde(色白的) housewife(家庭主妇) turned mechanic, had inherited the place from her predecessor(前任) and refused to let one setback(顿挫) after another defeat her. Her partner was a striking(引人注目的), tactful(机智的) man who could simplify(简化) any problem and soothe(安慰) any angry customer. To support(支撑) the business they had to compensate(赔偿) for years of decline. Their first job that moist(潮湿的) morning was a hatchback(有仓门式后背的汽) whose engine made a tiresome(使人厌倦的) rattle. I watched him tap(龙头) the metal, kick(踢) a tyre, and digest(摘要) the symptoms with acute(厉害的) attention. "The flavor(情味) of this fault," he joked, "is sour, like a strawberry(草莓) left too long." He underlined a note on the clipboard with a clip(回形针), then asked me to hang(悬挂) a lamp from the derrick(钻塔)-like frame above. We worked on the inner(内部的) shoulder(肩) of the chassis, between the wheel and the base(基础), careful not to spill oil on the ground(地). A faint smell of sulphur(硫磺) drifted from a nearby plant where emission(散发) controls had clearly failed. He explained that rust can decompose(分解) metal the way a parasite(寄生虫) weakens an ox(牛), and that any modified(改良的) part must be responsive(响应的) and perpendicular(垂直的) to the axle or it will wear in succession(连续). The whole task was hectic(脸上发红), almost spectacular(壮观的) in its mess, and the throat(咽喉)-tightening fumes made us pause(中止) to breathe. A mob(乌合之众vi) of curious neighbours gathered at the keyhole(钥匙孔) of the door, eager to intrude(闯入), but the manager would not let them embarrass(使为难) the team. With a whip(鞭子)-like crack of his wrench he spurred us on. Prices were rising, and an unsalable(不好销售的) surplus of old electrical(电的) parts sat in crates; yet he treated honest accounting(会计学) as a matter of integrity(诚实), never as a disgraceful(耻辱的) trick. "Think," he said, "of the gratitude(感激) of a family whose car runs again." He had a formidable(可怕的) patience. When sales would plummet(铅锤) he sought an alternative(二选一); he would even revive a museum-piece engine, armour(盔甲)-plated like a dinosaur(恐龙), just to keep the staff in good footing(立足点). By dusk the hatchback purred, and we were pleased(高兴的). We shared cracker(苏打饼干) biscuits and amazement(惊奇) at our own work. A patent(明显的) application lay half-finished on his desk, a premise(逻辑) for some future device. The supposition(假定) that a small, physical(物质的) craft cannot matter is, I now believe, a miscarriage(误判) of judgement. To my amazement, the militant(好战的) gloom I had carried for months simply dissolved, and I phoned my mother to relate the news, a rabbit(兔子)-quick joy in my voice. That evening, nineteen(十九pron) of us crowded into a cheap hostel(廉价旅馆) near the lake(湖泊), more than(比) ready to celebrate. Our boss told a comedy(喜剧) routine so silly it would amaze(使惊奇) even a stone, mixing slapstick with a touch of gritty realism(现实主义). He let his phone(电话) ring unanswered and explained, with childlike glee, how a tiny microprocessor(微信息处理器) now controls each modern engine, far smarter than the clinging(执着的) grease of the old days. He had grown up on the mainland(大陆), he said, and a single kind teacher there had been the spur(刺激) that set his life in motion. He liked to underline(划线于...之下) one necessary(必需的) truth: that even an ox has a trochanter(解), a small joint that lets a great body move, and that small parts, humble as they seem, carry the weight of the whole.

## 75. A Diplomat's Holiday in Mexico

When the **veteran**(老手) **diplomat**(外交人员) finally took a **holiday**(假日) in **Mexico**(墨西哥), he was acutely **aware**(知道的) that his **usual**(通常的) life of **diplomacy**(外交) had left him starved for **solitude**(寂寞). The **republic**(共和国), with **its**(它的) **radiant**(发光的) light and its **cultural**(文化的) depth, seemed the **special**(特殊的) place to **dispel**(驱散) the **monotony**(单调) of endless negotiation. He would **negotiate**(商订) nothing here; he would simply **operate**(操作) as an ordinary man. On the **seaside**(海滨) **street**(街) near the **consulate**(领事馆) he rented **three**(三 **pron**) rooms at a **site**(位置) overlooking the **traffic**(交通), and each morning he would **rub**(摩擦) his eyes, scan the **calendar**(历书), and decide that today, too, he would do nothing **decisive**(决定性的). A **boarding card**(乘车证) from his flight still marked the page of a **poem**(诗) he liked, and beside it lay a **compass**(指南针) he no longer needed to find his way. The local **peasant**(小农) families, far from **naive**(天真的), were **tenacious**(顽强的) and proud; their welcome was an **appeal**(呼吁) to the heart rather than a **negative**(否定的) formality. He watched a **woodpecker**(啄木鸟) hammer a **stump**(树桩), saw a hawk-like **claw**(爪) of shadow **sway**(摇摆) across a **poisonous**(有毒的)-looking but harmless plant, and felt his old **displeasure**(不快) **subside**(下沉). Diplomacy, he reflected, often forced a man to distort the **gist**(要点) of **what**(什么a) he truly meant, to **obstruct**(阻隔) his own feelings, to **inhibit**(抑制) every spontaneous word. Here, by contrast, the **corresponding**(符合的) honesty of daily life was refreshing. He bought **jelly**(冻) and **sticky**(粘的) sweets at a stall, paid in **sterling**(金银标准成分的) out of habit before **correctly**(正确地) counting the local notes the **teller**(出纳) had given him, and laughed when the woman behind the counter, with mild **disapproval**(不批准), pointed out his error. An **influx**(流入) of tourists, he knew, could **jeopardize**(危及) this fragile peace; mass tourism tends to **prevail**(流行) and to **devalue**(贬值) whatever it touches, hastening a kind of cultural **depreciation**(折旧). Yet for now the **energy**(活力) of the town felt **grown**(已长成的) and whole. One afternoon a sudden squall made the awnings **plunge**(投入) and the boats lurch; a **helmet**(头盔)-wearing worker climbed from a **manhole**(人孔) to inspect a flooded canal, and an **inspection**(检查) crew hurried **enroute**(在途中) to the consulate. The **magnitude**(大小) of the storm was real, but it would not **condemn**(谴责) the day. He thought of his **heir**(继承人) back home, of the energy he must still summon, of the grown responsibilities he could not **outdo**(胜过) or escape. To **include**(包括) this trip in his memoirs, he decided, would be **erroneous**(错误的) only if he pretended it had changed nothing. **Hence**(从此地) he wrote three lines in his journal, **suddenly**(突然地) certain that an **interim**(中间的) of rest is not a luxury but a necessity. Its lesson was simple, and he would not **punish**(惩罚) himself for learning it late: even a man sworn to serve the nation must sometimes **disable**(使无能力) the machine of duty, sway gently in the warm air, and let the special quiet of an **overseas**(外国的) evening teach him who he is. One quiet evening he sat in a small theatre to enjoy an **opera**(歌剧), an old **fable**(寓言) of a **crown**(王冠) and a **lesser**(较小的) prince set to music. He would not **deplore**(表示悲痛) his earlier **job**(工作) in code **programing**(程序编排), nor the **cutting**(锋利的) remarks of rivals; he raised no **objection**(反对) now. Like a doctor guarding a fragile **fetus**(胎儿), he had learned that the **integration**(结合) of work and rest is itself an art. He would **entreat**(恳求) no favours, sought no **opium**(鸦片) of false praise, and the **dressing**(打扮) on an old wound finally healed. He cleaned each **utensil**(器皿) after his simple meal, and by the **conjunction**(连词) of luck and patience even his **past-due**(过期的) debts felt lighter. The treasure, he smiled, was never a **mine**(我的n) of gold but the calm that was truly mine.

## 76. The Harvest at Greenhill Orchard

Every autumn the village **near**(近的) the **cottage**(村舍) regarded the **harvest**(收获) as its single great event, and the people came to **regard**(把...看作为) Otto, the **tidy**(整洁的) farmer, with quiet respect. He would **get**(获得) up at **dusk**(薄暮)'s opposite hour and **dress**(服装) in the dark, then drive his **tractor**(拖拉机) across the **domestic**(家的) acres where **maize**(玉米) and **hay**(干草) grew in long rows beside the **orchard**(果园). He had learned to **cultivate**(耕作) the land with **caution**(小心), to **trust**(信任) the soil, and to **deliver**(投递) each crop to market with care. The **recognition**(认出) his produce earned **annually**(年年) surpassed that of any rival farm; even a famous **psychologist**(心理学家) who once came to a **conference**(会议) at the regional **headquarters**(司令部) called the place a small **civilization**(文明) of its own.

**Forth**(向前) from the barn each morning came a bunch of helpers: a **Swiss**(瑞士的) exchange student, a **communist**(共产党员) old uncle who liked to **meddle**(管闲事) in everyone's rows, a **foolish**(愚笨的) but **ingenuous**(坦白的) boy, a **lecturer**(演讲者) on leave, and a **waiter**(侍者) from town. They would **jot**(匆匆记下) the day's totals on a **scroll**(卷轴) of brown paper, then **roast**(烤) maize over coals and eat **herb**(草木植物)-flavored bread until their hunger, and any lingering **indigestion**(消化不良), gave way to contentment. The work was **structural**(结构的) and **radical**(根本的) at once: it reshaped the land and the people both. Otto kept a **medical**(医学的) kit for any **emergency**(紧急情况), a fire near the hay always under tidy control, and an old **headline**(大字标题) pinned to the wall to remind him how an **outbreak**(爆发) of blight had once nearly ruined him. That setback had been a **quagmire**(沼泽) of debt; the **amount**(等于) owed had seemed formidable.

This year the maize was so abundant it threatened a glut. Rather than **monopolize**(垄断) the trade, Otto would not **overtake**(超过) his smaller neighbours unfairly; he made **amends**(赔偿) to the lean years by giving a **lump sum**(总数) of grain to the clinic, an **offering**(报盘) free of any hidden motive. He hated **tyranny**(暴政) and the **terror**(恐怖) of debt alike, and thought it **politic**(策略性的), not merely kind, to share. A **bodyguard**(保镖) of geese patrolled the **lattice**(格子) fence near the **boat**(小船) pond, and beyond it a new **flyover**(n飞机编队低空飞) and a curving cutting carried traffic toward **Malaysia**(马来西亚)-bound and **Canada**(加拿大)-bound ships. Otto could not **travel**(旅行v) far himself; his **marital**(婚姻的) duties and a stubborn **inability**(无能) to leave the soil kept him home, though he never let that fact **disrupt**(使中断) his cheer.

In the evening his daughter would do the **shopping**(买东西), then sit by the **page**(页) of a grammar book, underlining each **noun**(名词) and learning that knowledge, like **fermentation**(发酵) in **chemistry**(化学), needs time. A **hypothetical**(假设的) question—what if the rains failed?—no longer made him **numb**(麻木的). He would not deplore the weather nor let a **skew**(歪斜的) rumor **disprove**(反驳) his faith in the work. **Sex**(性别) of the calf, weight of the ox, the **exhaustive**(详尽的) **adjustment**(调整) of every account: these were the plain illustrations of a good life. The **proforma**(形式的) ledger balanced. Each tenant would **pay**(付款) on time, and the old stone **castle**(城堡) on the hill, once thought **incompatible**(不相容的) with farming, now **linger**(逗留) in the children's stories as a friendly ghost. So the harvest closed, not in fear, but in peace. When the last sheaf was in, the village threw a festival. A **firework**(爆竹) would **surpass**(超越) the stars for one brief, **potent**(有力的) moment, its **width**(宽阔) of light blooming over the orchard. Otto, in one worn **slipper**(便鞋), felt the **prick**(刺伤) of a thread as a **tailor**(裁缝v) mended his coat by the **electronic**(电子的) glow of a lamp, and he tugged the **zipper**(拉链) of his jacket against the chill. His old fear, **latent**(潜伏的) and once **vicious**(恶意的), no longer had the power to **hurt**(伤痛) him; he felt almost **immune**(免疫的) to it now. Honest **labor**(工作), he told the children as a final **illustration**(说明), is the only charm that lasts.

## 77. A Studio of Light and Grief

The woman(妇女) who chose to immigrate(移居入境) to the shady(成荫的) river town(市镇) arrived with little more than a candle(蜡烛), an album of charcoal(炭) sketches, and an aimless hope. Apparently(显然) she had once been a novelist's muse; later(后来) she would become a studio(画室) artist whose work demonstrated a rare charm(吸引力). Her beloved(被热爱的) mentor, a Jewish(犹太人的) lecturer of fervent(热情的) temper, had taught her to capture(捕获) a feeling and fix(固定) it on the page, to formulate(精确地表达) each idea explicitly rather than leave(离开) it invisible(看不见的). He was no conceited(自负的) man, though his vengeance(报仇) against laziness was famous; he would shove(乱推) a half-finished canvas back at a pupil with a pointed, selective(选择的) eye and demand they begin anew. Mainly(主要地) he prized the intrinsic(固有的) over the showy, the finite(有限的) craft over the infinite excuse.

Her first hundred(百) days in town were hectic. She rented a room above a directory(名录) shop, climbing a stair(楼梯) past a drawer(抽屉) of old keys, and arranged her tools on a desk below(在...下面) a window that let the solar(太阳的) light roll(卷) across the floor. A bugle(军号) from the brass(黄铜) band would ring(戒指) through the door(门) each Friday, and she would pause, anyhow(不论用何种方法), to listen. The idiom(习语) of the place was strange to her; she would jot each new verb(动词) and noun, each exclamation(呼喊), into a notebook, learning its grade(等级) and its attributive(定语的) use, as a student learns grammar. Familiarity(熟悉) came slowly. She felt a deep humiliation(羞辱) at her early errors, a resentment(不满) that bordered on grief(悲伤), and more than once a hesitant cry(哭) would climb her throat as she sat below the candle.

Yet she would not deviate(偏离) from her duty. The pivot(枢轴) of her life had become the work. She learned to blend sugar(糖)-bright pigment with the dark, to exclude(拒绝) what did not serve the whole, to mark each exclusion(排除) with deliberation(慎重). One night a commotion(骚动) in the street, which neighbors called a near-massacre(大屠杀) though it proved only a fuss, distracted the whole quarter; even so she kept the candle lit. By the silt(淤泥)-grey light of dawn she finished the piece. It showed a hare(野兔) and an insect(昆虫) beside a basin(盆) of refreshing(提神的) water, a dainty(优雅) momentum(动力) of recovery(痊愈) after long humiliation. The exclusion of every superfluous line gave it an intrinsic calm; the appendix(附录) of notes she pinned below it explained, with finite honesty, how she had built the image from blood(血液)-warm reds. A naturally(自然地) gentle critic from the town came to her living-room(起居室), climbed the stair, and stood in apparent silence. He confessed the work would not be excluded from the annual(每年的) show; on the contrary, its momentum and selective grace made it a panacea(万能药) for the gallery's dull season. The recovery of her confidence, fragile as a candle in wind(风), was complete; she had, against humiliation and grief, exalted the improper(不适当的) into the beautiful, and felt, for the first time, lucky. Years later technology(科学技术) would change her studio: she learned to dial(表面) a phone, set the ignition(点火) of a small kiln, and watch a ferrous(铁的) tool glow for an hour(小时). A modest subsidy(补助金) from an egalitarian(平等主义的) arts fund let her exalt(抬高) her craft without the damage(损害) of poverty. She would affix(使附于) each sketch to a long tract(广阔的地面) of board, demonstrate(论证) her method to students, and maneuver(机动) a funnel(漏斗) of pigment with explicit(清楚的) care. When prices would sag(下跌) she did not despair; the completion(完成) of a true piece, she said, was worth more than a market. She kept a marble bust(半身像) by the door, gave it a daily kiss(吻) for luck, and refused to let one disappointed(失望的) buyer set the pitch(球场) of her mood, for she would never accompany(陪伴) regret. No tumour(医) of doubt could grow where joy had taken root.

## 78. A Brief Holiday in the Highland Northwest

Sir(先生) Edmund, a knowledgeable(博学的) bachelor(单身汉) and amateur novelist(小说家), decided his life had grown too aimless(无目的的), so he made a brief(简短的) request(要求) of his travel partner(合作者): arrange(安排) a holiday in the highland(高地) of the northwest(西北方). The layout(布置) of the trip was simple. They would tramp(徒步远行) the changeable(变化的) hills, secure(安全的) a gentle(文雅的) cottage, and let the curtain(窗帘) of routine fall. "Likewise(同样地)," his partner said, "we should leave the phone behind." Sir Edmund gave a composed(镇静的) nod, sure(肯定的) of the plan, and slid a souvenir(纪念品) map and an album(相片册) into his briefcase beside a handbag(手袋) of snacks.

The meal(膳食) on the first day was a luncheon(午餐) of silk(丝)-smooth soup, milky(牛奶的) tea, a bunch(束) of grass(草)-fed lamb, and a delicate(易碎的) dessert of starch(淀粉) and sugar. The waiter, an obliging man(人), did not overcharge(多收钱) them, which was a refreshing improvement(改进) on the city, where every replacement(取代) part and every model(样式) seemed unaffordable(买不起的). There was no disparity(不同) here between price and worth, no pilferage(偷窃), no overrule(驳回) of common sense by greed. Such simplicity(简单), Sir Edmund confessed, amused him enormously(非常地).

They hired a small fleet(舰队) of boats to circle(圆) the ice-bound(冰封的) lake, a mile(英里) of cold and joyful(十分喜悦的) water. A bachelor of leisure, he had no duty(义务) to quicken(加快) his pace; he could indulge a desire(愿望) to pause, to shake(摇动) off the broken(被打碎的) rhythm of work, to initiate(开始) a slower mode of being. His partner, more hesitant(犹豫的), was prone(俯伏的) to fuss; the changing weather and the milky fog would distract(分散) her, and a disagreement(不一致) over the date(日期) of return briefly chilled the air. But the encouragement(鼓舞) of the view—a plateau(高原) crowned with mesh(网)-like cloud—soothed every worry. They did not let the disagreement linger.

Reading a borrowed text(正文) by a famous correspondent(记者), Sir Edmund grew subjective(主观的) about it all. He saw the highland as a model of secure peace, immune to the materialism(唯物主义) and mortgage(抵押) anxiety of town, free of the truce(休战)-and-war cycle of office politics. A lucky(幸运的) wallaby(动), escaped from some distant zoo, was rumored to roam the moor; the locals, ordinarily(通常) reserved, told the tale with a joyful relish. Whether a soldier's truce or an invader(入侵者)'s retreat, every old story consisted of the same quiet courage. By the last day Sir Edmund felt the slow improvement of his spirit, and he requested, likewise, that the holiday be extended—a sure sign, he confessed with a smile, that the cure had worked. The Highland Inn, run by an obliging emperor(皇帝) of hospitality (so the locals teased its owner), did consist(组成) of only three rooms, but each held a quiet attraction(吸引). Sir Edmund would confess(供认) his interest(兴趣) in old war relics: a military(军事的) cap with a frayed cuff(袖口), a model submarine(潜水艇), a faded photograph of a smoker(抽烟者) leaning on a periscope. The high humidity(湿度) made the air feel differently(不同地) soft, and a strange yelp(狗吠) from a fox at night did not repel(击退) him but rather did amuse(逗...笑) him. He had no recourse(求助对象) to the city now, no expedience(便利) of taxis or vaccine(疫苗的) queues; the one drawback(障碍) was that the post would not enrol(登记) his letters quickly. To pass the hours he learned to blend(混合) herbs for tea, to solicit(恳求) recipes from the cook, and to chant low notes that tested his larynx(解). The inclusion(包括在内) of such small pleasures, free of any larger plan, was its own reward.

## 79. The Metropolitan Theatre and Its Survivor

In the **east**(东) of **Britain**(不列颠) stands a grand **metropolitan**(首都的) **building**(建筑), a theatre whose **standing**(持续) in the city is **immense**(广大的). Its **presidential**(总统的) box, draped in **velvet**(丝绒) so soft that the **softness**(温和) seems **audible**(听得见的), has hosted **Arab**(阿拉伯) princes and an exiled Arab emir alike. The **clever**(聪明的) director, a former **broker**(经纪人) who left the **lab**(实验室) of finance for the stage, likes to **refer**(参考) to the place as a **survivor**(幸存者) of every **divergence**(分歧) in public taste. **No.**(号) 1 on the playbill this season is a **theatrical**(戏剧的) **prelude**(序言) about **crime**(罪行), **exile**(流放), and **grace**(优美).

The lead, a **steady**(稳的) veteran of the metropolitan circle, was nearly assassinated years ago by a **bullet**(子弹) meant for another; he **barely**(赤裸裸地) escaped, and the **coincidence**(巧合) still gives him a **chill**(寒冷). Now he rehearses with immense focus, refusing to **indulge**(放纵) in the **snobbery**(势利) and **fuss**(大惊) of younger players. "**Respect**(尊敬) the text," he tells them, an **assertion**(断言) he repeats **invariably**(不变地). He will **tolerate**(容忍) a missed cue, but not a **gloomy**(黑暗的), **prosaic**(散文的) delivery that drains the drama of its charm. When a scene goes flat, he does not **bang**(猛击) the table; he simply asks them to **fill**(填满) the silence with feeling.

The play itself is **enjoyable**(愉快的) yet **evident**(明显的) in its message. A **corporate**(社团的) tyrant tries to **levy**(征收) a cruel tax and **oust**(剥夺) a beloved governor; the people, restless dwellers of a poor district, **muster**(集合) their courage. The plot may seem **superfluous**(多余的) at the **radius**(半径) of a single **inch**(英寸), but it slowly will **evolve**(发展) into a study of how grief and an **insult**(侮辱) can **brew**(酿造) into rebellion. A **profile**(侧面) of the villain emerges: timid in private, immense in cruelty in public. The **cellular**(细胞的) detail of each character, down to the smallest nuance, makes the whole feel **solid**(固体的).

Backstage, an old **grandfather**(祖父) who has swept the floors for decades cheers every survivor of opening night. He fills a glass of brew, dots the program with a pencil, and watches the velvet curtain glide up. A **stream**(小河) of applause, an ovation, rises through the theatre. The **scarcity**(缺乏) of such joy in ordinary life is what keeps him here, year after year. To him the standing ovation is no superfluous ritual but a kind of **therapy**(治疗), an invariably honest **sculpture**(雕塑) of human feeling, carved fresh each evening from the immense and steady love of the crowd. Each theatre **dweller**(居住者) and a regular smoker of a **classmate**(同班同学) from his youth often linger after the show. This **player**(游戏的人) was once a **dull**(阴暗的), **thirsty**(口渴的) understudy whose **mien**(风度) betrayed deep **disappointment**(失望); a **rift**(裂缝) with the **orthodox**(正统的), **possessive**(所有的) old guard had nearly ended his **involvement**(卷入) in the craft. But he refused to **dissatisfy**(使不满) his own ambition. After a minor **incision**(切割) near his larynx and a long recovery, breathing **helium**(氦) -light and easy again, he learned to **handle**(柄) a role with **fluid**(流动的) grace, to **cheer**(振奋) rather than **agitate**(摇动) a nervous cast, and to treat improvisation as a sacred **prerogative**(特权). At a **plenary**(完全的) **rehearse**(排练) before opening, the **majority**(多数) of the cast gathered around a **buffet**(餐室) of **ham**(火腿) sandwiches, **nickel**(镍) coffee urns, and **whiting**(白粉) fish; they would **dot**(小圆点) napkins with notes, knot a **rope**(绳) of cues, and measure each pause to the **millimetre**(毫米). Some grumbled the **overdue**(迟到的) **invention**(发明) of a new lighting rig was an unwanted **entertainment**(娱乐) expense, but no one stayed dissatisfied for long. A **landed**(卸货的) patron, born of a **sailing**(启航的) family, had funded it. By curtain the whole troupe felt, against every disappointment, that art itself could **assassinate**(暗杀) despair.

## 80. The Archives Expedition

I want to **relate**(叙述), **by**(被) way of a brief **narrative**(叙述性的), the **past**(过去的ad) **expedition**(远征) our **association**(联盟) mounted under the **auspice**(赞助) of a **major**(主要的n) university. Our **goal**(球门) was the **cemetery**(公墓) **archives**(档案) of an ancient site in **Egypt**(埃及), where an **honorable**(可敬的) scholar believed a **miracle**(奇迹) of preservation lay buried. I packed my **briefcase**(公文包) and a **portable**(轻便的) **filing**(档案管理) kit, **never**(永不) imagining how a single **drive**(开) across the desert would change my view of **politics**(政治), of **posterity**(子孙), and of myself.

The lead researcher, a **smart**(漂亮的) and **obliging**(亲切的) man, was no **timid**(胆怯的) bachelor of theory; he had real **conceptive**(有想像力的) power. "All(全部的) of us," he said, "carry the **onus**(责任) of honest work. Do not **exaggerate**(夸大), do not **generalize**(概括), and never **defer**(推迟) a hard question." His **brother-in-law**(姻兄), a **creditworthy**(有信誉的) **consumer**(消费者)-goods broker, had funded the trip, but the man refused to let money **impose**(征) on the science. When a **glut**(供过于求v) of cheap rumors threatened to **infest**(大批滋生) the project, he would simply **slam**(砰地关上) the briefcase shut and **stride**(大踏步走) out to clear his head.

The work was **almost**(几乎) pure **chore**(家务杂事). We would **bore**(钻孔) into packed earth, **tow**(拖n) equipment by **motor**(发动机) across the **lot**(许多), and **grab**(攫取) any fragment the **net**(网) of our sieve caught. A faint **wavelength**(波长) on the **metric**(米制的) scanner, **equivalent**(相等的) to a heartbeat, made the whole **machine**(机器) **vibrate**(摆动). Algae, **deuterium**(化) traces, **kerosene**(煤油) lamps, even an old **palm**(手掌)-sized **trophy**(战利品) of bronze emerged from the **dark**(黑暗的). Each **fleeting**(飞逝的) find felt like **regeneration**(再生) of a lost world. I learned to **persevere**(锲而不舍) through **exasperation**(愤慨), to **ventilate**(使通风) the tomb so no one fainted, and to file every **chart**(海图) **faithfully**(忠诚地).

**Incidentally**(偶然地), the **awkwardness**(笨拙) of our first week gave way to something **fashionable**(流行的) among the team: a quiet pride. A **westerner**(西方人) on the crew, once prone to **misunderstanding**(误会) the locals, grew to respect them; an **unkind**(不仁慈的) remark would now earn a **glide**(滑动) of disapproving silence. We learned that **voting**(有投票权的) on every decision, however **restless**(焦躁不安的) it made us, kept the **autonomy**(自治) of the group intact and warded off **aggression**(侵略). The **proceeds**(收益) of the dig, the **jewelry**(珠宝) and the records, were never ours to own; they belonged to Egypt and to posterity. As the **silver**(银) dawn rose over the desert and a stray **dog**(狗) trotted past my **desk**(书桌) in the **garage**(车库)-turned-office, I sat at the garage table and wrote it all down, sure that this **dishonor**(耻辱v)-free, faithfully kept account would outlast us all. On **Friday**(星期五) the team would gather for a **preparatory**(预备的) **seminar**(研究班), a relaxed **news**(新闻) briefing where each **volunteer**(自愿) could **dilate**(扩大) on the week and not **lag**(走得慢) behind. We treated **experimental**(实验的) methods and old methods **equally**(相等地), attentive to every **nuance**(细微差别); a sample of **alga**(藻类) from the tomb wall, we agreed, held no **exclusivity**(独家经营权) over a coin. When the season ended, the locals gave us a warm **ovation**(热烈欢迎) we would never forget.

## 81. The Earl's Coffee Estate

On a **fine**(晴朗的) morning, the **urbane**(彬彬有礼的) **earl**(伯爵) chose to **sit**(坐) **in**(在...里) his study at the **northeast**(东北) **hub**(毂) of his estate, sipping **coffee**(咖啡) and reading a **memo**(备忘录) about the season's crop. The mansion stood at a high **altitude**(高度) above a wide **estuary**(河口), where flat-bottomed boats still **ply**(使用) the brown water. He was a man of unusual **sanity**(心智健全) in troubled times, an **analytic**(分析的) thinker who had **always**(总是) refused to **collaborate**(协作) with the **fascism**(法西斯) then spreading across the **west**(西).

His **primary**(最初的) concern this **time**(时间) was the estate's **prosperity**(繁荣), which seemed to be in slow **descent**(下降). Earlier that year he had nearly **lost**(失去的) everything. A **gaunt**(憔悴的), **miserable**(悲惨的) winter had forced **strenuous**(奋发的) work on everyone, and a late frost would **freeze**(使结冰) the buds and **startle**(惊吓) the hens, whose **yolk**(蛋黄)-rich eggs were sold along a fixed **route**(路线) into town. For years a near-**monopoly**(垄断) had let his family **pamper**(纵容) its workers, but a **dearth**(缺乏) of rain and a plague of **pest**(害虫) had left the soil **brittle**(易碎的) and the harvest **dim**(暗的). A **stubborn**(顽固的) **bacterium**(细菌) was attacking the **oak**(橡树) windbreaks and even the coffee shrubs.

The **veterinary**(兽医) surgeon came to **warn**(警告) him that the **drug**(药物) used on each **animal**(动物) might not **penetrate**(穿过) the new strain, and he advised the earl to **integrate**(使一体化) modern methods rather than **sneak**(偷偷地走) by on tradition. A government **reshuffle**(改组) had done little for growers, and distant **ASEAN**(东盟) trade talks threatened to reshape the whole **situation**(形势) overnight. As an **employer**(雇主), the earl decided to **exercise**(练习) patience; he would not let **outrage**(暴行) **sabotage**(阴谋破坏) his judgment, nor let worry **preoccupy**(使迷住) him.

He hired a young **mechanic**(技工) with an **elementary**(基本的) but **concrete**(有形的) grasp of machinery to repair a **vehicle**(车辆交通工具) whose **exhaust**(排气) had failed, and a **discreet**(谨慎的) agronomist to run a **qualitative**(质的) survey of the **discrete**(不连续的) plots. The two roles were **interdependent**(相互依赖的) and formed a useful **interface**(接合部位) between tradition and science: one could **untie**(解开) a tangled engine, the other could **observe**(观察) with **concentrated**(全神贯注的) care every **cubic**(立方形的) meter of soil. Their findings would **prove**(证明) decisive, and the fields **partially**(部分地) recovered.

By the **climax**(顶点) of the season the reforms had taken hold, and others rushed to **mimic**(模仿的) them. A national **league**(同盟) of growers gave him an **award**(授予); even the local **bishop**(主教) praised the work, and a **commuter**(通勤者) newspaper printed his **photograph**(照片), though he asked them to use a **pseudonym**(假名) to avoid **superficial**(表面的) fame. He refused to crush rivals, for he believed in **equity**(公平), not the urge to **annihilate**(消灭) competition. Watching the **moon**(月球) rise over the **smooth**(光滑的) water, he felt the **incompatibility**(不兼容) between greed and **humanity**(人类) dissolve. The **empty**(空的) fields would soon **enlarge**(扩大) into orchards. A worker in a dripping **raincoat**(雨衣) walked **down**(下) past the grain **elevator**(电梯), gave a **grin**(露齿而笑) and a **whisper**(耳语) of thanks, then ran to catch the morning **bus**(公共汽车), and his daughter waved from the little **hairdress**(美发) shop she ran in town.

## 82. Memoir of an Industrial Town

In my **memoir**(回忆录) I wanted to **reveal**(展现), **truly**(真正地) and **explicitly**(清晰地), what it felt like to grow up in a grimy town during the **era**(时代) when steel came to **industrialize**(工业化) the valley. From the **standpoint**(立场) of a child, the place held a strange **magic**(魔术), though a **sober**(未醉的) **adult**(成年人) would, in the dour **fashion**(流行式样) of grown-ups, **assume**(假定) it was merely **dingy**(脏的). It was a **distinct**(清楚的) world, and people there knew how to **live**(活). Let me **commemorate**(纪念) it **calmly**(平静地), neither in **anguish**(痛苦) nor in **contempt**(轻蔑).

The town sat on the **periphery**(外围) of a great **works**(工厂) whose **grid**(格子) of pipes hissed day and night. My father was a **superintendent**(管理人) there, an **ambitious**(有抱负的) but **obstinate**(顽固的) man who would never **capitulate**(有条件投降) to the owners. He kept a memoir of his own, a thin **pamphlet**(小册子) full of an **assortment**(花色品种) of complaints about **management**(经营), which he would **ramble**(漫步) through at supper. I did not **hate**(恨) the place, yet I **wonder**(惊奇) now how we managed to **overcome**(战胜) the daily **hardship**(艰难). To weigh his grievances against the bosses, owner **versus**(对) worker, was his favorite supper game, and he would **tally**(吻合) each side on his fingers, his **metabolism**(新陈代谢) of resentment never slowing.

Mother cooked plain **cuisine**(厨房烹调法): **mutton**(羊肉) stew with a thick **crust**(面包) of bread, warmed quickly in our first **microwave**(微波), an **abnormal**(变态的) luxury then. We were not **well-to-do**(小康的), but we ate enough; the food was **sufficiently**(足够地) filling. On winter mornings she would **adjust**(校准) my **mitten**(连指手套) and warn me of the **deathly**(致死的) cold with calm **precaution**(预防), an **indication**(指出) of love rather than fear. I would dash to catch the rattling **streetcar**(有轨电车), a **kite**(风筝) of newspaper made to **scurry**(急赶) past my feet, and **reach**(抵达) school just as the bell rang. The way we dressed was its own austere fashion, and the seasons gave a distinct rhythm to where we would live and work.

My **tutor**(导师), a **critic**(批评家) of careless work, set a **mandatory**(命令的) standard. He held the **intense**(强烈的) view that no pupil should **underestimate**(低估) grammar; he made us list each **antonym**(反义词), learn the **inward**(向内) logic of every sentence, and **search**(搜索) a worn **catalog**(目录) of poems. He sang an old **carol**(颂歌) off-key, to our quiet **embarrassment**(窘迫), yet there was an honest **bond**(契约) between us. He spoke with **awe**(敬畏) of distant cities and of the **inexorable**(无情的) march of progress. I used to assume his every word was true, and I valued his **intimate**(亲密的) counsel; he welcomed my **input**(输入) even when the harvest of a meager **crop**(作物) made everyone short-tempered.

The **predominance**(优越) of the mills could not last. As demand began to **wane**(变小) in a **volatile**(飞行的) market, the company tried to **evict**(驱逐) whole streets and impose a **ban**(禁令) on the union. There was talk of **forgery**(锻炉) in the accounts, and an inspector came to **adjudicate**(判决) the dispute, his findings tallying poorly with the firm's. The **realization**(实现) that the era was ending came like a **hurricane**(飓风). **Subsequent**(接着的) years brought a **tragic**(悲剧的) decline; **sewage**(下水道) filled the canals, and the great **vat**(大桶) in which they once mixed the alloy stood empty, every **impurity**(不纯) left to rust.

Yet the people did not **masquerade**(化妆舞会) as victims. From the **outermost**(最外面的) cottage to the manager's house, families lived on, the **operator**(操作人员) and the laborer alike. Looking back from the **direction**(方向) of old age, I **feast**(筵席) on these memories. The **transmission**(传递) of such stories is, I think, a **pressing**(急迫的) duty: to **sterilize**(杀菌) nothing, to record both the **disc**(圆盘) of the sun over the slag heaps and the awe-filled **landing**(上岸) of the first jet at the new airfield that the children would one day call home.

## 83. The Biographer at the Excavation

As a **biographer**(传记记者) and a **Swedish**(瑞典人) documentary maker, I had to **peruse**(仔细阅读) a **plethora**(过剩) of dusty papers before I could **explore**(考察) the ruined fortress where the famous **German**(德国的) general had endured a long **siege**(围困). My **forte**(长处) was patience, and the work demanded the **best**(最好的) of it. The local guide, a **cheerful**(快乐的) **baker**(面包师) by trade and an amateur historian by **temperament**(气质), met me at the **mailbox**(信箱) of the old post house and offered me a glass of **herbal**(草药的) **wine**(葡萄酒).

We drove **farther**(更远地) up the **angular**(角状的) ridge, past a deep **chasm**(深坑) and an **inactive**(无行动的) gas **pipeline**(管道), until the **field**(田野) opened before us. The **coolness**(凉爽) of the dawn made me **exhale**(呼气) slowly. There, half buried in **powder**(粉末)-fine **dust**(灰尘), lay a **corpse**(尸体) of stone: a fallen **statue**(塑像) whose **terse**(简洁的) inscription, by no **negligible**(可忽略不计的) **oversight**(监视) of the original mason, named the wrong king. To the **credit**(信誉) of earlier scholars, the error was an honest one. I took out my **digital**(数字的) camera and my survey **kit**(所有装备) and began to record.

The **selection**(选择) of what to film was never simple. With grave **appreciation**(欣赏) I framed the **diamond**(金钢石)-shaped courtyard, then caught a sudden **glimpse**(一瞥) of a carved **porpoise**(动) on a broken **seal**(海豹). My guide, who would sometimes **harangue**(尤指指责性的) tourists about **foreign**(外国的) looters, grew almost **hysteric**(亢奋的) with delight. "Do not let this **gem**(宝石) **rot**(腐烂) in obscurity," he said, his voice rising in an **upward**(向上的) sweep. "To **dignify**(使尊荣) the dead is no mere **imposition**(强迫接受); it is a sacred **standard**(标准)."

Inside, the air smelled of old **fodder**(饲料) and damp **cartilage**(解剖) left from some animal that had died here. I felt a **vague**(不明确的) unease, the kind that can **derive**(取得) from any ruin where men once chose **suicide**(自杀) over surrender. A single **dart**(标) of light pierced a crack and seemed to **envelop**(包) a heap of rusted armor. I did not **complain**(抱怨); such moments **expend**(消费) the soul yet feed it.

We worked to **rehabilitate**(使康复) the site, not to exploit it. Every **gram**(克) and every **ton**(吨) of debris was logged. To **agonize**(使痛苦) over each fragment would be **unworkable**(行不通的), so I set a simple **criterion**(标准) and let the team **supervise**(监督) themselves while I **worship**(礼拜), in my own quiet way, the craft that originated here. A foreign foundation had agreed to **expose**(使暴露) the find to the public through a single **broadcast**(广播), a true **milestone**(里程碑), and to underwrite the **application**(申请) for a grant whose value, the curator joked, was **inestimable**(无价的).

By dusk a small **crowd**(人群) had gathered. I heard one boy **whistle**(口哨) and **overhear**(无意中听到) another claim, with comic **superiority**(优越), that the fort had been built to **lubricate**(使润滑) trade between two valleys. It was, of course, an **exception**(例外) to no rule of history; an **ailment**(疾病) of pride had brought it down, **simultaneous**(同时发生的) with famine. We loaded the last **crate**(一箱), dodged a passing flock of **poultry**(家禽), and drove home through the **suburban**(郊区的) lanes, the engine's **reverse**(相反) gear whining, our minds set with full **concentration**(集中) on the ancient lives we would, **sometime**(将来某个时候) soon, **retroactive**(可追溯的) justice fulfilled, bring back into the light. Back at my desk, the **receiver**(收受者) of my old phone buzzed as the museum confirmed the find; I felt a **supreme**(最高的) calm, free at last of the low-grade **neurosis**(神经症) that any long **process**(过程) can **originate**(发生) in a tired mind. There was no **space**(间隔) now for doubt. With sincere **sympathy**(同情) for the curators who feared the project might **fail**(失败), I promised to **undo**(解开) every careless note and rewrite the report from the start.

## 84. The Sculptor's Vocational Journey

Ms. (女士) Adair, a **venerable** (庄严的) **Scotsman** (苏格兰人) by descent and a **learner** (学习者) all her life, ran a **vocational** (职业的) program that taught young people to **chisel** (凿子) **stone** (石). Her own **maternal** (母亲的) grandmother had been an **elite** (<法>) craftswoman, and Ms. Adair was **loath** (憎恶的) to let that **backbone** (脊梁骨) of skill fade. "Compare (比较) any **chemical** (化学的n) shortcut to honest labor," she would say, "and you will **return** (返回) to the chisel." Her **exterior** (外部的) was stern, yet her **cognitive** (认知的) frankness made students less **envious** (嫉妒的) than grateful.

The **systematic** (有系统的) curriculum had a **predictable** (可预言的), **seasonal** (季节性的) **pattern** (模式). In the warm months students worked outdoors until **sunburn** (晒黑) forced them under the **bungalow** (平房) roof beside the **plantation** (种植园) that bordered the school. Each pupil learned to **subtract** (减去) waste from a block, to **pave** (铺) a path, and to **react** (反应) calmly when a piece cracked. The **endurance** (忍耐力) this demanded was no small **extent** (广度) of their training; an **unfortunate** (不幸的) slip could ruin a week's effort, and the **disillusion** (觉醒vt) that followed tested even the most **prepared** (准备好的).

One **immediate** (立即的) problem that **protracted** (延长了的) into the **eighth** (第八) and **seventh** (第七) week was a dearth of good **mineral** (矿物) stone. The **consultant** (会诊医师) they hired, a **frank** (坦白的) elderly **builder** (建筑工人), plugged a lamp into a wall **socket** (窝) near the **temple** (庙宇)-shaped studio, unrolled a **sketch** (草图), and spoke with **exalted** (高贵的) certainty. "This region was **once** (一次) a **hinterland** (内地) of quarries," he said. "The **industry** (工业) here could pave the way for a true revival. Let **imagination** (想象), not mere **want** (想要), guide you."

He was a **namesake** (同姓的人) of a long-**dead** (死的) sculptor, a coincidence that delighted the **dormitory** (宿舍) at night. The students would compare their work, **mourn** (哀悼) a failed **bud** (芽) of an idea, and feel a strange **sensation** (感觉) of awe at how a **plump** (丰满的) lump of clay could, once shaped, **redound** (增加) to their pride. To **avail** (有益于) themselves of every chance, they categorized each tool and stowed it with care, lest a careless mishap **miscarry** (未运到) the whole project.

Winter brought **ultraviolet** (紫外线的) warnings and thinning **ozone** (新鲜的空气) in the news, plus a **tax** (税) debate that reached even this quiet northern town. Ms. Adair remained **obedient** (服从的) to her own rule: **beauty** (美) first, profit later. She would not let the dead weight of **difficult** (困难的) bookkeeping crush the **feeling** (感情) of joy. When a wealthy patron offered to **reimburse** (偿还) the cost of marble shipped from **Oceania** (大洋洲), she accepted, then used part of the **cannon** (大炮)-shaped fountain commission to buy **cosmetics** (化妆品) and small wares as prizes.

The final show was magnificent. An **orchestra** (管弦乐队) played while a **balloon** (气球) drifted over the courtyard and a single **liquid** (液体a) line of light traced each finished statue. Critics from as far as the **upper** (上面的) coast came; some, plainly envious, called the work a **prophecy** (预言) of a new school, comparing it to the **calcium** (化)-white classical busts of old. Ms. Adair only smiled. Her **plasma** (解) of ambition had never been about fame. The **fascination** (入迷) she felt, watching a once-obedient student grow bold, was reward enough. She picked up a fresh **ware** (商品), examined a **sneeze** (打喷嚏)-inducing cloud of dust in the **ambient** (周围的) light, and, **ineffective** (效率低的) tools set aside, named her favorite piece after the **nostril** (鼻孔)-flaring lad who had carved it, sealing his **adoption** (收养) into the long, proud line of her craft. History, she liked to say, would **vindicate** (维护) the slow trades: while empires **plunder** (抢劫) and armies **jam** (压紧) the roads in panic, while waves of **emigration** (向国外移民) empty whole villages, a **center** (中心) of patient skill endures. She paid the marble bill in a single **instalment** (分期付款), refused to **categorize** (加以类别) art by price, and taught each pupil to **stow** (装载) a tool and to **name** (名字vt) a stone with equal respect, knowing how far one lesson could **ramify** (分枝) through a life.

## 85. A Layman's Guide to Modern Medicine

Before(在...以前) you assume that medicine is only for the **genius**(天才) or the **autonomous**(自治的) specialist, **hear**(听见) a **layman**(外行) **explain**(解释) it in **general**(一般的) terms, **preferably**(更好地) with a **daily**(每日的ad), **optimistic**(乐观主义的) attitude. A **famous**(著名的) **statesman**(政治家) once said that to **know**(知道) your own body is a **religious**(宗教的) duty; that **proposition**(主张), though **archaic**(古老的) in **wording**(措辞), still applies. This **chapter**(章), free of the **artificial**(人工的) gloss of a glossy **commercial**(贸易的), will **equip**(装备) you with a working **vocabulary**(词汇).

Start with the basics. The body has a remarkable **elasticity**(弹性), and doctors **classify**(把...分类) symptoms much as you would sort **miscellaneous**(各色各样混在一起) items into a **basket**(筐). Doctors **assess**(评价) each case, often **unconditional**(无条件的) in their care, and rarely **fastidious**(难取悦的) to the point of cruelty. When you **apply**(要求) for a hospital **membership**(会员资格) or seek a **loan**(借出物) to cover surgery, an **arbitrator**(仲裁员) or auditor may review your file; an **audit**(审计) is routine, not a sign of **guilty**(有罪的) wrongdoing.

Consider the **flu**(流感). It seems trivial, yet for a **minority**(少数) of patients it is grave. A **neurotic**(神经病患者) or hysteric reaction helps no one; calm **politeness**(礼貌) toward the nurse in her crisp **uniform**(制服) does. If a **downpour**(倾盆大雨) soaks you on the **pavement**(人行道) and you feel **sour**(酸的) and **desolate**(荒芜的), that **misgiving**(疑虑) is natural, but it is no excuse to **wander**(漫游) off your **itinerary**(路线) of care. The **gradual**(逐渐的) return of health is the true **excellence**(优秀).

Modern surgery can **transplant**(移植) organs, **amputate**(切除) a ruined limb, or—through **vaccination**(接种)—prevent disease before it can **saturate**(使饱和) the blood. A surgeon may apply **hypnosis**(催眠状态) to soothe a patient, equip a ward with an **amber**(琥珀) night-light, or **scatter**(打散) staff across a busy floor like seeds across a field. Even the **indigenous**(本土的) herbal lore of remote villages, once thought **illusive**(幻觉的), now informs commercial research; the **gush**(涌出) of new data is hard to classify.

Think of the **lining**(衬里) of a coat, or the **watertight**(不漏水的) seam of a **gown**(长袍): each layer has a purpose. So too the body. A **drunkard**(醉鬼) who poisons his liver, a **widower**(鳏夫) who lets grief gush unchecked, a **girl**(少女) who ignores a sore throat—each underestimates the cost. The **independent**(独立的) statesman, the religious **gentleman**(绅士), the **Catholic**(天主教教徒) nun, the **granddaughter**(孙女) learning **English**(英语) from a **dictionary**(词典): none is exempt. **Unless**(除非prep) we **modernize**(使现代化) our habits, we pay later.

My **random**(随便) advice, drawn from a **magnificent**(宏伟的) body of study, is simple. Equip yourself with knowledge. Treat the **prosecutor**(检察官) of bad health—neglect—as your enemy. When a **distributorship**(分销权) of clinics or a **wholesale**(批发) supplier markets a product, read the **asterisk**(星号) and the fine print. A proposition that sounds too magnificent is often a **preposition**(介词) away from a trap. Stay sober in judgment, keep your **image**(形象) of health clear, and let no **embankment**(堤防) of fear, no **solvency**(偿付能力) worry, no **reappraisal**(重新估计) of your worth keep you from the **dining-room**(餐厅) of good life. Equip, assess, and act. Hospitals now **employ**(雇用) physicists who study how a single **neutron**(中子) behaves in scanning equipment, and good clinics **earmark**(标记) funds for prevention rather than cure. Health is no narrow **sexual**(性的) or private secret; it is an **outdoor**(室外的) matter of clean air and sunlight, of a quiet hour on a **balcony**(阳台), of returning now and then to your own **birthplace**(出生地) to walk familiar paths. Turn your attention **inwards**(向内的), plant the **seed**(种子v) of one good habit, and let it grow.

## 86. The Carpenter Who Rebuilt the Harbor Town

In July(七月), a gorgeous(令人十分愉快的) southern(南方的) light fell over the seashore(海滨) town, and a lad(男孩) named Tomas stood in the yard(院) behind his cellar(地窖) workshop. He was a carpenter(木工) by trade, habitual(习惯性的) in his work, and the message(消息) that reached him that morning would change everything. The local economy(节约) had suffered a great loss(丧失); the old superstructure(上部构造) of the wharf had begun to creep(慢慢地) and crumble, and the bottom-line(末行数字) of the council's budget looked bleak(寒冷的). The success(成就) of any repair was uncertain, but Tomas was not indifferent(不感兴趣的).

He loaded a barge(驳船) with timber, a carton(纸盒) of nails, and a soda(苏打) for the road. A migrant(迁移的) crew, lawful(合法的) and hardworking, helped him stow the cargo. The shipping(船运) company had sent finished(制成的) beams and planks fresh from a processing(加工) yard; the manufacturer(制造商)'s catalog, quoted at a cif(到岸价) price, promised they would not flatten(把...弄平) or warp. Tomas would measure each one, for accurate measurement(衡量) was, in his view, a requisite(需要的n) of any honest craft. He refused to portray(描写) cheap work as good; he had nothing but contempt for advertising(广告的) that hid the exact(确切的) truth, and he would enumerate(列举) every fault aloud rather than stay silent. A former(以前的) apprentice, now a meat-shop owner, lent him an old mincer(粉碎机) to grind paint pigment and a sack of crushed ore(矿石) for ballast.

As they worked, a puppy(小狗) crept near, and an old hostess(女主人) from the inn brought clothes(衣服) and a pan(平底锅) of food. The men did not grumble(埋怨); even when a sudden clash(金属碰撞声) of opinion threatened to creep into a quarrel, prudence(谨慎) and the foreman's authentic(可信的) kindness restrained it. One worker tried to sneer(冷笑) at the slow pace, but Tomas would not let impatience curb(勒马的皮带) the perfection(尽善尽美) he sought. "We must not impair(削弱) the frame," he said, "nor inflict(使遭受) a hidden flaw that doom will later expose."

The scene was picturesque(似画的), almost like a mirage(海市蜃楼): vines on the southern wall, a robot(机器人) crane lent by a modern firm, a wedge(楔子) of light over the water. Tomas would wrap(包裹) a splint(藤条) of oak around a cracked post, compress(压缩) the joint, and nail a carton-thin board to hide the seam. He would eliminate(排除) every weak point, encircle(环绕) each pillar with iron, and reduce(减少) the risk of collapse. He would not be the cause of the harbor's downfall(衰败).

By nine(九pron) that evening the men were awake(醒着的vt) but weary. A surgeon(外科医生) from the next avenue(林荫路), summoned for a minor cut, praised their measurement and their nerve. The poison(毒物) of doubt had no hold here. Tomas thought of the mercantile(贸易的) glory the town once knew, of the gaudy(华而不实的) festivals, the wedding(婚礼) processions down the main avenue, the trail(痕迹) of lanterns along the pavement. He would liberate(解放) the town from decay. He picked up his nozzle(管口) and hose to clear(清晰的vt) the drain, flicked a flap(拍打) of canvas over the fresh wood, and felt, despite the shameful(可耻的) neglect of years past, a clear and gorgeous hope. The language(语言) of good work, he knew, needs no translation; it speaks in every yard of solid timber. The robot crane hummed; the lad smiled; the harbor would live.

Later, in the town stadium(露天运动场), the mayor gave a ponderous(沉重的) monologue(独白) that some called epoch-making(划时代的), though a blunt fisherman muttered, "Oh, fuck(浑蛋) the speeches." Tomas, a former apprentice now a master, was decidedly(明确地) calm. He would not be the judge(法官) of politics. He let his plans materialize(使具体化) on paper, enumerate each cost on a line marked cif for the imported steel and iron ore, and restrain(阻止) his impatient(不耐烦的) hopes. The automatic(自动的) saw whirled near a vine(葡萄树)-covered fence. A neighbor used a mincer to prepare stuffing(填塞料) for a roast, and Tomas would cook(厨师v) a simple supper at home. He clutched a worn garment(衣服) to his bosom(胸) against the night chill. This was no fiction(虚构), no idle processing of dreams; it was real work, and it was good.

## 87. A Hot-Air Balloon Festival in April

Certainly(一定) the most romantic(浪漫的) event of our year is the ballooning(热气球飞行运动) festival held in April(四月), nearly(差不多) at the foot of the mountain(山). To be(是) there at sunrise(日出), when the first balloon lifts and the music(音乐) of a brass band drifts over the field, is to feel a zest(风味) for life that no trivial(不重要的) worry can deprive(剥夺). I will reply(回答) at once to anyone who calls it a freak(怪诞的思想) hobby: they simply have not tried it.

My uncle, a grown-up(成长的) who never lost his boyish wonder, taught me the trade. He would shave(剃) at dawn, light his pipe of tobacco(烟草), and forecast(预报) the weather with an accuracy the local viewer(观察者) of the weekly(每星期的) broadcast could not match. "The wind is erratic(无确定路线) today," he might gasp(喘气), half out of breath, "so we adjust the diet(饮食) of fuel and watch the gauge." His anatomy(剖析) of the sport was thorough, almost clinical(临床的), and his yearly(每年的) notes filled a thick file.

Conversely(相反地), my aunt was inefficient(效率低的) with the ropes but a genius with people. She would console(安慰) a nervous first-timer, hush(沉默int) a crying child, and offer popcorn(爆米花) and a glass of champagne(香槟酒) to anyone who looked pale. Her zest for hospitality gave the festival its prominence(显着). She disliked any deception(欺诈); a salesman who once tried a sly back-call(第二次访问) to upsell cheap gear got a mute(哑的), distinctly(显然) cold reply, and she sent him off with a limp(柔软的) wave and a yawn(打呵欠).

The science is real, though laymen find it enlightening(给人启发的). Hot air, being neutral(中立的) and light, expands and the craft rises; cool it, and you descend. A periodic(周期的) check of the network(网状物) of valves is mandatory. One must never underestimate the strain(拉紧) on the fabric, nor the threat(恐吓) of a sudden gust. A humanitarian(博爱的n) group even uses balloons to extend(伸出) aid to flooded country(国家) districts, dropping a supplementary(补充的) parcel of food where a bomber(轰炸机) could never safely fly.

This year a contemporary(同时代的) artist, a luxurious(爱好奢侈的) dreamer with a fortune(运气) to spend, painted his balloon to imply(意指) the migration of the locust(蝗虫) and the grasshopper(蚱蜢) across the plain, a strange but striking image. A clinical psychologist gave a talk on the temptation(引诱) to overwork and the suffering(苦难) it breeds; she urged us, economically(节约地) and otherwise, to rest. Even the Egyptian(埃及的n) consul, a descendant(子孙) of an ancient line, came to acclaim(喝彩) the show, and an old Swede(瑞典人) in a tan(棕褐色vt) jacket wept with quiet pity(可怜) at its beauty.

As the climax neared, fifty(五十) balloons rose at once. A volley(齐射) of cheers went up. The performance(演出) was flawless. I felt my own anguish of the past year drain(排水管) away. To imply that such joy is mere escape would be to misread it; it is, rather, a phase(阶段) of healing. Whatever doom(毁灭) the headlines forecast, here, for a few(有些) apiece(每个)-bought hours, we were free. The literature(文学) of flight, I thought, is written not in books but in the slow, ginger(姜) ascent of a single bright sphere into the morning sky, and I would borrow(借) that feeling for as long as I could, fully(完全) and without apology, before the limp ropes called me back to earth and sleep(睡n).

If I must give a brief synopsis(大纲) of why this endeavor(努力) matters, it is this. The festival's success rate(速率) is no accident; we accommodate(提供住宿) every type(型式) of visitor, from the child who points at a platypus(动) drawn on a banner to the retiree living on a modest annuity(年金). Volunteers work overtime(超时的) without complaint, and any variance(分歧) in the schedule is posted early so no one need disagree(有分歧) at the gate. We expand(扩大) the program each year, replacing every dead bulb(鳞茎) in the night display and refusing to let litter contaminate(污染) the field. The crew that runs the propane will not trigger(扳机) a single careless spark; safety is the prime ingredient(成分) of the whole affair. No one is dragged off to jail(监狱) for a mistake, but no one cuts a corner either.

## 88. The Painter and the Physicist Next Door

The inn(小旅馆) at the edge of the wharf(码头) was a busy(忙) place, though(可是) its grey(灰色的) walls and the stain(染料) on the canvas(粗帆布) awning made it look secondhand(二手的) and dismal(阴郁的). Inside, a thin(薄的) painter sat at a table set with a menu(菜单), a jar of olive(橄榄) paste, and a bowl of fresh(新鲜的) carrot(胡萝卜) scraps the cook had spared. He had come to rest(休息), yet his mind was an ongoing(正在进行的) racket(吵闹声) of ideas. He pinned a sketch to the wall with a single thumbtack(按钉), his old passion(激情) for science still burning like a fire(火). He would not divorce(离婚) his art from science, he said, and that very claim(要求) made his work fresh. Painting, for him, was no juvenile(青少年的) pastime nor mere moonlighting(业余干活); it was a manufactured(制成的) world standing on the surface(表面) of real laws.

Next(紧接的) door, behind a rug(地毯) that hung as(同样地conj) a curtain, lived a quiet professor(教授), a mathematician(数学家) and sometime biologist(生物学家) who lectured on the curriculum(课程) of optics(光学) at the college to the south(南). His tongue(舌头) could explain the theory of relativity(相关) as easily as a child describes snow(雪). He spoke of the acceleration(加速) of light, the breadth(宽度) of a sphere(球) of stars, and the impact(影响) of one idea upon another, all as themselves(他们自己) a kind of mathematics(数学). The painter would lick(舔) the tip of his brush, pinch(捏) a fresh tube of grey, and listen.

"Evidence(明显)," the professor said, "is the prime(主要的) burden(担子) of any honest mind. A terrorist(恐怖分子) or a gangster hides behind secrecy; a scientist must seek publicity for the truth." He held that a society too permissive(允许的) of deception would breed its own deadly(致命的) decline. He would rejoice(欣喜) at a clean proof and grumble at a sloppy one. Computerization(计算机化), he admitted, had changed his field; an ultrasonic(超声的n) scan or an X-ray now gave data he once had to fumble(摸索) for by hand.

The painter, for his part, worked in a different setting(镶嵌). He would twist(捻) a coil(盘绕) of wire into a small sculpture, nestle(安顿) it on a perch(栖木) of driftwood, and call it done. A vender(商贩) at the next stall, eager to repute(声誉v) himself a critic, would sneer, but the painter was willing(愿意的) to ignore him. Context(背景), he believed, was everything; a scrap(碎片) of color in the right place had more competence(能力) to move the heart than a whole museum.

One grey morning the two men shared a check-up(核对) of the season's plans. The professor proposed a referendum(公民投票) among their friends: should they introduce(介绍) a joint show, mixing canvas and equation? The painter, twisting a grin, agreed at once. "A minimum(最小量) of fuss," he said, "and a maximum of wonder." They would not conceal their aim. To honor an old appointment(约会), they invited the grandparent(祖父) of a neighbor, a retired commune(公社) organizer, to open it. As the snow fell outside in stillness(寂静), they drew up the plan, signed it, asked a witness to countersign(副署), and felt, for the first time in a year, that their separate spheres had at last begun to touch. The next phase, they agreed, would prove harder, but neither doubted it was worth the burden, nor that the glamour(亦作glamor) of the idea would, in time, repay every hour of their labor.

There was, of course, no doubt(怀疑) left in their minds. They would seek no asylum(庇护) in vanity and take no bribe(贿赂) of easy praise. The professor, who had once worked in banking(银行业务) before fleeing a capitalist(资本主义的) scheme he found offensive(冒犯的), spoke of an intermediate(中间的) plan: a slow removal(移动) of every weak piece, then a fierce, tigress(母虎)-like defense of the strong. As a former defendant(被告) in a petty dispute, he knew how the law could repeal(撤销) goodwill(商誉) overnight; he would not contend(斗争) with rivals of high rank(军衔), nor try to repatriate(遣返) old grudges. He swatted a mosquito(蚊子), smiled at the odd mixture(混合) of paint and chalk dust on his sleeve, and let the matter rest.

## 89. The Museum of an Ancient Trade

On a small **Pacific**(和平的) island once governed from far-off **Ireland**(爱尔兰), an **academic**(学术的) named Dr. Pace set out to **update**(使现代化) an old museum and **popularize**(普及) the **craftsmanship**(手艺) of an **ancient**(古代的) trade. The building was situated near the **water**(水vt), where the salt would **seep**(渗出) into the foundations and the **monsoon**(季候风) each year tested its **defence**(防卫) against the storms. **Currently**(普遍地) the place was dismal, and visitors were few; he wanted to **reconcile**(使和解) its dusty past with a **complete**(完全的), living future.

He began at the entrance **aisle**(通道), where a **thermostat**(自动调温器) now kept the rooms at an even temperature. On the wall, a fresh **rubric**(印) printed in bold gave each exhibit a heading, and a glossy booklet served as a **handout**(施舍物) for every receiver. With a **screwdriver**(螺丝刀) and a steady **forefinger**(食指) he fixed a loose label himself; he would not **mishandle**(装卸不慎) a single relic, nor **conceal**(隐藏) a flaw, for he was a **truthful**(诚实的) and **loyal**(忠诚的) man whose **heart**(心) lay in honest work. He took care not to **violate**() the spirit of the original collection, regardless of pressure from the new **publisher**(出版商) who funded the show.

The museum told the **historical**(历史的) story of the island's **peasantry**(农民). There were tools worn smooth by use: an opener of carved bone, a **jar**(罐坛) that once held **shrimp**(虾) paste, a **saucer**(茶托) of fired clay, and a **cylinder**(圆筒) press a long-dead **inventor**(发明者) had built. A **soldier**(士兵)'s **costume**(装束) hung beside a robber's mask used in an old **pageant**(盛会). Glass cases displayed how the people would **breed**(繁殖) cattle, drive a single loyal **cow**(母牛) to market, and **hatch**(孵出) fish in shallow furrows of seawater. Nearby, a faded **magazine**(杂志) described the whaling crews who once braved the deep, hunting **prey**(捕食) that could, like a **brute**(禽兽), smash a boat to **foam**(泡沫).

Not everyone approved. One **entrenched**(确立的) landowner, **indignant**(愤慨的) and **pathetic**(可怜的) in his anger, claimed the new **tenancy**(租佃) of the building was **disadvantageous**(不利的) to him and **contractual**(合同的) in name only. He sent an **uncalled-for**(不必要的) letter, almost a threat, hinting he might **alienate**(疏远) the island's council. Dr. Pace refused to be intimidated. He would not let such a **brow**(眉)-beating **rebel**(反抗) spoil the work. "I can **compute**(计算) the cost," he said calmly in the **auditorium**(观众席), before a **united**(联合的) **assembly**(集合) of townsfolk and one visiting **pedlar**(小贩), "and I can vouch that the benefit is greater. This is no pretense."

When the doors finally opened, the response was **dazzling**(令人目眩的). A **batch**(一炉) of schoolchildren filed past the **blackboard**(黑板) where a guide chalked diagrams; their **applause**(鼓掌), free of any **conventional**(惯例的) restraint, filled the hall. A **delectable**(使人愉快的) smell of grilled **hamburger**(汉堡包) and **pineapple**(凤梨) drifted from a stall **outside**(向外面n), near the **toilet**(厕所) block and the rows of lockers. The **influence**(影响) of the day was plain: people lingered, took notes in **pencil**(铅笔vt), and left with a sense that the **development**(发展) of their own heritage was, at last, an **entity**(实体) worth protecting. By the eleventh hour, as a soft mist rose over the **dorsal**(背的) ridge of the hills, Dr. Pace stood alone, secure in the **secrecy**(秘密) of his own quiet pride, certain the museum's **slippery**(滑的) decline had been halted and that no ruinous neglect, no **susceptible**(易受影响的) weakness, no **death**(死) of memory would claim it again. The campaign for **publicity**(公开) had not been **ruthless**(残忍的); he had simply let people **pass**(经) through and see for themselves. A retired farmer, his face lined like a **furrow**(犁沟), said the museum had restored his failing **eyesight**(视力) for the past. A **college**(学院) choir sang beside an old **stereo**(立体声录音机), and a reformed **gangster**(匪徒), now a generous **giver**(给予) to charity, donated a relic from another **continent**(大陆), its **outward**(外面的) shine masking a deeper worth. He offered no **apology**(道歉) for caring so much, and added the day's small disbursement to the ledger with a **deposit**(存款) of hope. The **inference**(推论), written **therein**(在那里), was simple: a trade preserved is a people preserved, and the **strategy**(战略) had worked.

## 90. The Queen's Charity and the Village Choir

It is **imperative**(紧急的), the **local**(地方的) **nun**(修女) told the children, that we **aid**(援助) one another, for **assistance**(协作) freely given is always **preferable**(更可取的) to charity offered as a mere **pretense**(借口). She ran a small **parish**(教区) in the **countryside**(乡下), and her every **speech**(演说), however short, seemed **worthy**(值得...的) of a **hymn**(赞美诗). Her **nephew**(侄子), a quiet boy with bright eyes, would **imitate**(模仿) her **grammar**(语法) and her gentle tone, and the **likeness**(同样) made the whole village smile.

The parish was **situated**(位于) where a green hill adjoins a winding river, and a single **subway**(地铁) line, recently extended, now linked it to the town. The local **landlord**(房东), a **firm**(坚固的) but fair man whose family firm supplied grain to half the region, had agreed to **cater**(供应伙食) the harvest feast. He would not **intimidate**(胁迫) his tenants; rather, he sought to **animate**(使有活力) the place, to **lift**(升起) its spirits and **lessen**(减少) its old burdens. He could **vouch**(担保), he said, that the coming year held **plenty**(丰富).

This year the **queen**(女王) herself, **regardless**(不注意的) of the long road, planned to visit. The news did not **awaken**(醒着的) envy so much as joy. The children rehearsed a **dialog**(对话) and a **cartoon**(漫画)-bright pageant; the choir practiced until each voice could **equal**(相等的) the next. A **supplier**(供应商) of costumes sent a **label**(标签)-stamped crate of robes; a **subsidiary**(辅助的) of the town's largest firm donated a **film**(电影) crew to record the day. **Deliberately**(审慎地) and with care, the committee drew up a **heading**(标题) for every part of the program and asked the bishop to **verify**(证实) the order of events.

Science, too, had its place. A visiting teacher gave a talk on the **molecular**(分子的) **life**(生命) of the soil, on the **coefficient**(协同因素) of growth in a healthy field, and on how a single seed, properly tended, could **split**(劈开), sprout, and never **degenerate**(退化的) into waste. He showed an **X-ray**(X射线) of a leaf and a **generalization**(一般化) drawn from years of study, urging the children to **envisage**(正视) a future they could build. "Do not imitate the past blindly," he said. "**Replace**(取代) what fails; **encourage**(鼓励) what works."

The day arrived under a thin **mist**(薄雾) that soon lifted. A **bead**(有孔小珠) of dew still clung to every blade as the queen stepped from her car, her **face**(脸) calm, her **hair**(毛发) tied back with a simple band. She walked the avenue between two rows of villagers, paused before the firm's new **opener**(开罐器)-and-canning works, and admired the craftsmanship of the local carvers. A **drunk**(醉酒的) reveler at the rear was gently steered away, and a **robber**(强盗) who had once plagued the lanes was, the constable noted with **herein**(在此)-recorded relief, long since gone.

Her speech was **outstanding**(突出的), an **everyday**(每日的) warmth raised to something fine. She spoke of equal worth, of the **interaction**(相互作用) between a people and their land, of a life lived in service. She did not animate the crowd with grand pretense but with truth. When she finished, the choir sang their hymn; the sound seemed to **constrict**(压缩) every throat with feeling, then release it in applause. Even the oldest **husband**(丈夫) and wife, **side**(旁边) by side near the **locker**(上锁的人) of old tools, wept. The **whaling**(捕鲸) songs of the coast, the **booklet**(小册子) of local lore, the **romanticism**(浪漫主义) of the poets—all of it, for one bright afternoon, seemed to **hold**(拿着) together, and no **ruinous**(毁灭性的) doubt could touch it. In the days that followed, a quiet **change**(改变) settled over the parish. Each **parent**(父母) helped to **manufacture**(大量制造加工) the small **adornment**(装饰) that would **complement**(补足物) the festival hall, whose **lower**(较低的) wing would **adjoin**(贴近) a new **pioneering**(先驱的) workshop. A printed **description**(描写), no longer than a **ticket**(票) stub, hung by the door, and the nun would **impress**(印) upon every child that they **shall**(将要) keep the place clean. They learned to **separate**(分离的) the good seed from the empty **shell**(壳), to read a thermometer and note the **temperature**(温度), and to **eke**(补充) out a living without bitterness. No **coffin**(棺材) of old grief, no memory of past **persecution**(迫害), could lower their hope. Within the small **arena**(竞技场) of the courtyard, a boy with an artistic **bent**(爱好) dropped a **dime**(一角) into the box for the **eleventh**(第十一) time that week, a modest **disbursement**(支付) toward a brighter year, and the nun, her duty done, gave silent thanks for a day so plainly worthy of memory.

## 91. The Harbour Cafe

As a seasoned **traveler**(旅行者) keeping a **concise**(简明的) journal, I learned that the best stories refuse to stay **dormant**(睡眠状态的). Last **weekday**(平常日) I would **skip**(跳) the noisy main road and **resort**(求助) to a quiet **harbour**(海港) **cafe**(咖啡馆) near my **neighborhood**(邻居), a **public**(公共的) spot open to all, where I could **chat**(闲谈) over a **pint**(品脱) of **creamy**(奶油的) coffee **whilst**(当...时候) watching a **pigeon**(鸽) and a stray **duck**(鸭) **nibble**(半位元组) crumbs by the water. The place was never **pretentious**(自负的), and no **rival**(竞争者) cafe could match it; its **diverse**(多种多样的), **multifarious**(种种的) crowd would **mingle**(混合) freely — a **poet**(诗人) scribbling in **ink**(墨水), an off-duty **meteorologist**(气象学者) reading a weather **catalogue**(目录), and a retired **stevedore**(码头工人) who once loaded a **railroad**(铁路) car with **platinum**(白金) and **pyrite**(矿) ore.

The owner, a **sentimental**(多愁善感的) woman with great **tact**(机敏), kept **attendance**(出席) low so guests could **concentrate**(集中). She told a **tale**(故事) about an ancient **treaty**(条约) signed under **moonlight**(月光), when a **marshal**(元帅) had to **salute**(行礼) a **pharaoh**(法老王)-like ruler and a **mercenary**(唯利是图的) army was ordered, by **sudden**(出乎意料的) **directive**(命令), to **disobey**(不服从) and lay down arms. To **suppress**(镇压) a coming war, both sides reached a **concerted**(商定的) **agreement**(同意); the threat of mutual **extinction**(绝灭) was suddenly **null**(无效力的).

I am no **spy**(间谍), **just**(正好地) a **self**(自我)-taught listener with a quiet **internal**(内部的) compass. Over the years a **cumulative**(累积的) habit of note-taking gave me real **leeway**(活动余地) to wander. I have seen a **helicopter**(直升机) **descend**(下降) onto **land**(陆地) caked with **mud**(泥), watched a **comet**(彗星) streak across the **cosmos**(宇宙), and studied **plankton**(浮游生物) through an **audio-visual**(利用视觉和听觉) lab on a university **campus**(校园). None of it felt **stupid**(愚蠢的) or pretentious; every **tangible**(切实的) detail mattered, and curiosity was the deciding **factor**(因素).

That morning the harbour traffic sat **stationary**(固定的), a market **slump**(暴跌) having idled the docks. A **trumpet**(喇叭) rang out as a sports **rally**(集合) passed; runners completed one more **lap**(一圈), their steady **rhythm**(韵律) broken only by one athlete's minor **injury**(伤害) from a **deflection**(偏斜) off a metal **bar**(棍). A **spike**(穗) in the crowd surged forward like a turning **wheel**(轮), then settled behind a low **hedge**(树篱).

The **handicapped**(有残疾的) veteran beside me, a man whose **liver**(肝) troubles made him avoid anything **alcoholic**(含酒精的), raised his cup as if to **shield**(盾) a memory. He had begun to **wear**(穿着) the same coat for years. The **separation**(分离) of past and present, he said, is the only real **disadvantage**(不利) of growing old. There was no **absurdity**(荒唐) in that; it was the plain truth, hard-won on an **arduous**(艰巨的) road. He would never **hitchhike**(免费搭乘他人便车), never scheme for profit, and refused to let nostalgia **dominate**(在...中占首要地位) his days. Each **cog**(机) of his routine turned with **purpose**(目的), and that, more than money, was what **spread**(铺开) warmth through the room.

## 92. The Oyster Farmer's Trial

My **visit**(访问) to the **western**(西方的) coast began the day a **shipowner**(船主) agreed to **sue**(控告) a rival over a **counter-offer**(还价) he called **dreadful**(可怕的). The dispute was **largely**(主要地) about an **oyster**(牡蛎) bed, a **sizable**(相当大的) **quarry**(采石场) of shells that, since **birth**(出生), had been the **root**(根) of his livelihood. To **examine**(检查) the case, a judge had to **mediate**(仲裁), and I was asked to **learn**(学习) the facts and **dig**(挖) into the records, however **unbearable**(难堪的) the **informal**(非正式的) paperwork seemed. Each **tertiary**(第三的) clause, each **segment**(部分) of every **proceeding**(行动), demanded a **thorough**(彻底的) reading.

The shipowner was a **sturdy**(强健的), **capable**(有本领的) man, **righteous**(正直的) yet **fickle**(变幻无常的), and his **enthusiasm**(热情) could **strike**(罢工vt) you as both **lasting**(持久的) and dreadful at once. He would **catch**(捕捉) the morning tide, **drink**(喝) a mug of strong tea, eat a **slab**(厚平板) of **pudding**(布丁), and **clock**(钟vt) in before the **sunset**(日落) of the previous day had even faded. A **handful**(一把) of workers, **mostly**(几乎全部地) young, would **slack**(松的) off whenever he turned his back, an **idleness**(懒惰) he could not suppress. To **thrash**(痛打) out a routine, he set a strict **mandate**(命令) that would **prohibit**(禁止) lateness; **worse**(更坏), he said, than a **slave**(奴隶)'s chains is a **blunder**(瞎闯) born of plain stupidity.

He explained, with **vividness**(生动), how a **hydraulic**(水力的) **pulley**(滑轮) driven by a small **propellent**(推进的) pump in good **tune**(曲调) could raise oysters from the **muscle**(肌肉)-aching deep. The **requirement**(需要) was teamwork; **collaboration**(协作), he insisted, was **elemental**(基本的), and to **retain**(保持) a crew you must **reward**(奖赏) them, and **vice versa**(反之亦然). **Cheap**(便宜的) pay breeds **envy**(妒忌) and a **consequent**(作为结果的) sense of **inferiority**(劣势), whereas a fair, **sectional**(可组合的) bonus can **inspire**(激励) loyalty. People **misconceive**(误解) the work, giving the wrong **attribution**(属于) to luck; in truth diligence helps a crew **earn**(赚得) and even **transcend**(超越) old limits. He refused the **abortion**(流产) of a plan once begun, and would not **displace**(转移) a loyal hand for an **obsolete**(荒废的) machine.

**Yesterday**(昨天) I learned how the trade had changed over a **millennium**(太平盛世). Methods once thorough are now obsolete; **analogous**(类似的) to how an **apple**(苹果) cart yields to a truck, the old ways **lapse**(小错) and a new **governor**(统治者) of commerce takes the helm. **Exposure**(暴露) to harsh weather can **quiz**(小型考试) even the bravest, like an **infernal**(阴间的) **assault**(袭击) from the sea, and any lapse in care brings ruin. The work is **intensive**(加强的), the **abundance**(丰富) never guaranteed, even when **Jupiter**(丘庇特) shines bright as a far beacon and trade with **Brazil**(巴西) booms.

As the **rosy**(玫瑰红的) dawn rose over the **gutter**(沟) of a quiet street, a **dancer**(舞蹈者) in a clean **collar**(衣领) walked by; a **hen**(母鸡) pecked at scraps, and a **chemist**(化学家), **up**(向上) early, examined a vial. The shipowner tugged his collar and, with a polite nod to a passing **madam**(夫人), returned to the **cover**(覆盖) of his shed to wait for the verdict.

### 93. The Invigilator's Afternoon

Only(仅仅) a fractionally(极少地) trained dean(院长) could foresee(预见) how a single afternoon(下午) would unravel. The plan was to computerize(使计算机化) the exam hall, yet a breakdown(损坏) of the main(主要的) server displeased everyone. The story(故事) is true, though it sounds far(远)-fetched, and properly(适当地) told it should make you glance(扫视n) twice.

I had come(来) to invigilate(看守), a duty I expect(预期) to be dull. On the eve(前夜) of the test, a rapid(快) remittance(汇款) from the secretariat(秘书处) had confirmed my pay, so I felt no envy. Students arrived in a long procession(队伍) and would huddle(拥挤) against a bumpy(颠簸不平的) wind, each carrying an umbrella(伞) against the rain, papers ready to sprawl(四肢伸开的躺卧姿) across the top(顶) of every desk. One blond(白肤金发碧眼的人) boy gripped a pair of scissors(剪刀) he had no legal(法律的) reason to bring; a fussy(爱大惊小怪的) girl clutched a tattered biography(传记) of a poet whose loyalty(忠诚) and patriotism(爱国主义) had won him a strange notoriety(恶名). A toad(蟾蜍) of a man, the proctor, told them to skim(浏览) no notes and to skip nothing on the page. He would utilize(利用) a strict, grammatical(语法上的) script for the rules, biting his(他的) lip(嘴唇) after each line as if to interview(接见) the room with his eyes.

The room was meant to exhilarate(使高兴) the mind, not displease(使不愉快) it. On the wall a faded carving(雕塑) and a school motto(座右铭) in disuse(废止) hung above the boarding(伙食)-house list. Somewhere(某地) a clock ticked. To conclude(结束) the briefing, the dean read out each regulation(规则) in a sound(声音v), justifiable(有理由的) voice, his aim(目的) to guide rather than to scold. He invoked the heroine(女英雄) of an old tale, a near-idol(偶像) whose courage, like a unicorn(独角兽)'s, seemed virtual(实际上的) yet stirring(动人的).

Then the tremor(震动) came. It was a real, faint(微弱的) quake, felt far underground where alluvial(冲积的) soil(泥土) and limestone(石灰石) lie. A male(男性) student's pen began to roll; another, overcome by fatigue(疲劳), gave a tired crow(乌鸦v) of alarm. I had to confirm(证实) no one was hurt. Adverse(不利的) rumor spread of smuggling(走私) and of a make-shift(临时的n) bomb, but I would not vex(使烦恼) the room with panic. A crow flew past the window; a melon(甜瓜) rolled off a desk and would surely fall(跌倒) and split its skin like a torn stitch(缝纫). The dull routine, a killer(杀人者) of nerves, had turned thrilling. The principal, frantic yet refined, came round(圆的prep) on a tram from the far campus to investigate(调查).

No one was liable(有...倾向的) for the gravitation(地心吸力) of events. The civilian(平民) crowd outside, fed false counsel(忠告) by a criminal(犯罪的), nearly knocked down the gate. A herbalist(草药医生) offered ice-cream(冰淇淋) to calm the children; a nightingale-like singer hummed an overture(建议) to soothe them. The cubism(立体主义) on a nearby poster looked grim, its stitched edges torn. When help did come, we found the panic insufficient(不足的) cause for alarm; the danger, we concluded, stemmed therefrom(由此) no real threat. Ultimately, with steady guidance(引导), calm was restored. His report, signed with a careful rivet(铆钉) of ink, called it the ninth(第九) quiet ending to a noisy day, and the clan(部落) of weary staff went home to a deserved rest, the bathroom(浴室) queue at last short, while Saturn(农神) rose pale over the rooftops.

## 94. The Undergraduate's Summer Job

On the **inaugural**(开幕的) **Monday**(星期一) of summer, I took a job at a small **hotel**(旅馆) in **Japan**(日本), a **marvelous**(引起惊异的) old building with a wide **patio**(天井) and a tiled **window**(窗) that would **shine**(照耀) in the morning sun. As an **undergraduate**(大学生) with little money, I could not afford to **starve**(挨饿), so I jumped at the **vacancy**(空缺) the moment an **agent**(代理人) confirmed it. The pay was **equitable**(公平的), the contract was **incorporated**(有限的) into a tidy **document**(公文), and a kindly **sponsorship**(发起) from the owner made the deal **exceedingly**(极端地) fair.

My duties seemed **minor**(较小的) but never let up. I had to **itemize**(分列) the **goods**(货物) in the pantry, **mix**(使混合) batter for **cake**(饼), fry an **egg**(蛋) or boil a **chicken**(鸡肉), and **insert**(插入) fresh flowers into every vase. I learned to **shun**(躲避) shortcuts and to **resist**(抵抗) the urge to skip a task, since any **backlog**(未交付的订货) would only **sicken**(使患病) the schedule and **trouble**(烦恼) the staff. A **restrictive**(限制的) house rule warned that no one should be **oblivious**(遗忘的) to a guest's **need**(需要), and I tried to **honor**(尊敬) it with a calm **countenance**(容貌) and never a **fiery**(火的) temper.

The other **recruit**(招募) was a **naughty**(顽皮的) boy whose **timidity**(胆怯) hid behind loud jokes. He would **shamble**(蹒跚地走) across the lobby pushing a baby's **stroller**(散步者) for a young mother, then **snap**(啪地移动) a photo with a grin. Once he dropped a **pebble**(卵石) into the **gas**(气体) burner as a prank and seemed **seemingly**(外观上) proud of it, an **idiot**(白痴) move that earned him a light **slap**(掌击) of warning from the cook. I had to **remember**(记住) that he was the real **culprit**(犯人), yet I gave him the **consolation**(安慰) of a second chance.

Guests arrived from everywhere. A **deaf**(聋的) **artist**(艺术家) sketched the **arctic**(北极的) light; a scholar of **Islam**(伊斯兰教) discussed **freedom**(自由) and faith in the **vernacular**(本国的) over tea; a singer with the voice of a **nightingale**(夜莺) practiced each **syllable**(音节) beside the **organ**(器官) in the hall. The **amplification**(放大) of her **loudness**(响亮) filled the patio, and people would **nod**(点) and **confer**(协商) in low tones, oblivious to time. We would **still**(静止的) confer **warrant**(正当理由) for late check-ins, a **reciprocal**(相互的) courtesy.

One afternoon a pipe burst, and the **result**(结果) was instant chaos. **Molten**(融化) residue from an old **axle**(轴) had clogged a **cavity**(洞) in the boiler, and a worker had to **excavate**(挖掘) the **filthy**(污秽的) **clay**(粘土) around it. Water rose **heavily**(重重地), so I had to **scoop**(铲子) it out and **instantly**(立即) **divide**(分) the wet towels into a neat **package**(包装) for the laundry. An **off-duty**(不当班的) plumber, watching a **hind**(后面的) leg of his dog twitch in sleep, refused to let the leak **bewilder**(迷惑) him. He said a steady crew should **embody**(体现) calm, never panic. We used a small **calculator**(计算机) to itemize the cost of an **amendment**(修改) to the lease, then ran a **shuttle**(梭) to **import**(进口) spare parts. The **franchise**(特许权) office **bitterly**(苦苦地) disputed the bill, but the manager set a **preset**(预先装置) budget, fed the chickens by the **hive**(蜂房), and ate from his **appetite**(食欲) of patience. By the end my whole **personality**(个性) felt remade, and I would not slap that summer from memory; it had become, on a humble **mat**(席子), a true import to my growing self.

## 95. The Ranch Get-Together

The **deposition**(免职) of fresh **frost**(严寒) on the **broad**(宽的) valley was **reminiscent**(使想起的) of my childhood on a **native**(本地的) **ranch**(大牧场). Last autumn I drove out to a **get-together**(集会) hosted by an **elderly**(过了中年的) **acquaintance**(认识), a **distinguished**(尊贵的) and **decent**(正当的) rancher whose **generosity**(慷慨) was as **sincere**(真挚的) as it was famous. He had sent a **proper**(适合的) invitation, signed with a flowing **signature**(签名), and I could **predict**(预言) the day would be a **happy**(快乐的) one as I took the **approach**(接近) road past the **dock**(船坞) and the old **rail**(栏杆) line.

The ranch was a hive of honest work. At dawn the **livestock**(家畜) would stir, and a hired **retailer**(零售商) of feed arrived to **mount**(登上) a delivery, his truck **rough**(不平的) on the **uneven**(不平坦的), bumpy track. I watched a **worm**(虫) wriggle in the **ripe**(熟的) soil and a green **sprout**(发芽) **pry**(探查) its way up through a **chunk**(大块) of softened earth. The rancher would **pore**(毛孔) over a seed catalogue, deciding which **plant**(植物) to grow, and he kept an old **gun**(枪) by the door against coyotes. He liked **detailed**(详细的) **statistics**(统计); he would **argue**(不同意), with a **sensible**(明智的) **humor**(幽默), that the **salability**(适销性) of his beef was a **relatively**(相对地) steady, if **middling**(中等的), business, dependent on the **duration**(持久) of good weather and on a fair **rebate**(回扣) from the market. To **possess**(占有) such land, he said, demanded that one **check**(支票) every figure and **beware**(当心) of every **faulty**(有错误的) calculation.

Inside, the kitchen smelled of **soap**(肥皂) and fresh bread. A **ceramic**(陶瓷的) bowl held a **soluble**(可溶的) powder for the **meringue**(蛋白与糖的混合物) his niece was beating into a happy froth. We ate a **hotdog**(热狗) each, then went to **wash**(洗) up. An **Irish**(爱尔兰人) guest in a thick **sweater**(厚运动衫) told us, with rough good cheer, of an **American**(美洲的) **pilgrim**(香客) whose pry into family records had uncovered an **heiress**(女继承人) and a long-lost **portrait**(肖像). An **onlooker**(旁观者), a quiet **intellect**(理智), gave an **interesting**(有趣的) **recital**(朗诵) of a poem whose **intonation**(语调) and **inclination**(倾向) toward melancholy made us all **shrug**(耸肩) and smile.

Not everything was easy. A **nasty**(令人讨厌的) **bug**(臭虫) had bitten the herd, and the **gene**(遗传) pool, the rancher feared, had grown too thin; the **radium**(镭)-bright sun of the **equator**(赤道) seemed to mock his **cumbersome**(讨厌的), **demanding**(对人要求严格的) routine. He had a **scheme**(安排) to **disguise**(假扮) the loss and to redistribute the **strong**(强壮的) calves, but he would **forbid**(禁止) any plan that proved immoral. **Regretfully**(遗憾地), a **constraint**(强迫) on water put real **privacy**(隐私) and rest out of reach.

We knocked off at dusk, and a sudden **knock**(敲) at the door announced a late guest. My **playmate**(游伴) from years past, now a **selfish**(自私的) but charming man, liked to **shuffle**(拖脚走) a deck of cards by the **tile**(瓦片) stove. A **thinner**(稀释剂), **aching**(疼痛的) cold crept in, and I felt a pang of **carelessness**(粗心) for having stayed so long. Yet the **social**(社会的) warmth, granted **unconditionally**(无条件地), was a fine **hobby**(业余爱好) of the heart, and I would **approve**(赞成) of such a gathering again, without **trial**(试验) or doubt.

## 96. A Canadian Family Reunion

Every year **during**(在...期间) the long **winding**(卷绕着的线a) road home for **Thanksgiving Day**(感恩节), our **homely**(家庭的) **Canadian**(加拿大的) family would gather in a rented farmhouse to celebrate a **festival**(节日) of food and memory. The **rental**(租借的) was **plain**(明白的) but warm, and the **key**(钥匙) to the front door hung from a faded ribbon **like**(喜欢prep) a small **private**(私人的) treasure. I cannot **bear**(熊) to miss **it**(它); the **anticipation**(预期) alone could **enchant**(迷住) me for weeks.

My grandmother, a proud **lady**(女士) whose **marriage**(结婚) had lasted fifty years, ruled the kitchen with quiet **gravity**(重力). She would **govern**(统治) the stove, **harden**(变硬) the toffee, and **puff**(一阵) flour across a tray as she rolled the **filling**(充填物) for the pies. **Namely**(即), she made three: pumpkin, apple, and a **Danish**(丹麦人) pastry she had learned to bake **abroad**(到国外). She liked to **cite**(引用) an old **written**(写作的) recipe, an heirloom whose ink had begun to fade, and she would not **modify**(修改) it for **anything**(任何东西), not even to cut a single **calorie**(卡). To **loosen**(解开) the dough she added cream, and the rich, **fabulous**(寓言中的) smell could **fascinate**(使神魂颠倒) any child in the house.

My uncle, a **reticent**(沉默寡言的) man, worked in **telecommunication**(电讯) and could explain any **system**(系统) of **automation**(自动), from a **barrel**(圆桶)-shaped engine to the **machinery**(机器) that ran the local **ministry**(部) of transport. He spoke of **progress**(进步) with **pride**(自豪), citing **protectionism**(贸易保护主义) and **indemnity**(保证物) clauses as if they were poetry. He could even explain each **abbreviation**(缩略语) on a circuit board **entirely**(完全地) from memory, pausing only to play a slow tune on the upright **piano**(钢琴). He once showed me an **odometer**(<美>里程表) he had taken from a **deceased**(已死的) neighbor's car, hoping to **reclaim**(要回) and restore it, and a **coupon**(息票) book, a **monthly**(每月的ad) rebate scheme, that he kept like a **fossil**(化石) of thriftier days. He never let his curiosity **falter**(支吾地说).

After dinner we played games. A **comic**(滑稽的) cousin would mimic a **panther**(豹) creeping, then a **frog**(蛙) leaping, while the youngest cradled an **ivory**(象牙) chess piece like a **sled**(雪橇)-bound toy. We held a **contest**(争夺) of riddles; the prize was a **globe**(球体) and a worn **map**(地图) of **Rome**(罗马). I cannot **disentangle**(解脱) one memory from another, for they all puff together like smoke.

Not every year was easy. One winter **influenza**(流行性感冒), a **sharp**(锋利的) **respiratory**(呼吸的) illness, left two of us **sick**(有病的) and **mournful**(悲悼的), and a **continental**(大陆的) cold snap froze the **tar**(柏油) on the road. An **ominous**(不祥的) **telephone**(电话) call once warned of a **smuggler**(走私者) caught at the border, an **immoral**(不道德的) man whose **retiral**(复审) in **court**(法院) was front-page news; the case, **undeniable**(不可否认的) in its detail, had to be settled by a fair **measure**(量度) of law. We would **mail**(邮件v) a card to the **lonesome**(寂寞的), the **rose**(玫瑰)-cheeked **nursery**(托儿所) children, and to relatives who could not travel.

**Finally**(最后), **plumb**(铅锤) tired and happy, we would **throw**(扔) the last logs on the fire with a thick **glove**(手套) to guard our hands. An **aquatic**(水的) calm settled, as if the whole globe had paused in **motion**(运动). Like a slow, steady puff of breath, the evening closed; it was **available**(可获得的) to us only once a year, **etc.**(等等), yet it never lost its **meaning**(意思), and the **reproach**(责备) of distance melted away.

## 97. The Old Carpenter's Workshop

I(我) still remember the **hubbub**(吵闹声) of my grandfather's **carpentry**(木工工作) shop, a place that could **muffle**(裹住) the noise of the **windy**(多风的) street and replace it with the steady **flow**(流) of honest work. As a boy of **seventeen**(十七) I would **bike**(自行车) there after school, **hungry**(饥饿的) for the **warmth**(暖和) and **serenity**(安详) of the **four**(四pron) cluttered walls. He kept the place in **optimal**(最佳的) order, every chisel and saw on **par**(原价相等) with the next, every **accessory**(同谋者) in its proper **category**(种类). An old **aphorism**(格言) hung above the door, **wrought**(work的过去式) in iron: a **steadfast**(坚定的) hand and a **logical**(逻辑的) mind together **denote**(是...的符号) a true craftsman.

Grandfather was a **renowned**(有名的) **weaver**(织布工) of wood, though he was **color-blind**(色盲的) and could not always trust his eyes. He would **consult**(请教) a worn manual, **calculate**(计算) each angle, and **adhere**(粘着) to a plan that was always **definitive**(可靠的). To **prepare**(准备) a fresh board he would measure twice, his **attention**(注意) never wavering. I watched, in something close to **ecstasy**(狂喜), as a plain plank was transformed **downwards**(向下) from rough timber into a thing of beauty, and the **joy**(欢乐) of it was **inextricable**(无法解脱的) from my earliest **memory**(记忆).

He disliked **drudgery**(苦差事) for its own sake, yet he refused to **relinquish**(放弃) patience. 'Luck(运气) is **unavoidable**(不可避免的),' he would say, 'but you cannot **bait**(饵) it; you must earn it.' He had no **intention**(意图) to **deceive**(欺骗) a customer, and any **flimsy**(易坏的) or **unsuitable**(不合适的) job he would tear apart and begin again. He never showed **indifference**(冷淡) to a flaw. A single misaligned **rib**(肋骨) of a chair could cause **havoc**(大破坏) to the whole frame, and he refused to **conform**(符合) to shoddy taste merely to win **patronage**(赞助).

The shop sold many things. A **king**(君主) of customers, a wealthy man, once placed an **invitation**(邀请) to build a cabinet adorned with carved leaves, a **cardinal**(主要的) piece for his hall. Grandfather wrought it so the joints were perfectly **congruent**(适合的), then sent me on an **errand**(差使) to **inform**(通知) the buyer. The man's **delight**(快乐) was a small **victory**(胜利), an **advantage**(优点) of good name that money could not buy.

Over the years a quiet **disintegration**(分散) set in. His old **washing-machine**(洗衣机) broke; a leak in the **roof**(屋顶) let **evaporation**(蒸发) rot a beam; the **displacement**(移置) of the trade by automation made the **awkward**(难使用的) future hard to **translate**(翻译) into hope. Yet he remained **courageous**(勇敢的). He would not **swerve**(突然转向) from his **quest**(寻找), nor **lock**(锁v) the door on his calling. A **manifold**(复印本) of small **mushroom**(蘑菇)-like worries could **occur**(发生), but he met each with an **easy**(容易的) grace.

I am forever **indebted**(感激的) to him. When a child would **toddle**(东倒西歪地走) in and a dog would **bark**(树皮) and **paw**(爪) at a **quart**(夸脱) pail, he would smile, **dose**(一剂) out a sweet, and **adorn**(装饰) the moment with a story. His shop was a kind of **forum**(论坛), a place of **wholesome**(健康的) talk where every **outlook**(景色) met. He had a clear **conception**(概念) of craft, and he would **use**(使) no shortcut; a clumsy joint, **notably**(尤其), could **deflate**(收缩) his pride faster than a snapped **sword**(剑). He gave my **mental**(精神的) world its shape, and his **holding**(支持) of one **hectare**(公顷) of dignity, **mechanical**(机械的) and human at once, taught me what it means to be a **friend**(朋友) to one's own work.

## 98. The Provincial Boxer

It is **unlikely**(未必的) that anyone in our **provincial**(省级的) town will forget the **hard-working**(勤劳的) **boxer**(拳击运动员) who once trained behind the old **cathedral**(总教堂). He was **born**(出生的) in a **solitary**(独居的) **brick**(砖块) house near the **airport**(机场), the son of a **gardener**(园丁), and **from**(从) an early age he had an **absolute**(绝对的), **heartfelt**(衷心的) **motive**(动机): to escape the **dropout**(中途退出者)'s fate and make something **terrific**(可怕的) of his life. His **physique**(体格) was **ungainly**(难看的) at first, **chiefly**(多半) because a childhood **surgery**(外科) had left one shoulder stiff, but he learned to **pronounce**(发...的音) each ambition aloud, dwelling on every **vowel**(元音) as if the very sound were a **referent**(指示物) for his dream, a quiet creed of **humanism**(人道主义) that put human effort above all. Years of **experience**(经验), stacked one upon the next like a tall **stack**(堆) of worn gloves, would **standardize**(使与标准比较) his own resolve.

He would **bypass**(迂回的旁道) the noisy **cafeteria**(自助食堂) and ride his **bicycle**(自行车vi) past the **zebra**(斑马) crossing to a humble gym above a **kitchen**(厨房) that always smelled of **butter**(黄油) and toast. There he would **devote**(把...奉献给) whole afternoons to the **chase**(追逐) of skill, working a single **tactic**(策略) until it ran **smoothly**(光滑地). A **bossy**(好发号施令的) old coach, a former **commissioner**(委员) of the regional league, did not spare the **rebuke**(指责); his harsh words could **seize**(抓住) a man's pride, yet they were never pure **cruelty**(残酷). 'Comply(遵照) with the **protocol**(礼仪),' he would **say**(说), 'or **simply**(简单地) leave.'

The coach loved to elaborate. His **elaboration**(详尽阐述) on footwork was a kind of **verse**(韵文), and he could **compile**(编辑) a whole **canon**(规范) of drills from memory. He taught the boy to **understand**(懂) each **facet**(面) of the ring, to **contrast**(使对比) a clumsy lunge with a clean one, and to **ascertain**(查明) an opponent's weakness before the first **horn**(角). 'Hatred(憎恨) has no place here,' he said. 'Neutrality(中立) of mind, and a **fruitful**(多产的) patience, will **produce**(生产) the win.' It was a **fallacy**(谬误), he insisted, that rage alone could **shoot**(发射) a man to victory; that was an **awful**(可怕的) and **prohibitive**(禁止的) lie.

Life outside the gym was harder. **Inflation**(膨胀) had made even **postage**(邮费) dear, and the cost of clean **linen**(亚麻布) and good **fabric**(织物) for his robe was nearly prohibitive. A provincial **reporter**(报告人), eager for an **issue**(分发) to fill the page, once wrote a **doubtful**(怀疑的) piece that seemed to **trespass**(过失) on his privacy, citing a faked **facsimile**(摹写) of a contract. The boy felt **mean**(吝啬的) and **blue**(蓝色的) for a day, then would **refresh**(精神振作) his focus and let the slight pass like a **breeze**(微风).

On **Boxing-Day**(节礼日), the **eleven**(十一pron)-year mark of his career and his eleventh fight, he stepped onto the **stage**(舞台). The hall, thick with **smog**(烟雾) from outside and the heat of the crowd, would **hinge**(铰链) on a single round. He would not **hurl**(猛掷) wild blows; he moved in a calm **orbit**(天体轨道), a **compound**(混合物) of speed and grace, until the **executive**(总经理) judges, with absolute fairness, named him the winner. A **typhoon**(台风) of cheers rose. **Royalty**(皇家) itself, they joked, would envy such **comfort**(舒适) and delight. He sipped a cold **beverage**(饮料), **qualify**(具有资格) at last for the national stage, and offered a quiet **specimen**(标本) of thanks, a **delicacy**(精致) of feeling that no **isolation**(隔离) or fame could ever take from him.

## 99. The Inventor of Iceland

How(怎样) a refined(精炼的) governess(女家庭教师) from Iceland(冰岛) came to hold a copyright(版权) on a super(极好的) wireless(不用电线的) generator(发电机) is a tale worth the daily grind(磨) of telling. Her name, hereinafter(以下) the Inventor, was known across society(社会) for her analytical(分析的) mind and her steady, almost ethereal(轻的) calm. She never let a single germ(微生物) of doubt grind her down. Each daytime(白天) she would scramble(爬) up a massive(大而重的) hill at a brisk pace(步), trot(小跑) home, and abide(遵守) by a strict budget(预算), principally(主要) to fund her secret(秘密的) undertaking(任务).

The core(果核) of her work was a translucent(半透明的) filament(细丝) that, when fed a dual(双的) current, could weld(焊接) itself to a stainless(纯洁的) bracket(括号) and glow with a light pliable(易曲折的) enough to bend. She had to calibrate(校准) it with great detail(细节), adapt(使适应) the design again and again, and counterbalance(使平均) the inefficiency(无效力) of the early models. A frantic(狂乱的) period(时期) followed; she would grunt(作呼噜声) over the equations, paint(油漆) diagrams across the wall, and treat(对待) each failure as a lesson(课) rather than a defeat. Her deep understanding(理解) of physics made safety her first priority(先).

Her sister(姐), a fisherman(渔夫)'s wife(妻子), and her young niece(侄女) helped without complaint. They would canvass(游说) the village for parts, declare(宣告) every honest cost, and abide by a managerial(管理的) discipline that no thief(贼) or careless hand could spoil. The Inventor took the initiative(创始的) to elect(选举) a small board, responsible(应负责的) and virtuous(善良的), to guard against piracy(海盗行为) of her idea. A brutal(野蛮的) controversy(争论) soon arose: a rival in America(美洲), negligent(粗心大意的) of all ethics, tried to redistribute(重新分配) her plans under a false name. The undermentioned(下述的) clause of her contract, however, gave her the affirmative(肯定的) right to fight back.

The project would ultimately(最终) culminate(达到顶点) on a quiet evening when Venus(维纳斯) hung bright in the sky. With a single clap(拍手) she switched on the generator; a hose(输水软管) of coolant hissed, and the device hummed toward infinity(大量). Her champion(冠军) supporters cheered. The light, steadily(稳定地) brightening, seemed to coincide(恰好相合) with the dawn of something new. It was not a missile(导弹) of war but an inducement(诱导) to peace, a thing of permanence(永久) rather than spectacle.

That night she ate a simple meal of beef(牛肉) and a vitamin(维生素) tonic, then arranged a bouquet(花束) on the windowsill in remembrance(记得) of her late mother. A doctor(医生) friend rode in on the last tram(有轨电车) to say hello(英喂) and to tackle(处理) a small repair. She would not strew(散播) her success across the headlines; instead she set a modest target(目标), accept(接受) the praise eastward(向东的) toward the harbour, and let a rhyme(韵) of gratitude settle in her heart. The dye(染料) of her ambition had set; her livelihood(生活), built on the firm constitution(构成) of patience, was finally her own.

## 100. The Charity Bazaar

The annual **charity**(赈济款) **bazaar**(集市) in our **oriental**(东方的) seaside town was a **genial**(亲切的), **energetic**(精力旺盛的) affair, and this year it carried a special weight of **commemoration**(纪念). We held it in remembrance of a beloved **missionary**(教会的) who had spent her life helping the **homeless**(无家可归的), and the **preparation**(准备) alone took months. **Without**(无) her, the work would have been **infinitely**(无限地) harder, and her **introduction**(介绍) of small kindnesses had, **over**(在上方) the years, helped to **fortify**(设防于) the whole community.

The square was a **paradise**(天国) of color. Stalls lined every **wall**(墙), each one **suitable**(合适的) for a different trade. One booth sold **tulip**(郁金香) bulbs and seeds; a **second**(第二) offered an **up-to-date**(现代化的) **pictorial**(画报) catalogue printed by a **duty-free**(免税的) importer. An elderly tailor had hauled out his old **sewing-machine**(缝纫机) and a battered **typewriter**(打字机), and beside him a clerk made **photostatic**(静电复印的) copies for a **fractional**(零碎的) fee. A vendor of cameras let children peer through one **camera**(照相机)'s clean **lens**(透镜), while a fishmonger laid out a fresh **halibut**(大比目鱼) on ice. I bought a plain **shirt**(衬衫) and an **innocuous**(无害的) little **ashtray**(烟灰缸) as a gift.

The day was not without its **dilemma**(进退两难的局面). A **frequent**(时常发生的) visitor, a man once nearly **bankrupt**(破产的), arrived **homesick**(思乡的) and weary; his **confidence**(信任) had grown **inferior**(劣质的) to his old **vigor**(活动), and he seemed ready to **doze**(瞌睡) in a corner rather than join the fun. We urged him, **urgently**(紧急地) but gently, to **cope**(竞争) and to **receive**(收到) the warmth of the crowd. Slowly his **grit**(粗砂) returned. He helped **irrigate**(灌溉) the flower beds, carried a child **piggyback**(骑在背肩上的) through the **laughter**(笑), and would **clench**(咬紧) his fists in a **gesture**(姿势) of renewed **greatness**(伟大).

There were games of every **figure**(体形). A **naval**(海军的) veteran ran a ring-toss; a strong-arm **competition**(比赛) tested who could **combat**(战斗) fatigue the longest, the **championship**(锦标) decided by a single **concurrent**(同时发生的) throw. Energy seemed to **swell**(使膨胀) and **reel**(卷) through the square. Now and then a **weird**(怪异的) hush would **halt**(暂停) the noise as a **melody**(旋律) drifted from a **fan**(扇子)-cooled bandstand, only for the din to **activate**(使活动) again like a **capillary**(毛细管) catching the tide.

Profits would **fund**(资金) a clinic. A doctor explained, with quiet **piety**(虔诚), how a **scarce**(缺乏的) **medication**(药物治疗), mixed with **glycerin**(甘油), could keep a wound from turning septic, and how iron in the blood could **oxidize**(氧化) and **darken**(变黑) if a patient went untreated. He cited one **instance**(例子) of a sailor whose arm, crushed by a falling **shaft**(矛), had healed only after a long **confinement**(限制) in bed, the daily **irritation**(刺激) of the dressings a small price for survival. An **injure**(损害) to the body, he said, must be met second by second, **irrespective**(不考虑的) of cost, lest a small hurt swell into a **devastating**(破坏性的) **recurrence**(再发生) that could **devastate**(毁坏) a family. The **effectiveness**(有效) of early care was, he insisted, **appreciably**(相当大地) greater.

By **night**(夜间), the lamps glowed at their **peak**(山顶) over the **edge**(边) of the harbour. A child fell **asleep**(睡觉) on a **bookcase**(书橱) bench near a **gear**(齿轮的)-driven music box; a peak of joy settled over us all. There had been no **burial**(葬) of hope here, only its revival. The **product**(产品) of our labor was **nought**(无) less than belonging, and as people drifted home **around**(在...周围) the quiet streets, no one needed to **apologize**(道歉) for a single tear of gratitude.